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TAOIST YOGA FOR WOMEN

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Foreword for English edition

This book is dedicated to a subject which is very hard to discuss in any language other than Chinese. Taoism, the ancient art of alchemy and inner cultivation had its genesis in China. The hieroglyphics and ancient pictograms of Chinese Language themselves embody alchemical expression. It is a language which turns things from one side to another, allowing one to grasp the meaning, by look and feel, from different angles. This is the major reason why any discussion about Taoist Yoga or Taoist Alchemy cannot be pursued using the terms we are used to.

For the uninitiated woman, Ancient Taoist poems offer some insight and are generally a good introduction to the concepts of Taoist Alchemy. It's the metaphorical, soft and flowing forms of language that may allow us to feel the inner meaning and content of Taoist practices. By attempting to transfer the explanations of principles of alchemical work into common mainstream language, the meaning and definitions will become flat.

Generally speaking this book is dedicated to one concept – the preparation of women's mind, body and spirit as a first step on the road towards alchemical transformation and development. We will focus on the preparation, not the transformation itself, paying particular attention to the differences of the female approach to the

application of these practices. This is in contrast to the vast majority of books, which are in the main, directed towards to men.

You will find many things are repeated, the purpose being to assist women to define and understand the underlying conception of their practice. In addition, the English language has a very specific way of expressing Chinese ideas and concepts. That is why you might sometimes have a feeling of 'drowning' in the flow of information. The only thing to do is to allow it to fill you, by immersing yourself in it.

It is not necessary to read it from the beginning to the very end at once. Rather it may become a manual, which you open only when you feel a need to do so. Today, you might want to find something out about the Immortal Sisters, tomorrow you will open a chapter about Tao Yin and next week discover more about the practice during menstruation. The connections between the parts of this book are not linear.

In this edition we used a traditional Mainland Chinese system of transliteration called Pinyin. According to this system the word 'Tao', for instance, should be spelled as 'Dao', but considering the popular acceptance of 'Tao', this spelling was retained.

We hope you find fulfilment in the reading of this book and wish you the best of luck on your way to acquiring and mastering this serious discipline – the Art of Internal Alchemical Transformation.

Editors.

PART ONE

Introduction

This book is a continuation in a series of books on the «Thirty two rotations of the crucible». It is dedicated to Taoist alchemical practices. In this book we will examine the specificity of alchemical practices for women in more depth. We will pay special attention to the preparation for these practices, which are a prerequisite for our work today.

Many publications exist that are concerned with Taoist traditions, with their numbers increasing each year. However, the topic of specific female practices within the Taoist tradition is examined and dealt with meticulously for the first time in this book. Women, interested in internal Taoist practices, have had to subject themselves for far too long now to exercises designed uniquely for men.

Besides, most women would not have had access to original sources of information which would describe the particularity of female practices - even in coded and metaphorical forms.

Such a deliberate misinformation ultimately cannot prohibit women from self-realisation, but it creates a situation requiring much self-adjustment. In order for a knowledge to become realised as an instrument, it must first be tuned, followed by an accurate method of application. This work must have a proper foundation.

The purpose of this book is to provide you with hitherto inaccessible information, to boost and to facilitate your journey towards self-development. That's why this current work is not being published separately, but as part of a series, dedicated to Taoist traditions as a whole. As more information becomes available we will endeavour to present this to you.

The information offered demonstrates an alternate perspective in relation to Taoist practices and to female existence. Our intent is to show you how to use what women already have, in order to move on, and begin the journey towards the discovery of your internal you through self-transformation.

Women and Tao

When we seriously consider women's involvement in the development of any internal doctrine we hit a dead end. One of the reasons for this is that today it has become very difficult to adequately fathom and appreciate the experiences of women from the past. Undoubtedly, the matrilineal formation and development of any specific teaching, depends on the collective female consciousness, and the vigour of each woman's participation. However, to date these teachings have either not reached us at all or if they have, we have received them in an encoded or distorted form. Today's culmination of external destructive influences has had such an effect on us that we can now only encounter echoes of what was actually practised by women in the past. Therefore, we face difficulties in finding and applying these intricate and complex techniques.

As an example, the experiences of women of ancient South

America can be regarded as part of this lost knowledge. It also must be remembered that it is impossible to examine such intangible knowledge, since its weave is based on innate understandings, rather than on taught concepts. Nowadays we are accustomed to receiving information that has been structured, examined and methodically worked through by someone else for us to use. As it is unstructured, we therefore cannot interpret or apply it logically in its original form today. The best way to learn this is simply to experience the movements.

When the flow of transmission of knowledge was interrupted between women, and as such weakened from generation to generation, the opposite male lore automatically could permeate the flow. As a consequence the male flow of knowledge was strengthened. The result of this development was that those few women who perceived the imbalance were unable to recover the original concept. This female knowledge therefore cannot possibly reach us in its original form.

As the patriarchal way assumed and reapplied this information, the female system began to retreat, and to separate itself from its origin. The female way was not clearly considered in this process at all, but was used as a stepping stone for the development of the male way. The unique nature of the woman was unfortunately only partially considered in this process of amalgamation. Yet at times outstanding women appeared who experienced difficulties, not only in being themselves, but also in utilising their characteristically inborn qualities without suppressing them.

Although the female nature is not perfect, yet despite demonstrated loyalty in developing her unique way, this cannot be the model for our greater development. The larger part of both Eastern and Western worldviews are precisely in accord with this outlook.

Why then should we try to use something as a model that, according to definition, can not move, and should not move?

Despite the prevailing patriarchal influence in the formative period, Taoism blends both the male and female aspects in a fluid way. These are not only inseparable aspects of it, but also represent its foundation. The female aspect is simply not obvious, it is hidden for many reasons. Before its formation as a system Taoism was rooted in Shamanism, which combined the observation of natural processes and principles with a mystical life. This combination emulates the same unstructured and truly elementary character of female development.

Today some of the investigators of Taoism define it as 'the feminine nutriment', or as a product of the female principle of cultivation and sustenance. At times it was even in opposition to Confucianism, with its doctrine of «masculine rationality and authoritarianism». Indeed, when Taoism began to increase its influence and develop as a system, everything that gave it structure and growth reflected a yang aspect. A yin aspect was the basis of this process, keeping and retaining everything that has evolved.

The foundation of Taoism, based on natural principles and laws, (grounded in nature itself), ensured its cultivation and growth, and formed what is known as Taoist Alchemy. (See «*The Alchemy of Tai Ji*»). The alchemical components of Taoist teachings were assembled during the whole period of its formation. We must note that practices were mainly the same for both men and women. Slight variations were undoubtedly considered. The basis of the Yin Methodology or Female Alchemy began to form within the Taoist teaching tradition between the 3rd-4th centuries and did not differ from the alchemical

method designed for men. The differences were found in the preparatory work. Without delving into an historical foundation, we must however draw attention to some important factors that are necessary background information for beginners. On the other hand these must serve as indicators for the dynamics of the process of development for present day people. This has urged us to find a new approach.

Our female ancestors, without any doubt, had different living conditions. This is particularly valid for the purpose of our present inquiry in terms of movement and development. One must take this into account if one wants to familiarise oneself with the classical traditions of Taoist practices from existing texts. Women did not leave vast amounts of written knowledge behind in volumes of alchemical works. There are only a few exceptions in the few poetical treatises, containing metaphorical descriptions of various states and levels of the alchemical process and it may be difficult for us to understand and value most of these texts today. This has happened especially because of the considerable distortion that occurred in the translations from ancient Chinese into other languages. The real meanings have been passed on through direct experience and not by description. This was the way of teaching in the past where women directly passed on their knowledge to each other.

Taoist treatise refer to knowledge as a considerable force, although that force was never considered to be real knowledge. This was sometimes manifested in the juxtaposition between men and women. Sometimes wives spontaneously and silently were touched by Taoist knowledge, while their husbands were looking for power, thinking that they were on the path to comprehend the Tao.

There are a considerable number of stories about husbands who, while searching for power and immortality, did not notice their wives becoming practitioners of Tao. One of these women became a recluse in the mountains, leaving her husband behind, because over a long period of time he disregarded her wise counsel. When he finally came looking for her, she flew into the clouds leaving him with only a pair of boots.

Another story is about a woman, who secretly became a disciple of *Fan Yunqiao*, a well-known female Taoist practitioner from the 4th century AD. She met her unexpectedly, and after realising the Tao, she could appear and disappear at will. Her husband was furious each time his wife suddenly disappeared. With the help of the local authority, he hid her in a prison cell, because he did not understand the nature of her power. She continued her practices in her confinement, and soon afterwards realised the art of full transformation. She flew out of the window, leaving only her shoes in front of her bewildered husband.

Of course, there were also cases of the other way round when husbands introduced their wives to practices they followed. *Sun Bu-er* was one of the most famous Taoist women. She is considered to be a founder of the alchemical sciences for women, because of her poetry and secret writings dedicated to the art of inner alchemy. She and her husband met master *Wang Chze* and became his disciples. Many well-known practitioners of the past were initiated by the Taoist masters, masters who did not make distinctions between men and women and who transferred their knowledge to those who were ready to perceive it.

In general not so many women transmitted their experience to others. Often they simply left the worldly life behind, disappearing from those around them. Only those travelling in the mountains could count on an accidental meeting with them. According to legend, the immortal sisters disappeared when their time came. They flew into the clouds and afterwards, rarely appeared on earth. Often they are represented by the crane (the symbol of the immortals), or the deer, which accompanied them while on earth.

The tradition of knowledge transferral from the female teacher to the student took place at the time when the alchemical teaching was founded. The appropriation of a Taoist name, accompanied by a change of lineage, took place later in the monasteries.

The Immortal Sisters

One of the first references to women in the context of Taoist teachings is connected with the two female councillors of the Yellow Emperor, *Huang Di*. They taught him the secrets of sexual encounters and magic. *Huang Di*, a semi mystical figure from the middle of the 3rd millennium BC is considered to be one of the founders of Taoist teachings. His treatise equal those of *Lao Tzu*'s «Tao Te Ching». Two men were the councillors and the teachers on two other disciplines: Medicine and the Art of Power and Longevity. It was natural that women had the knowledge of magic and sexual interaction - aspects their nature is best at.

The wisdom and mystical power of the councillors of *Huang Di* were connected with mother earth, and the power of giving birth. These women possessed a knowledge of the human body and energy,

and leant on the natural laws of interaction between the energies of yin and yang. This interaction was representative of the internal worlds of men and women within their surroundings, and it was this understanding that enabled them to use symbols, talismans and rituals. Ancient descriptions exist of the knowledge and ability of women who were able to manifest inconceivable forces.

In one of the Chinese territories, long before the leadership of *Huang Di*, there is a story of a shaman woman who was the leader of one of the tribes. It is told that for the well-being of her tribe, she "travelled in the skies with five coloured stones", symbolically representing her possession of the five powers or primary elements. Her work on this journey helped her to remove the disorders, disturbances, sickness and bad harvest her people were suffering.

The most popular legendary woman in ancient Chinese mythology is the Queen Mother of the West. She is *Hsi Wang Mu*, or the *Golden Mother of the Turtle's Pedestal*, in whose vision all women who practice Tao are present. As a rule, when she comes to transfer her knowledge to those who are ready for it, her appearance in this ordinary world are not only experienced but also described. On her travels she is often accompanied by the Mistress of the Golden Foundation, who was also a patroness of Taoist practitioners. Their names

reflect what we define as an aspect of female Taoism, being the presence of a foundation.

This quality of this presence can effectively be used by women for further development, and is necessary for the stability of the system as a whole. It is the ability of women to form this foundation, that is the basis of what they can lean on during the process of its cultivation. In turn this fundament, consists of that which strengthens and gathers. It is the yin component of alchemy. We will discuss this concept later, but now let's just note that it is women from the original tradition of internal Taoism, who are connected to that which prepares, forms and strengthens. While it is men who are connected to that which grows and develops.

The first references to the immortal sisters come from ordinary people's descriptions of their encounters with the *Queen Mother of the West*. These encounters took place from the 10 Century BC onwards, in the Kunlun mountains. Legends tell of earthly immortals who could transform their bodies and energies and so were able to govern the process of their existence. The immortal sisters appeared in the Imperial Gardens as well as in the ordinary settlements, and their participation in the lives of ordinary people led to wondrous things. One of the sisters, whose name remains unknown, appeared over a hundred-year period around the time of the 4th Century AD. She was referred to as «*the Tea Elder*», because she always carried a basket with tea leaves.

People purchased tea from her from the early morning, till the evening, yet her basket always remained full. Her appearance was always the same. She looked like a seventy year old woman to those who saw her, yet her walk was firm, her glance and hearing sharp,

and her hair black and shiny. Her appearances were really miraculous for people of many generations which caused fear in the rulers of this particular province. One day when they tried to catch her in order to put her in prison, she simply flew away with her basket. In general, to avoid unwanted contacts, the immortal sisters very often just flew away.

In the 11th Century, *He Xiangu* was the only woman living in a group of recluses, known as the Eight Immortals, the first of whom was initiated by the immortal Taoists in the 2nd Century BC. *Lu Dongbin* joined him in the 8th Century, and it was he who passed on the peach of immortality to *He Xiengu*. Because of her ascetic way of life she had already reached such lightness that she could fly over the mountaintops.

As earthly creatures women, are transformers and keepers of its energies. When a woman can rise above the energy of the earth's gravity, she is indeed an exponent of real transformation. Even regarding this phenomenon as a metaphor, it cannot be denied that the Taoist immortal sisters had the knowledge to change their nature. *He Xiengu* is usually portrayed with the magical mushroom, and a lotus in her hand. A large number of male Taoists practitioners in China left descriptions of their experiences. It was therefore often simpler for them to describe the incredible powers and abilities of women by referring to them as spirits, angels and goddesses. The

idea that such women were messengers from other worlds or dimensions was quite widely spread, as these special women never advertised their extraordinary abilities. Unexpectedly those around them discovered that these women were followers of Tao, as miraculous events often occurred as they were departing this mortal world. It also happened that sometimes these women left the world, even if it was not their original intention to do so.

Cheng Wei, a military minister during the Han Dynasty, was trying to practice the alchemy known as, «*The Art of the White and the Yellow*», or «*The Art of the Silvery and Golden*». Like other men of his time, he was unaware his wife had become a Taoist follower, who had realised «contact with the spirit world and transformation». Her secret was only revealed when she came into her husband's workshop while he was preparing mercury for an alchemical experiment. She placed something into the vessel, and the mercury immediately turned into gold. «The Tao is inside you, but you never told me, why is that?» he asked her, and she replied: «In order to realise it, make it your destiny». *Cheng Wei* observed her for a long time, demanding her to pass her knowledge on to him. In the end, when he threatened her physically, she told him: «To pass on the knowledge of the Tao is impossible if one is not ready to receive it», and with these words she vanished. In this case the gold was given to him as a test for his inner essence to manifest itself.

On the whole women of those times were not taken to be potential disciples. They were not considered capable of consciously understanding the Taoist teachings, or of practising the internal art, by working through their inner essence, in order to realise the meaning of transformation. In those days nevertheless, women whose

destiny was determined by Heaven, were more plentiful than in comparison to later generations. Indeed they realised the Tao, but not by means of a structured conscious practice, they did it rather through an extraordinary experience. This occurred when their inner state was ready to receive, and circumstances brought them into contact with remarkable personalities and the immortals.

Some of these women also became well known writers who described their experience as a gift for others. Their realisation made it possible for them not only to find seclusion, but also to create alchemical poetry. *Sun Bu-er*, as already mentioned, became a famous poet of her time. These poems are only fully comprehended by those who are ready for this kind of understanding.

Wu Kailuan was the daughter of a Taoist practitioner in the 3rd Century AD. She was educated in a special place dedicated to female alchemy. She realised the Way. The following refers to her, later in the 9th century, when she appeared in order to become the wife of a proficient scientist. She helped her husband for ten years, and also wrote poetry. The time came, and they both moved to another place, and soon after this, in the mountains, they disappeared.

My body resides in the city,
but my essence is in the mountains.
The fear of marionettes' games
can not be taken seriously.
When the snow mountains
turn into the mustard seed,
all the worlds of the
universe are mortal.

We have already mentioned *Fan Yunqiao*, a Taoist teacher in the 3rd Century AD. Her husband was a Taoist disciple, but according to legend, her extraordinary magical powers and abilities superseded his knowledge of the occult. They practised together, and one day, they left together.

To nurture the essence first calm your mind.
Why bother yourself searching formastery
With a thread and a needle in your hands?
When you're leading an iron bull,
you are revealing the depth
of endless deeds of wisdom.

Practically nothing is known of *Cui Shaoxuan*, except that she was the younger daughter of an officer in northern China. She left just a few poems behind, dedicated to the practice.

The first crescent moon is like
the eyebrow of a beautiful woman:
united with the glare of the sun,
its light is abundant.
If you want to increase
the life forming energy
and to thicken the jade's broth,
first search for the coming and going away,
grab the golden wave.

Tang Guangzhen lived in the 12th Century AD. She became a healer after dreaming of contact with a Taoist, who passed medical knowledge on to her. She then learned from the immortal sisters. Later, she encountered three immortals, who gave her the choice between immortality, or life among ordinary people. She chose to live with ordinary people, and after this choice, was given a tiny golden pill. When she swallowed it, she stopped eating seeds. She was invited to live in a monastery where she was named: *«The True Immortal with the Spirit Melted into Calm»*.

When you are neither angry nor happy,
you are in harmony,
responding to events
as they happen
The wind blows the clouds,
the tiger is at peace, the dragon is tamed.
The mind is Calm;
the bright moon in the azure sky
shines with whiteness.

Chzou Xuanjing was a disciple of *Wang Zhe* in the 12th Century, and her son was also one of his pupils. She had a mystical experience after his birth, and when he was twenty, he became a follower of *Wang Zhe*'s teachings. She joined him.

The essence and the liveliness
has to be experienced first
in the moon cave.
Catch the dragon, tie up the tiger,
don't hesitate.
If yang flows out
as you develop yourself,
how can the particles
be preserved as the whole?

Sun Bu-er is perhaps the most famous female figure in Chinese Taoist tradition, together with *Wang Zhe*, the teacher who initiated both her husband and herself. She belongs to a group of the most famous Taoist immortals. She was born in 1124 and married *Ma Danian*, the disciple of *Wang Zhe*. She had three children and connected with the Tao at the age of fifty one, which was normal at that time. After experiencing marriage and motherhood, women come to experience their inner essence, unburdened by either desires or ambitions.

Sun Bu-er became a disciple of *Wang Zhe* when he came to her house in a state of drunkenness, and fell down. He was simultaneously in another place with her husband as well as being asleep in a third place. When *Sun Bu-er* realised that *Wang Zhe* had been in three places at once, she became one of his followers and studied alchemy as well as the art of talismans and magic symbols. Later she became the disciple

of one of the immortal sisters, a follower of the great *Lu Yan*. Her texts and poetry were dedicated to practices of internal transformation, where the work of consciousness and energy are directed toward purification, change and further growth.

The act of Practice

Collect your breathing in a spot,
where the frozen spirit resides.
The life energy will come from the east
let there be no restraints
bringing you to the blind alley
and then only the energy
collected on the terrace.
The darkness should go down in front,
the light comes up from behind.
After the rain the thunder
rolling over the mountain tops
and deep in the sea.

The Cultivation of the Elixir

Tie up the tiger and return it to the true den;
bridle the dragon
gradually increasing the elixir.
The essence should be as pure as the water,
The mind should be calm like a mountain.
Regulate your breathing,
collect it into the golden crucible;
balance the spirit, guide the jade's path.
If you can increase
the seed of rice each day,
you will rejuvenate yourself.

Beside the classical method of meditation practice that she is describing, she is also indicating the differences in the practices of women. For example, «to return the tiger to the true den», is a metaphor for the gathering of *shen* spirit in the chest, which is different from the male method of practice, for the gathering of *shen* spirit in the head.

In order to gather and grow the internal elixir, women must transform their nature. This transformation will give them the ability to use and to develop yang energy. Yin energy was not considered to be the alchemical component, but it was redistributed in the process of preparatory work. We must remember that for women in those days an understanding of the Tao was already defined by the Sky, that is, their environmental conditions supported their development. Consequently it was not necessary for them to create and strengthen their yin foundation, they could immediately use their yang energy for development and growth.

It was not necessary for them to spend a lot of time in order to stop their menstrual cycle, which was the indicator of change. After one hundred days of specific practice «to cut off the dragon», they were ready to cultivate yang energy. Then they used the classical techniques.

Cutting off the Dragon

The maximal stillness
creates the movement.
Ying and yang create one another.
Grab the Jade Tiger
In the wind stream,
catch the Golden Bird in the moonlight.
Observe the internal change,
Concentrate your mind
on the outflow and return.
When the bridges are being crossed
the alchemical energy
returns to the crucible.

The writings of the immortal sisters can be a source of pure wisdom for those who practice even today. No one can realise more than they are able to, just as the vessel cannot be filled more than it can. If you are ready to take in this essence, nothing will stop you. Just remember, you have more possibilities to move forward if your preparation is secure. One more aspect needs to be mentioned in the development of the Taoist tradition.

There is an alternative within the female path connected to the use of her natural yin qualities, manifesting in sexual practices. This is the Tao of Love, the art of sexual interaction, undoubtedly, it allowed

women to initially work through yin energies, creating a good foundation for further practices. As time passed female participation in this process was minimised. As a result men utilised the knowledge, and women became more and more used.

Generally, they were content with this. However, as a result of more than a few centuries of being on this path, it began to lose its significance for women as a path for development. Women distanced themselves more and more from the realisation of the internal meaning of the practices. This deprived them of the possibility of regulating and controlling their energetic processes. As a result of their structured system of knowledge, men retained far more information, especially in the area of alchemical sexual experiences. Even now, women can still access some of the secrets of the sexual art, but to a larger degree, these secrets have been externalised and are not linked to the internal changes. Generally today, the real internal changes must proceed along a somewhat different process compared with those of the past.

Today we don't have the same conditions as in the period of the formation of classical Taoist alchemy. Therefore we must thoroughly, and seriously approach an investigation of our possibilities on this path. We can only try to understand how and why women of today must begin this work.

PART TWO

Sung
Separation

Definition of initial positions

The concept of Taoist Alchemy today can be conceived only if the conditions under which it can take place are understood. The meaning of it demands contemporary definition since the way it was outlined one thousand years ago cannot serve as a foundation for women today.

This relates to several factors. Firstly, it is impossible to deny that women live in a world developed according to the laws of male energy. Despite its positive creative influence these energies also carry destructive forces which primarily are reflected toward women. Although it may seem that women are capable of counteracting the world of male energy, in reality this remains an illusion. Women today cannot perform another principle of existence and development, because they have lost the ability to do so. Even the fact that they counteract the vector of male existence invokes a response to this same vector.

The male condition is that the principle of their movements is connected with macrocosmic laws. It is this same influence that urges civilisation to develop according to laws of expansion, extension of knowledge and action, today referred to as progress.

On the other hand this extension has the effect of structural formation, differentiation and displacement, which leads to destruction. Either way, it's foundation is embodied in one aspect – yang. The simple fact that this process is constant, active and dynamic, reflects its qualities, which can not be ignored, when striving for serious results. Otherwise you will feel like a particle within this whole movement: or else be defined as a singular entity developing according to its own laws, where none of the overall scheme will suit you.

So, here we determine that each process has its own *basis of movement* (Yang) and its own *basis of rest* (Yin). A *basis of rest* is something that can be used as a support (foundation) in a process of development and particularly self-development. *Basis of movement* contains principles of movement, something that makes this process able to be realized. These two bases, in turn, can either be formed according to Yang or Yin qualities. Women's *basis of rest* has naturally been formed in accordance with Yin quality. The actual task for women therefore, is to analyse and realize the *basis of movement*.

Existing in a world of dominant male energies, women, by applying and creating these conditions, ensure the possibility to be at least part of the process. However, these conditions can lead to the degradation of their own peaceful Yin based nature. The fact that the basis of rest in women has a primal Yin quality creates special conditions for internal transformation. However, they are unable to use it because they do not know how to define the *basis of movement*. Movement here implies development which leads to the possibility of realizing their inner qualities.

The process of our existence has developed according to essential yang qualities and laws. These laws of development can be

accessed by men, while the opportunity for access is withheld from women, because the law of development through Yin energy implies completely abandoning any kind of activity. Thus by reflecting and following the primal quality of her tranquil yin nature she contradicts the laws of masculine development. If women today wish to operate from their Yin qualities to access their natural peace and tranquillity, they must avoid society and follow a monastic life.

Only a complete separation from the influences of a yang world could guide her to the capability of working with the yin aspect of her existence. If this were to happen her life would transform into the embodiment of Peace. This transformation would demand a lot of deep internal work, while refusing all contact with the external influences of society. Naturally, if this option were possible, then a refined internal transformation could occur.

The real result of this kind of alchemical work can only manifest if yin qualities are completely regulated. At such a time these maximised Yin qualities will foster a Yang manifestation, which ultimately will lead to a state of *Wu Ji*. In this state there is no distinction between Yin and Yang. No partial work is permissible here. It must be understood that any interaction with the surrounding world will lead to a confrontation before the energies have been transformed. Such an existence implies either the absence of any practice at all, as the manifestation of a passive Yin quality, or the usage of certain specific practices which are impossible to meet today in the same form and capacity as in ancient times.

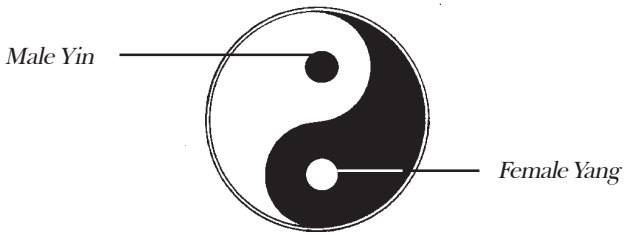
There is only one conclusion to be drawn from the above: theoretically women can use their Yin nature, but it is unrealistic to realise it practically.

On the other hand when considering the use of women's yang nature in their inherent development (which is a part of them and can also be developed), then we may again come to the same trap. Women using classical practices in some of the Taoist monasteries began working with their Yang energies, following the alchemical laws, which state that the cultivation of Yang leads to transformation and immortality. With all this in mind the yin nature of women is not considered to be a developmental factor. So, in the initial stages certain techniques are used to block and hold this yin based nature.

Undoubtedly all this leads to some results, but at a certain point these women are confronted with a problem. To work with Yang energies under monastic conditions does not give them any firm support in contact with the rest of the world. This limits them and makes them vulnerable when dealing with the inevitable influences of external conditions.

However, if this stage occurs in accordance with classical conditions and doctrines, then, sooner or later, the problem of partial energy redistribution would be lifted. So, when yang energies are cultivated in the classical way of solitude, then undoubtedly, it would be realistic to expect an alchemical result. However, again this would only occur when the work is undertaken in a complete manner, not a partial one.

Such complete work implies then that when the cultivation of Yang leads to its maximum manifestation, Yin energies begin to appear, and therefore, Yin and Yang cease to be separate, which actually is the final result. The Yang that women can use and cultivate has a direct ratio to their own yin energy. This applies to men as well, as their yin is present within their own yang.



The male Yang can be fully manifested and realised in the realistic conditions of the world. However the female Yin is constantly suppressed, and is not only unrealised but it also manifests itself negatively; as the male energies block its positive qualities. In this way men have created the conditions to manifest their yin qualities. While women are enclosed in a vicious circle, sustained by their Yin qualities, which cannot be converted within the given conditions of a male development vector.

Her major Yin does not allow her to define and use her minor Yang. On the other hand, it is exactly that suppressed Minor Yang, which keeps her yin quality enfolded. This is a natural effect, which influences those who practice classical Yang cultivation. Any external interference can influence the unregulated Yin energies which can be destructive or unbalanced. This triggers internal reactions that can vacillate within Minor Yang, which is not yet strengthened.

Without creating, restricting or isolating conditions, therefore, it can be seen from the above that it can take a long time for this work to lead to a final result, if it leads there at all. Here we have to take into account the essential quality of feminine energy. The woman can possess the refined Yang with a strong Yang direction in their development because their prenatal substance created these conditions.

If her Yin imbalanced nature does not impede her, she can start to work directly with their Major Yang, knowing that this path has no return. If they commence on this path, they must remember that the nature of their development will follow the same characteristics as male nature does. Their female qualities would become more and more subdued or withdrawn. When this happens the more they create the conditions for the formation and cultivation of Yang energy, the more they move Yin energy aside.

This makes it impossible for women to be fulfilled within themselves, either as a mother, a woman, or within male/female relationships. From this moment on all conditions are directed toward the formation of the immortal embryo, and any attempt to return to their former selves creates external and internal conflict.

Overall, we have to refine not one factor, but three. Together, they in fact form the conditions that either lead them to a correct way of development, or not. In some cases they even interfere in their development.

Three aspects of female development

The *first aspect* is connected with Prenatal Heaven. In Taoist tradition this is defined by the quality of primal energy ingrained in women from the first moment of their appearance in the world. It also depends on many other factors that precede their birth. This aspect defines the presence of Yang energy in women, and later, it determines how they will use it in their transformational work.

The *second aspect* is governed by the distribution of Yin energy, which defines women's developmental vector.

The *third aspect* is directly connected with the most important concept in the development - the rhythm, which is defined by the cycles and moon changes for women.

These three aspects form the main foundation for all the conditions that we can specify as possibilities and guides for women on their path. In order to achieve serious results in alchemical work the first aspect must have priority. However, it might not be considered in the initial stages of women's work, as they are unable either to define it or use it. Generally, the presence and expression of Yang energy has its own downfall, and should not be used as a basis for practice until such time as the preparatory work has become a real practice. If the conditions of Prenatal Heaven have been formed in such a way, that a woman finds herself in the right place from the very beginning, (a place with fine energies that would support the process of cultivation), and starts working with the correct alchemical practices, then the dynamics and quality of her work will naturally depend on Yang energy. In this case the second aspect, responsible for Yin distribution, need not be heeded, and the third aspect will relate to natural movement, and will form individual rhythm.

Although such a situation was the case in the ancient past, in the present it is practically impossible to address it. This is because even when yang energies place woman on a monastic path, they simultaneously create obstacles for them by not allowing them to understand their own foundation of unevenly distributed yin energy. This becomes the reason that causes them "to jump" over the stage of their preparatory work, causing future problems.

Women with a more defined Yang energy, whether they use it or not, have more chance not only to disengage this energy, but also

to lose it. Excessive Yang motivates them to be more active, concerning themselves with no supportive foundation. As a result, they find themselves in a situation where their action is accompanied not by accumulation, but by the burning of energy.

Excessive Yin, on the other hand, gives foundation, but as we defined earlier, has a nature of *basis of rest*. Women are not able to address it properly and will therefore not be able to induce the alchemical work of transformation.

The state of Yin energy redistribution, in turn, defines the degree of women's dependence on their Yin nature. Under present conditions this will maximise the destructive influence of this energy on them. The state manifests itself in the intensity of the flow of Yin energies. Their negative and repressive effect on women depends on whether they are able to redistribute those energies and more importantly on the degree of their past and present control over their emotional expression. The emotions, such as sadness, fear and irritation are the manifestations of women's Yin energy. Each of those expressions activates Yin energy, which has the tendency to accumulate in Yin organs. This then is followed by further intensification of these organs and by worsening their oppressive state.

Thus we have a viscous circle and only specially designed practices can take women out of these states. The practices will first help them to identify their Yin energy, and then to redistribute and stabilize it. Otherwise, any practice based on increasing and developing the dominance of Yang energy will also increase the energy in their Yin organs. This will intensify their Yin emotions and take them further and further away from the feeling of being fulfilled and happy in their lives. If they do not work on themselves and try to balance

their Yin states at all, then all their energy goes towards survival (and not to a fulfilled life). The reason for this is that they will have to use more and more of their energy for their existence under the conditions of concentrated and destructive internal and external attacks. Even love, which is the state of maximal Yang manifestation of women's Yin essence will be drowned in Yin-emotions and feelings and will be subordinated by them. They will not be able to use the force of this state (love) either for self-fulfillment, or, more specifically, for alchemical cultivation.

All the above demonstrates that Yin energy in women can either help them to develop themselves, or hinder and even stop them from the path of self-improvement. In each case, Yin energy can either be out of control and unrealised, or stabilised and utilised. If the later is the case, the alternative aspect of Yin energy is implied: the one of gathering and strengthening. We can consider this aspect of gathering only after proper understanding of the practice involved. Then we will not be talking of separation and contrasting of Yin and Yang energies, but rather about two inherent ingredients of the alchemical work, where all that gathers is connected with Yin energy and all that cultivates – with Yang energy (we will refer to this concept later). Until women start their alchemical work, the state of their Yin energy distribution will indicate what sort of work is necessary in order to learn how not to lose energy through their emotions and feelings and how to regulate it for further strengthening.

Rhythm, as a characteristic of existence can form both internally and externally. As a rule, rhythm, inherent and natural in us from birth, has a signature of our own primal energy. This rhythm gets lost and substituted by rhythm imposed on us by external factors. It

is somewhat simpler for women, as their own individual natures are based on cycles that are connected with menstruation. Nevertheless, this is not the rhythm we are referring to. On top of that, even the individual cyclic changes are very often connected with a rhythm imposed on women by society and by living conditions – in fact by all those factors, that form the external collective and not the individual rhythm. It may be good for women to become adapted to that rhythm and to structure their life and practices according to its demands. This will enable them to minimise energetic losses. Nevertheless, they can not avoid their energy loss unless they change their conditions of existence and find themselves in an externally different structure of rhythm. It becomes rather hard to keep at least some of the "gains" from the previous period.

It is a prerequisite in the law of alchemical transformation to observe rhythm. Although it is impossible to find one's own rhythm immediately, we must make efforts to find it from our first steps of practice. You have to define the occurrence, reason and timing for your actions in relation to moon cycles. Women of any age, even those who do not menstruate (young girls or elderly women) still experience their cycle changes each lunar month. On the initial stages of their self-development, practice is connected with restructuring their own rhythmic pattern.

We have defined three main factors, which are the basis of the female line of development. Generally speaking, from the point of view of practice, there are three factors that influence us. These factors not only effect future processes of change, but are also the starting point from where all the changes originate. When women try to define their own path, they must take into account these characteristics and

should therefore not consider the first practice they come in touch with to be the final truth.

Women and the practice

If women feel the necessity to define themselves and to change the quality of their existence, then the Taoist practices in the form in which they are presented today, can become either the most productive or the most disappointing for them as they demand reconstruction of the initial state. If women are capable of realising that the real alchemical practice is the process of the constant work leading to finer transformations, and if they look at the practice from this point of view; then it does not matter which practice is performed as long as it is done with awareness, constancy and a serious quality. Quality work in this respect implies that all the elements of energy, body and consciousness are included in the process. This was the way of practice in the past when alchemy was a part of normal existence and started to form as a system. It is another issue for today's women to attain such sensibility towards the practice. To be able to conduct the work in such a way is quite difficult at the initial stages.

This is especially so if they start to practice when the social structure has overtaken their consciousness, trapping them into a social world that they created themselves. This is why the incorrect approach towards this study can result in a sudden disappointment. Even if women could correct their energetic structures that have already begun to deteriorate, their consciousness still would not be satisfied. Here we have to take into account the distinctive consciousness of today's women, which hosts the expectation for results, development

and fulfilment and is much larger than their actual efforts to achieve these results.

When practice is correctly structured and in accordance with the necessary laws and energies, it can lead to a state where we can really start to work on alchemical transformations. Taoist practices belong to this category. The most dangerous trap here to be encountered is in the distinction between real practice and preparatory work. For women the concept of preparatory work carries an unfolding character. It is difficult for women to discover the meaningful value in long-lasting and carefully undertaken preparatory work, an indispensable prerequisite before they can actually commence the practice itself. To stop in the middle of the work, to doubt the quality of the technique they apply would mean they were only creating illusions. Women too often believe this to be the real practice while the given process is just a preparatory one. If women would recognise this merely as a preparation and accept it as a necessary condition, regardless of its duration, then the work at this stage will have better quality.

It is natural for women to desire fulfilment. It is their expectation to acquire this for themselves. It is also natural for men to aim for self-realisation themselves, although contrary to women their urge is to give. Thus, women in a state of expectation, desiring the fulfilment from the practice, approach their studies from this perspective without being aware of it. They can not create the conditions for fulfilment immediately as at first they must realise what is already theirs. This, combined with their colossal susceptibility to external conditions makes them vulnerable in the face of constant downfalls in practice and occurring depressions. Men are endangered

here in a different way: in that they inadequately define information and the realisation of actions. The result is that they do not understand their practice and, not understanding one approach, start to look for another. Nevertheless the coincidence of the general vector of development and individuality gives a man far more chances in his journey along the path of alchemical work. Women must constantly consider the specific incongruity in their energies, compared to the conditions required for their conversion. Active and even aggressive Yang environments prohibit women from realising quickly and correctly their own energetic inner yin qualities. Therefore what is necessary for their normal existence are not those practices designed specifically to cultivate Yang, but those which regulate and strengthen their Yin energies.

We will look at the Taoist practices for women as preparation for further alchemical work from this point of view.

Specific characteristics

Besides *Yin* energy, which women need to strengthen and regulate before developing and cultivating *Yang* energy, there is a third type of energy, which cannot be ignored.

In accepting conditions defined by men, women have come to a situation where their functions are disturbed from birth, thus neither being able to realise Yin, nor use Yang energies. As a result they lose twice as much energy during their lifetime as men do. It is difficult to define it externally: for example, it is believed that women live longer then men and yet they are able to expend more energy. According to alchemical laws and knowledge, it is considered a corruption of the

transformational practice if women's energy-consuming organs are focused on their survival. This existence forces them to use more effort than men in order to absorb energy from the surrounding world. The quality of this degradation, together with the loss of access to primary sources of knowledge, changed female energy so much that they began giving birth to descendants with altered energy. The energy of these children is neither yang nor yin, but is a third kind, which we will refer to as inorganic.

Women are not responsible for this misdirection to inorganic energy, however they, as birth givers, are responsible for creating a vacuum in the energetic construction of their offspring. This vacuum became filled by energy foreign to the original human condition. We will define this energy as inorganic (although today it is no longer alien to us, and is part of our reality).

It affected many of the internal techniques, and brought them to a restricted place formed not only by the sky and earth energy, but also by the energy of inorganic space. This barrier or wall cannot be penetrated unless all these energy types assimilate. This has a particular concern for women, yet men are soaked more deeply with this energy. Actually, it is this same energy that helps reconstruct the foreign codes superimposed over the earth, which appear benevolent, yet can be paralysing. Such a paralysing action also affects our potential for natural development by interfering with our natural energies. As a result, we can begin to develop a favourable space, but are unable to maintain our orientation there.

Taoist Alchemy explains why this energy develops, utilising knowledge of the electric potentials of the brain's impulses and high frequency emissions. Until recently this knowledge was hidden as it

represented the noblest of energetic manifestations in human beings. It has become possible for human kind to develop empirical perception, yet this knowledge and communication lacked the understanding of it's essence. Either way, the paralysis of our natural energies today has almost reached the last stages of resistance to this pressure, and we may in the future lose our ability to develop these energies.

When we look around we must agree that this information has been acknowledged before. If we would only use our own natural energy, then most of what we previously created would seem irrelevant. We are not suggesting a return to cave life; that would be unnatural. We are simply suggesting the need to recognise the forces that have to be utilised. These forces are a part of the ingredients necessary for the alchemical process of creating the golden pill. Of course, if you are prepared to live in natural conditions, external influences will not bother you; you will be able to deeply concentrate on your practice. However, there are only a few people ready to do this and, in addition, it also takes a lot more effort than it does to continue developing in our new inorganic environment that has become almost natural to us. It is important not to be afraid of this environment, and to learn how to understand it. If you do not understand your environment, then the focus is directed not to internal cultivation but only to healing yourself. You may succeed in purification of your yin and yang energy, but not of your inorganic energy. You will only be able to either «trick» or «fuse» it, nothing more.

Inorganic energy gravitates toward women more then men, even though a woman is less effected by this energy. Yet they are a carrier of it and transmit the effects of this energy to men. Thus we

have a vicious circle of contemporary women's development linking to the vector of male development. This vector, in turn, is conditioned by the influence of inorganic energy carried by women. This exerts an action on the frame of conditions which does not allow them to weave their energy in accordance with their nature.

What could be used under these circumstances? Firstly, a created potential which can neither be neglected nor particularly be counteracted. Strictly speaking, this potential appears in an opportunity for today's approach to the special practices. In other words, we can use that same frequency our brain has attuned to, i.e. by using the very misdirection of the inorganic energy, to help us master the inner practices to correct its influence. Yet it is quite another question for women's consciousness to learn a different method, to acquire and process the information to enable them to retain their energy in the procedure. To do this they relax their consciousness by redistributing the exertion in their head.

Ten centuries ago Taoist practitioners had no need for this kind of relaxation. Working deeply with the brain was not a defining factor in those days, unlike it is today. The amount of information that today invades our consciousness demands a similar level of energy for it to be processed. Obviously, hundreds of years ago our brain was not ready for such work, nor was there a necessity for it. Even today it is not quite ready for such a refined process. Nevertheless the brain is overloaded with information and consequently the intensity of this process does not decrease. In these circumstances of a forced and unschooled activation of the brain, certain changes occur: Alchemically its energetic structure induces an irreplaceable energy loss.

As we have touched upon capability of female energy distribution precisely from the viewpoint of contemporary existence, it is necessary to point out that fine preparatory alchemical work for women is connected with two parameters: the relaxation of the head; and, redistribution of energy in the lower abdomen. These two concepts are equally important and interrelated: we cannot talk about one separately from the other. Moreover this redistribution of energy in the lower abdomen needs to be understood, not as an energy cultivation process, but as a definition of consciousness. We imply that the process of perception needs to shift. It is the reverse for men: firstly, they regulate head energy, stopping the flow of consciousness; and relax the abdomen by redistributing the exertion. Thus they create conditions for the formation of the "cinnabar field" and cultivation of the alchemical Immortal Embryo.

When women relax their consciousness it is not implied that they weaken the brain (as it may seem to some). At this point then, it is necessary to define the condition of the energy in their head. Firstly, let us remember that the natural female functions are accumulation and consumption and that they manifest throughout all the process. Yet we cannot speak about the processes of preservation and holding until conditions have been created for a natural redistribution of the inflowing energy. Compared to men, women are more susceptible when they commence practising «brain exercises», as the energies going through the brain are directed toward nourishing their feelings and emotions. Such nourishing relates to unregulated energies in the lower abdomen.

In general, correct and incorrect functioning of the lower centres influences the overall distribution of energy, therefore, it is

important to start examining these processes. Whether willingly or not a general and acute susceptibility to surroundings makes women sensitive to any potential irritations, whether visual or tactile or even mental. This activates the brain process, and if it is not linked with the lower abdomen an energy block forms, leading to an imbalance. Today however, women have lost their connection, and so the information is not absorbed either properly or appropriately.

The problem comes when consciousness increases the Yin-emotions and Yin-feelings and they become captive to the resulting condition. This deprives them of the option to work with yang energy. Women are stimulated by emotions of sadness, worry, longing, fearfulness and torment, finding unhealthy satisfaction in these emotions, even if they will never admit it. Yet the noble and fine yin states, as for example self-sacrifice, are their prerogative. Nevertheless, it is important to define a method for development. If they choose to indulge in their emotional states and bring them to a fine condition, their ability to realise the yang states of fulfilment, happiness and satisfaction would occur less and less and it would be harder to maintain. Through considering the process of realising their yang qualities by means of yin energy redistribution, they avoid increasing yin-based suffering and concentrate on relaxation of their consciousness. These readjustments imply a return to a specific way of perception that can be enabled only with the proper functioning of energy in the lower abdomen.

From the viewpoint of today's alchemical practice, women's consciousness needs to achieve a certain state. On the one hand it has to enable the control of the processes of energy redistribution and further linkage throughout the body. On the other, it should help in

the work with finer energies and the energy of Heaven. These energies are responsible for the formation of the *shen* spirit (see «*Three Treasures of Alchemy*»).

Gathering and Strengthening

We have discussed that the perquisite to alchemical work, besides consciousness is based on acquiring the correct distribution of energy in the lower part of the body. If the energy is regulated here, and the head is energetically relaxed, then even those things that usually provoke negative emotions would not be harmful for women. The work in the lower part of the body needs to be linked with the *Supreme centre*. The conditions for this centre to appear, manifests itself during the preparatory work. Until the *Supreme centre* has become a Governor of all processes in the abdomen women are unable to use their potential yang energy dwelling in her abdomen; it is jammed. (That same energy in men is located in the head). The potential, yet entangled yang energy in a woman's abdomen does not give her advantages, although it is situated exactly in the same spot where the *Supreme centre* can be formed. This energy can be used when the energy in the lower part of the body has been regulated and corrected. Besides, this energy cannot be freed unless the upper part of the body is ready to receive it.

At this point we should mention that a prerequisite for this energy regulation is connected with the *rhythm*. Until then women need to cultivate energetic centres, so that in the first stage of the preparatory work the energy would properly function by filling yin organs and glands.

Actually, here we come back to the same topic from where we started. There can be no development for women without the initial energy distribution which, in turn, requires preparatory work connected with strengthening and redistributing Yin energies. Generally speaking, during the alchemical process the energetic division of Yin and Yang as two energies in opposition to each other ceases to exist. Everything that strengthens and gathers is connected with Yin energy, and everything that helps to grow and cultivate is connected with Yang energy. When strengthening reaches the required quality, then we begin to talk about increasing and cultivating it. The question arises: Is it necessary to strengthen both the body and the consciousness in order to study alchemy? If your answer is "yes", then you have to strengthen and gather Yin energy. If there is no need for you to gather and strengthen anything then you can immediately start to work with Yang energy. There are no contradictions between these two energies here. Some practitioners, who concentrate on cultivating Yang energy, speak of working with Yin energy as being opposite. This is not so, because if we gather and strengthen something before cultivating, it is then the work of Yin energies.

There are some Taoist practices, however, which do not pay attention to preparing consciousness and the body. If it is not necessary to work with body movement, then there is no need for them to prepare it. In this case the energy of stillness can be used, while increasing already existing Yang energy, as for example in static meditation.

Many of the practices to help gather and strengthen energies that are initially offered to women are similar to men's gathering

energy below (e.g., Tai Ji, Bagua). These practices will help women with basic practices, for instance, abdominal exercises where they will learn how to relax the abdomen. In any case this should lead to primary energy redistribution. It is essential, however, that the underlying foundation of practising them embodies specific individual methods and rhythm. Such a method should bring women to make a movement at those points where men are still and, antithetically, be still where men are moving. She has to move to the left while he moves to the right and vice versa. But it is not so easy to come to this state and more particularly, to realise it. That is why when women are using the practice in the same form as men, it is not considered to be a redistribution of energy, but rather a preparation of the body and creation of the conditions necessary for its realisation. Else it can be considered to be cultivating yang energy without preparation and gathering.

Regarding the rhythm: it is almost impossible for women to connect it to the practice without their cycles being connected to the moon. Individual work is required for women to connect their practice to the cycles of the moon. She needs to depend on her sensations, listening first of all to her menstrual cycle as well as the rhythm of its performance. In addition to that she needs to work according to even and uneven days. On uneven days working in a clockwise direction, and on even days in an anti-clockwise direction. In any case as long as women are not ready to connect their rhythm to the practice of such techniques as Bagua or Tai Ji, she will still create the conditions for further corrective work connected with her body and consciousness. This is already significant, although it takes a whole cycle of time, requiring constancy of practice in order to come to this stage.

When men's practice is correct, repetition of each movement brings the energy from the centre to the surface. For women the opposite applies: the repetition of each movement and turn brings the energy to the centre. But this does not mean that she has the correct place to accumulate the energy, i.e. the *Supreme centre*. The nature of female energy is such that it is directed inwards while men's energy is directed outwards. If this is not controlled, men will lose their energy during any physical activity while women will also lose theirs, but differently. Her energy is not gathered at random, but is pulled toward five yin organs.

Therefore, by concentrating on any of the yin organs connected with the specific feeling or experience, she increases the expression of this emotion. Naturally, this makes her lose energy by the action itself. For example, if a woman is inclined to sadness, then in the process of the dynamic practice this feeling could be increased because the energy would go to the lungs.

In any case, the energy needs to be gathered somewhere, and by doing the practice she strengthens her energy by gathering it. This does not mean that the practice is harmful to her, but rather that she must simply consider that before she understands the mechanics of gathering her energy, she has to pass a period of preparation.

This period may increase her yin inclinations. Naturally as yin states increase they lead to the loss of yang energy, but simultaneously yin energy can also be increased. This is indicated by the fact that women increase their oppressed states pertaining to their yin nature and enjoy being in those states. They do not loose the

energy but increase the yin quality. What they lose is capacity to open and cultivate the yang qualities.

Also it must be noted that the energy in women is not only pulled towards the five yin organs. It is further pulled to the glands and then into the blood. Actually together with these practices, leading to pulling the energy, there are also other practices, which help to understand the basis of this gathering in order to control these processes, e.g. Tao Yin.

Nevertheless, women can be fulfilled with what they do and with the internal processes inside them. In addition, the correct application of the practice would help them to open their yang energies. It is far more important for women, than it is for men, to use the correct techniques based on this comprehensible system of principles, otherwise they will not only lose their yang energy (because of wrong energy distribution), but also increase the formation of yin energy.

Working with Horizontal energies

The other important aspect in the preparation for alchemical work is linked to the fact that it's energetic basis is horizontal. This means that to create a maximum impulse for all forces, a horizontal structure must be used. Overall, female organs have an energetic construction based on a horizontal principle. This is why to understand the meaning of horizontal energy, women must be able to identify their external and internal sensations, and learn to control them.

Horizontal energy work is a necessary step for women, not only as a tool in understanding their nature, but also as one of the prerequisites, which will help them to use their potential in practices. On the other hand it can be explained that their life in relation to vertically oriented male energy deprives them of the opportunity to use their own basic principle. This principle is the foundation of their existence, and its quality is stillness. Women begin to lose their connection with this horizontal principle in early childhood, which has an increasingly negative influence on them as time goes by. Horizontal positions of the body are important for women, yet they spend most of their time in vertical positions. As such all spheres of their vital activity not only develop their energetic structure in relation to general principles, but also destroys it. The more women follow vertical laws, (especially when utilising them in their techniques and practices), the more they destroy their lymphatic system. Accordingly, they lessen their chances of identifying their essential Yin energy. We will discuss this aspect later.

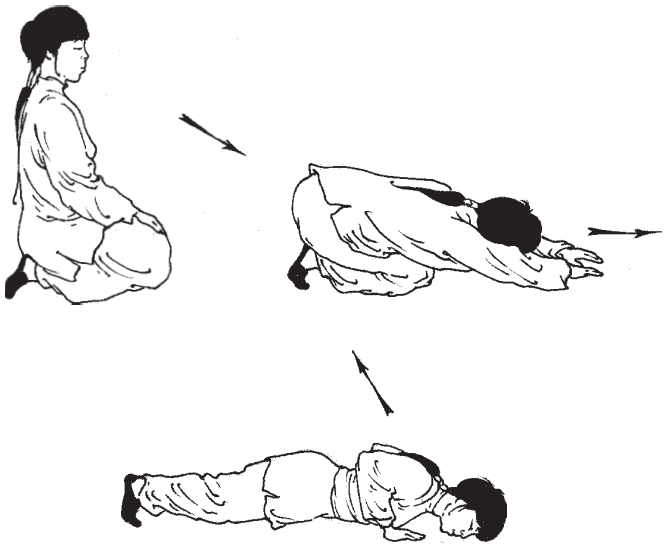
Furthermore the suppression begins to work on one of the most important glands for women - the thymus. This gland actively participates in the process of growth up to the age of 21, and then begins to shrink. It becomes energetically suppressed especially in the female body in a vertically oriented position. After the age of 21, the enlivening of the thymus for women can only be done in a lying position. This does not mean that sleep will help you to restore the function of the thymus. When we talk about energetic enlivening of the thymus, we mean that a lying position is necessary to practice, with a clear understanding, and concentrated movements. In order

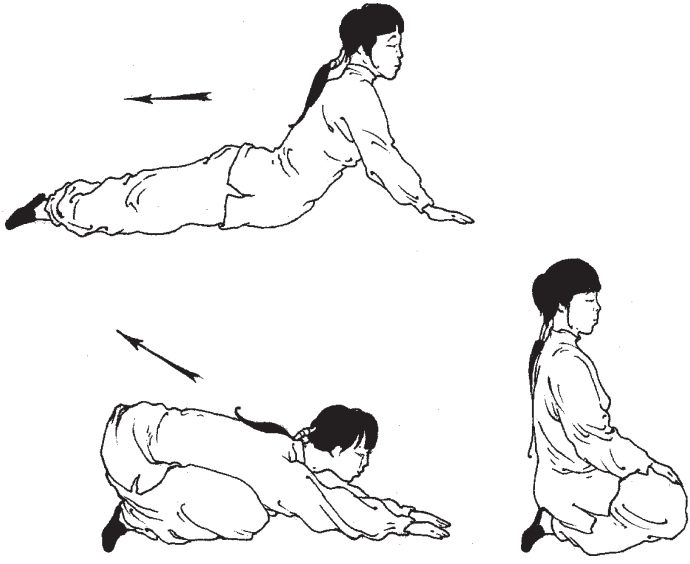
to purify the lymphatic system, and restore the thymus, it is necessary to practice in a horizontal position, no less then twenty minutes daily.

You will not only be able to restore the functions of the oppressed gland, but also be able to slow down the active ageing process, which is unavoidable when women orientate toward male practices and male ways of life. Nevertheless we must again emphasise that the principle foundation for work is not simply the lying position, but is the energy work done on the horizontal plane. Developing concentration in order to feel and direct your energy is only meaningful in the position most familiar to you. If you are not able to control your state, then the horizontal position will have a loosening effect on you. This does not mean that this practice is unsuitable for you. Rather, this loosened state simply shows the state of your own energetic condition. Therefore, in the vertical position develop concentration, and in the horizontal position learn how to use it for maximum benefit.

One of the practices offered is the tendon technique, "*Yijin-jing for the weak*». This technique concentrates precisely on the preparatory aspect. Here we can note that in women, rough and irregular energy is concentrated in their tendons. That same distressed thymus condition is partially responsible for the intensity of this concentration. Emotions like anger, fear, longing, irritations, as well as out of control gaiety are neither natural nor necessary for us. All these states are nourished by certain energies referred to in Taoist tradition as *Po* spirits, which are dwelling in the lungs. These spirits express all that is irrational, body bound and out of control in us. They form during birth, along with higher rational and conscious

Hun spirits. It is interesting to note that we have fewer (three) higher rational spirits, than lower ones (seven). Your physical and psychological well being depends on the harmonious interactions between these energies. Obviously, it is not easy for women to control *Po* spirits. By the way the dwelling place of *Hun* spirits is the liver, which is why importance is given when working with cyclic blood energy to free oneself from negative emotions. If the internal functions of our body are out of control, *Po* spirits take over, together with their energy and awareness. In a case of serious energy regulation work, they accumulate in the region, which relates to them, i.e. chest and lungs. This should not frighten us, neither should we try get rid of them. To dissolve this feeling of density, we can do certain exercises based on opening and closing the chest, taking care not to bring too much tension to ligaments and joints, and keeping the chest in a relaxed position.





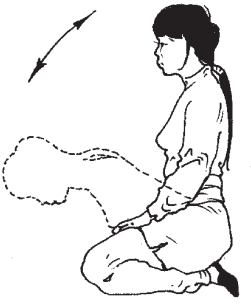
Later we will give special attention to relaxing the "purple castle", which protects the thymus and mammary gland energies from being consumed by *Po* spirits. Again working with the horizontal plane, it must be noted, that if you start to yawn a lot, as you lie down to do your practice, and feel like stretching out or simply want to lie, this indicates that the energies, connected with *Po* spirits, are being freed. This is a normal process, but do not exaggerate it. After all the yawning, stretching and rolling about, if the body becomes too relaxed, you will fall asleep.

One more point regarding the lying position: It is connected with tying up the energy in the female body. Actually there are two methods of tying up the energy; around the periphery and around the centre. Tying up the energy around the periphery is a more serious and refined work. However as women can be late creating the

conditions for the formation of the Immortal Embryo, it might take up too much time to firstly tie up energies around the periphery and then to tie up energies through the centre (which is absolutely necessary), making all the preliminary work in this case is irrelevant. Therefore, tying up the energy through the centre is at least a reliable approach to the reconstruction of their energetic system.

But before this step, women must regulate their energy, so that it can circulate naturally, gathering in a spiral. Apart from this, female energy needs to turn anti-clockwise in order to foster the circulation necessary to create the conditions for the *Supreme centre* to be nurtured. The best position for this is when the abdomen is parallel to the floor, although the vertical position can also be used.

As the energy needs to be naturally adopted and tied up, it can be done through the practice in horizontal and vertical positions. So, for tying up the energy we use twisting movement of the energy in a horizontal position, and then adopting it pressing toward and moving into a vertical position. Here we introduce one more principle, called the «shuttle» or «pendulum» method. Women both in their general practice as well as in individual exercises can use this, for example, rocking the body in a sitting position. Moreover it is preferable if women themselves define their own body position as well as the time beat of the rocking. If women are able to make such adjustments, the exercises become individualised as proper preparatory work. This could be used for shaking and jolting the energy in the lower part of the body.



Thus Internal practices for women have a basis in separation and discord. This is shown in the hexagram *Sung*: Separation. The hexagram of discord and conflict shows caution in development, being manifested in barriers along the path of unification with the sky. The external manifestation of the *Qian* trigram is hiding the waters of the abyss (Kan), ready to flood another layer, even if it is a symbol of perfection.

Before crossing a vast river, women need to understand the depth of their nature and its peculiarities. The energy they possess is dangerous, if it is applied without internal truth. Its application without proper comprehension deprives them from real actions and makes them dependent not only on external factors, but also on internal reasons. If a female practitioner wants to reach her independence, she has to balance her body, energy and spirit. Until this balance is achieved, we need to talk about these elements being in a state of sickness. Any sharp action and projection can also lead her to fall into the abyss. The gap between the water and sky (the foundation of the hexagram) relates to different movements that can be unified after long and serious work.

The beginning of any movement follows an event, which can be either good or bad. But all comes to an end, symbolising what is complete and can simultaneously become the beginning of something new. From the point of view of the given hexagram, the first line shows the beginning that has no foundation, but represents the gap from the previous event. If we master the given situation, we develop an internal foundation, shown in the following line. It becomes a foundation not only as a stage of succession, but also as an internal

force, which helps the action. Gaining such force, the female practitioner would be able to realise her own nature, which can only bring her joy and fulfilment. But we should not indulge in this force, directing it to extreme joy and happiness, but continue to self develop, so that the force, which moves feminine nature, will flow and change in accord with the laws of nature and not chaotically. If a female practitioner can understand her own forces, then each step she takes will strengthen her finer qualities. By gaining control over her inner truth, she would be able to control her destiny. This is incomparable to anything else. Thus, your first step is in the direction of the sky. But in the process of tearing yourself from the state of formlessness, it is wise to remember that each mistake is worth two. The fifth line of the hexagram shows happiness. It can be found if we follow our inner truth and not external meanings. It shows the singular reason for everything and, in a given case, the beginning of unification of qualities (for women), with the perspective of the sky. The sixth line completes the cycle of actions, showing the possibility of victory by means of separation. This becomes the basis for the following situation, or following life in the case of union with the quintessence, the foundation of inner nature.

Taoist Alchemy for women

Alchemical Tools

***Yang* - mind**, which forces energy to work.

***Yin* - body**, which creates conditions for energy gathering and nurturing.

Alchemical Forces

***Peng* Force** - forms framework for the alchemy and its centre.

***Lu* Force** - gathers and fills up the form.

***An* Force** - moves and redistributes energy.

***Chi* Force** - uncovers *jing* energy.

***Lieh* Force** - settles development of Yin energy.

***Tsai* Force** - draws energy towards centre.

***Chou* Force** - extract *shen* spirit

***Kao* Force** - gives form to alchemy.

Treasures of Alchemy

***Qi* treasure** - energy that fills and sustains the body.

***Jing* treasure** - energy that cultivates energetic body.

***Shen* treasure** - energy that forms spirit by cultivating the Immortal body.

Preparation of the Body to Realise the Alchemical Process

Moon - *Yang*

Positioning the body in such a way that the connections can be reorganised in the vertical plane. The Moon is in the first quarter.

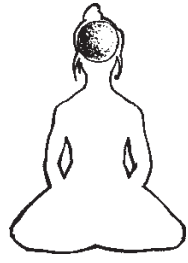
Moon - *Yin*

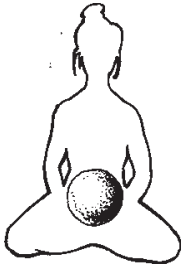
Positioning the legs and lower part of the trunk so that the links in the horizontal plane can be constructed. The moon is in the third quarter.

Preparation of Consciousness for the Alchemical Process

Sun - *Yang*

Relaxation of the head.





Sun - *Yin*

Relaxation of the stomach.

Qi, Jing and *Shen*

It is known that energies *jing, qi* and *shen* govern alchemical energies. It is important to understand the difference between the ideas usually described in popular volumes and actual alchemical concepts.

First we have to understand to the meaning of the term *jing*. Traditionally this term defines finer energy that is primarily connected with the semen (for men) or with the blood. This is a form creating energy necessary for finer existence. From this point of view *jing* generally represents the source of *shen* spirit for all living beings. This energy always exists in the human body in an uncontrolled condition.

However, according to alchemical concepts *jing* represents the basis for the formation of *shen* energy, which is of a substantially finer quality. Although we are still referring to *jing* energy, the production of this energy in the whole body during the process of the alchemical work is no longer uncontrolled. It is a necessary condition for the genuine alchemical transformation process. As long as this process is related to such an important concept as rhythm, we can refer to *jing* energy as a flow, which changes *qi*, forms *shen* and reinforces itself.

Jing energy is also interpreted as primal *jing* (*yuan jing*). It is inherited from our parents and is formed as a result of merging both, the *jing* energy of mother and father. Here we notice the special significance of *yuan jing* as a substance in which *qi* and *shen* energies form in a specific way. Making it possible for these energies to be kept and strengthened for higher quality usage later, namely for the formation of alchemical ingredients.

The kidneys are the dwelling place of *yuan jing* energy, which forms *yuan qi* (the original energy of our existence). *Yuan qi* is also stored in the kidneys. Generally, however, *yuan jing* is also concentrated in the glands and other yin organs, ie the liver, heart, lungs and spleen. This energy is one of the most important sources of life and growth; it is distributed throughout the organism and supports its vital functions. When we consider the appropriate redistribution of *yuan jing* energy, we refer to its function of supporting the glands, and to some extent preserving their *jing* energy. *Yuan jing* energy stimulates the behaviour of the vital activity of these organs, and encourages an appropriate rhythmic energy flow throughout the body.

The term *qi* has an enormous variety of definitions. As the body's foundational energy, *qi* is divided into two types: Pre-natal *qi* and Post-natal *qi*. The *qi* of meridians and glands is Pre-natal *qi* (*xiantian qi*), and manifests from birth. Post-natal *qi* (*houtian qi*) is formed in the process of life activities and is localised in the *zang*-fu organs. Pre-natal *qi* is known as the *qi* of water, or *shut qi*, and Post-natal *qi* is known as the *qi* of fire, or *ho qi*.

The alchemical task is to bring the fire of the post-natal energy to the lower abdomen, while the water of the pre-natal energy is brought up. This activity stimulates conditions for the beginning of the alchemical work of energy transformation. A balance between Pre-natal and Post-natal *qi* forms *jing* energy, which circulates, filling the eight Extraordinary Meridians.

From an alchemical viewpoint, *qi* is the fundamental element for the construction of the Immortal body. It is formed by *jing* energy, and is expanded by *shen* spirit. The formation of the *Supreme centre*, supporting the development of conditions favourable for the immortal

embryo, will sustain the production of *jing* energy in any part of the body to varying degrees. However, until this has been achieved, *yuan qi* and *yuan jing* energies are the prime ingredients for our alchemical development.

When we talk about *qi* energy from an alchemical viewpoint, we refer to an energy that offers control over the circulation of *qi* energy, especially in two main Extraordinary meridians – the Governing Vessel, and the Conception Vessel. It is essential to gain control over these two vessels at the beginning of alchemical practices, but this is not enough.

Firstly we will discuss developing a focused concentration on the alignment of the energy flow with the rhythm. This helps to safeguard energy that has been gathered, as well as to multiply it. It also helps to activate regulation of *jing* energy. We should note here that the regulation and the development of *jing* energy are two different processes. The development of energy is impossible without regulation. However, the process of regulation *should* occur without development. Under the concept of regulation of the energy without development, it is implied that the refined energy is lost unless it is being regulated. If the energy is being developed without regulation it will be lost. Together with the loss of this energy we create conditions, which have a destructive effect on the energetic body. This happens because the functions of various vessels are interrupted, some are filled with fine energies, while others are not. As a result the function of some glands increase to hyper-function, while others decrease to hypo-function. This often leads to an imbalance of energy flow throughout the body, inhibiting the possibility of a thorough, overall energetic control.

If a woman has just started practising or does not use practice at all, *jing* energy in her body is connected with the liver, mammary glands and ovaries. These glands produce a *jing* energy which is stored in the liver. Thus the blood becomes the main distributor of *jing* energy which can then be nourished and reconstructed during the menstrual cycle into a more revivified state. Even when a woman is not menstruating, she still has 2-3 days a month, during which time her whole endocrine system and blood undergoes reconstructive changes.

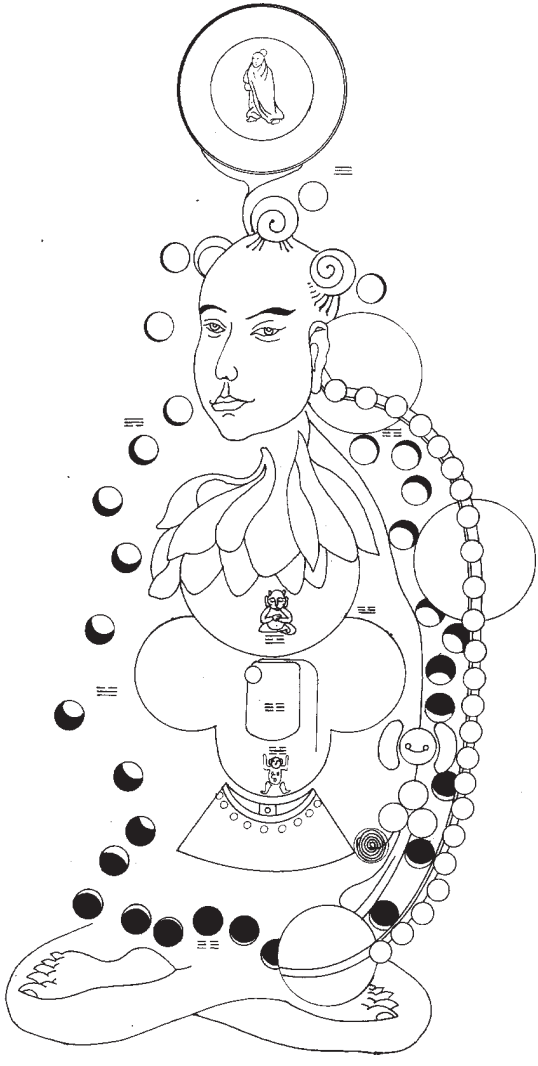
The work with *jing* energy should be closely interrelated with the lunar months, otherwise it is not worthwhile to discuss *jing* energy formation at all. Instead, we would speak of *qi* energy formation. In other words, *jing* energy has a certain rhythm within its function, and therefore to a certain degree can be controlled. Whereas *qi* energy is aligned by the rhythm of the seasons for its formation, and as such is out of our control.

The female practitioner should guide the energy through the rhythm of lunar cycles. Through this practice it is said that *jing* energy is thus created, which is necessary for alchemical growth toward the ultimate cultivation of *shen* energy.

According to Taoist tradition, if the orbit has been guided through fifteen phases, then fifteen seasons are realised.

Preparation for alchemical practice

In order for women to develop their yang energy line and not repress their yin nature they must first build an energetic structure with a proper foundation. This is of special concern for those women



who have not yet understood their energies, and because of their active lifestyle, are unable to completely commit themselves to specific practices. At first it may be dangerous for them to develop first the yang line, (which according to Taoist principles is based on male energies), as it may cause destructive consequences to their energetic bodies. They may not have enough strength to continue their development and proceed to alchemical work later on. Therefore the initial preparatory work has the primary role, as it creates a basis for further movement.

It is necessary to understand that everything connected with the preparatory techniques helps to create conditions for both *jing* development and *qi* regulation. Yet this does not manufacture conditions for the creation and growth of the immortal embryo. When we talk about the immortal embryo, we are primarily referring to an accumulated energetic structure or core, which does not disperse under any circumstances.

Contrary to men, women should not accelerate development of their *jing* energy. It is far more important for them to regulate their energy by normalising its circulation, and ensuring its preservation and concentrated state. Primarily, it is necessary to reach uttermost control over the movement of this energy by becoming aware of its volume and flow. When this point is reached practices can begin to work with *jing* energy.

Once the *jing* energy has reached a state of volume, it can be used to 'tie up' and bind together the energies, which represents fine alchemical work. The *jing* energy represents additional building material for *qi* energy, which cannot be considered outside the capacity

of *jing*. (*Qi* itself has a number of characteristics of energy, such as *qi* of itself, *qi* related to *jing* and *qi* related to *shen*).

Here it is necessary to understand the concept of energy foundation. It is formed by a complex vital organ, linking the *Supreme centre* of women with their womb. Before examining the role and development of this organ, it is necessary to explain the concept of a *Supreme centre*.

In Taoist Alchemy the *Supreme centre* has three levels. According to macrocosmic concepts this centre is represented by a Pole star known as *Dou He*, and is based on prospects for departure from the conceptual boundaries of this sphere. In other words, when we reach a certain level of development, we can become liberated, surpassing all the limits of Earth's boundaries. *Wu Ji* represents another symbol for this star, which has the same significance for other traditions as it does for the Taoist. It is connected to maximal change and transformation, based on spiral macrocosmic movement.

The second level of understanding of the *Supreme centre* is connected to the earth and its centre, known as *Dou Yi*. This conception centre cannot be understood literally as it only defines the foundation, which supports all the earth's creations.

The third level is directly connected to human beings and in Taoist traditions is referred to as *Dan Tien* (The Alchemical Field). Those who begin practising Taoist Alchemy, have to direct all their effort to developing and connecting with their *Dan Tien*. Forming their *Supreme centre* is harder for women than it is for men, because of the possibility of developing a false centre. In other words, when women begin feeling sensations in their lower abdomen they can

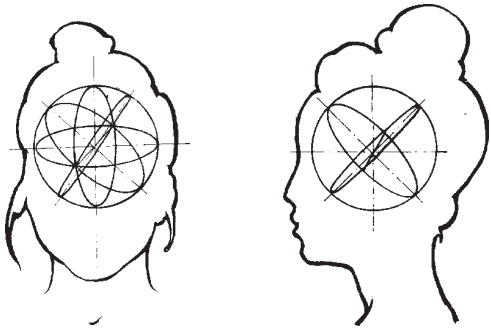
mistake them as coming from the *Supreme centre*. But in reality, these sensations originate in the womb, which activates women's yin energy. She may even experience certain sensations, similar to those created during the development of the actual lower alchemical field known as the "vermilion field'. This is a trap to always be aware of. Firstly it is connected to the head, which magnifies false sensations connected to changes in gland functions. Sometimes these changes are connected with visions, appearing because of the increased energy moving through the head. During practices with form creating techniques, because of their more sensitive nature, women can be confronted with information.

However she should not be scared of this, as it is a natural process which many experience. Yet, it is not advisable to trust these manifestations as they cannot be correctly employed before the *Supreme centre* has been created. In order to avoid these false sensations happening, it is necessary to follow proper practices. They should concentrate on providing conditions for *qi* regulation, followed by *jing* formation, development and the process of "tying it up'. With the effect of enhancement of concentration, strengthening of yin organs and energy regulation through the orbit. Providing that these conditions are satisfied, we can begin cultivating yang energies.

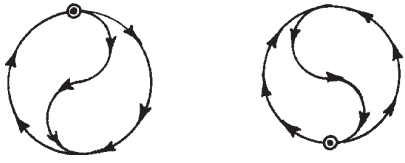
In order for yang energy to be actively cultivated from the beginning, it is important to create the necessary conditions for the neutralisation of yin energy. If yin energy is not neutralised, then with the cultivation of yang energy, the primal *yuan qi* will burn out.

We will now examine preparatory techniques which will be useful to enhance concentration as well as to create special conditions for finer energy redistribution.

Relaxation of the upper chambers (Septenary orbits for the head)



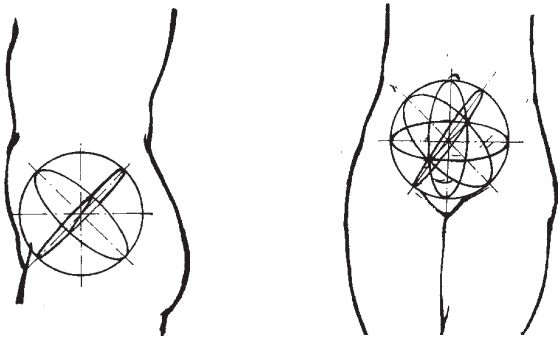
This technique is designed to liberate the brain from its dependence on the pressure of yin energies. It is based on movement along the line of yin-yang, when excessive concentration and exertion of energy will be released through its transformation into a certain form. Each plane is worked on separately. The movement can be made in the following sequence: from the top point, then through yin-yang via the centre, and finally from the bottom point to the opposite side again through yin-yang via the centre. Movement finishes at its commencing point. This movement describes an 8-shaped figure, forming a circuit across the inside of the circle via the centre.



This specific movement releases energy concentration, and pressure blockages in the head. It should transform these blockages,

returning the flow to a state of relaxed circulation again. It is useful to feel the sphere of the head vessel.

Strengthening of the lower chambers (Septenary orbits for the uterus)



The same technique applies to working with the lower chambers, although concentration needs to be more focused, and it is important to feel the direction, and consistency of the flow. Unless proper concentration has been achieved, the orbit along the 8-shaped field will not be felt, and movement will be circular. Each plane must be worked through separately.

Liberating the Purple Palace

The purpose of this technique is to relax the heart and the chest. It consists of alternate protuberance and bending in and out, of the chest, done thirty six times. When the breast is curved inwards, the heart is being relaxed, and when curved forward, the breasts are being relaxed.

It is recommended to practice these given preparatory exercises (Septenary orbits & Liberating Purple Palace) for three months before beginning the main preparatory practice. This relates to the energy redistribution process known as the Microcosmic Orbit Practice.

It is good to start and finish these exercises with light tapping or massaging of the whole body. It will serve to activate energetic circulation. It is important to take these practices seriously. All that you use in the initial stages may be equally useful later on.

In order for this technique to fulfil its function, it is important not to marginalise the initial stages of your work. It should be considered as an independent practice.

The major task of the following lower orbit (gamma orbit) practice, is to create a condition for the elixir gathering in the lower abdomen, to be transformed later into an Immortal Embryo.

This orbit also takes part in the creation of the basis for the alchemical body, which is lacking in women (but not in men). In the initial stages, this support is linked with the feet (to be examined in a later chapter), and with the chest. The chest region, particularly the mammary glands, produce essential energies that enter the heart and

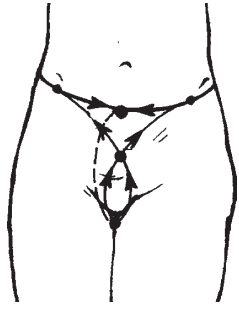
subsequently enter the blood. Then they are transported to the liver. This *jing* energy from the mammary glands is transformed in the liver, and together with *ling-qi* energy (formed in the lymph) forms a building block for the formation of groundwork in the region of the *Hui Yin* centre.

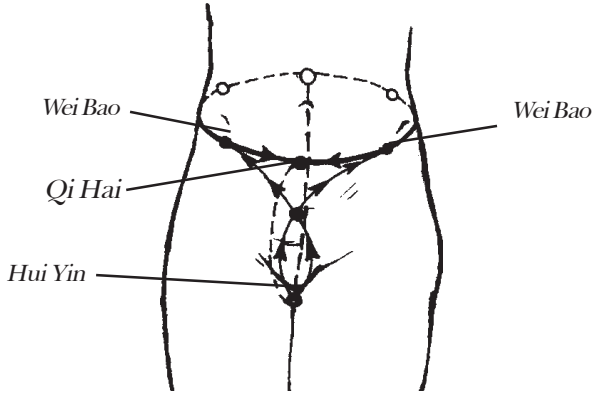
This period is characterised by a change in duration and quality of the menstrual cycle, even of its disappearance. From this moment on women must concentrate on forming a yang structure more actively.

In the initial stage, in order to create conditions for manufacturing and interlinking the *jing* energy, women must use additional methods to link, strengthen and redistribute energies in the womb and the mammary glands.

γ-orbit or the Orbit of the womb

This is the orbit to connect the womb and the waist meridian. Working with the γ–orbit, or womb orbit it is necessary, to strengthen the womb, so that later it will become a part of the *jing* production process. Awareness of the feelings and sensations of this orbit indicates that conditions for development of the alchemical meridian have been created (see «*The Alchemy of Tai Ji*»).

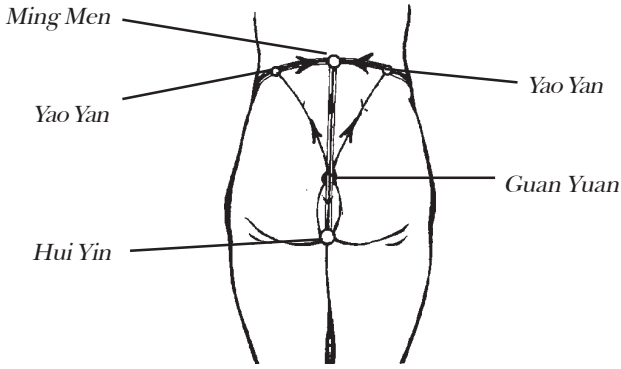




This orbit starts and finishes in the *Hui Yin* centre. As we exhale, we direct the flow of energy movement along the two channels from the *Hui Yin* centre to the *Guan Yuan* centre. Then from the *Guan Yuan* centre the flow along the left channel is directed to the *Wei Bao* centre, the other flow is along the right channel to another symmetrically located centre, also called the *Wei Bao*. Energy then flows down to the *Qi Hai* centre along the middle part of the abdomen and, finally, as we inhale, it returns to the *Hui Yin* centre.

The second aspect of this orbit starts on exhalation in the *Hui Yin* centre. From there it also flows up along two channels to the *Guan Yuan* centre. These two flows are then directed to both *Yao Yan* centres. These centres are connected to both *Wei Bao* centres, but are located on the opposite side of the waist region.

They are difficult to feel, if they have not been activated. Their location can be approximated by putting the palm of the hand to the *Ming Men* centre (at the back), or to the *Qi Hai* centre (in the front). The index finger is placed on one of these centres. The second centre is symmetrical to the first.

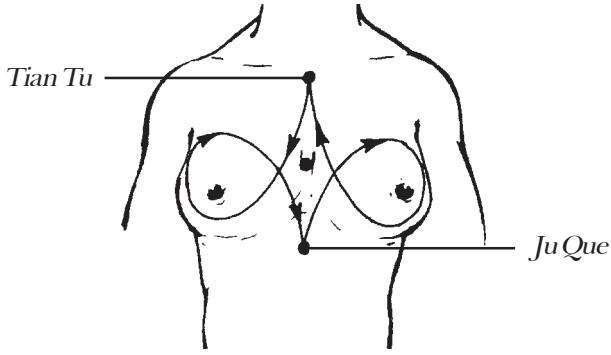


From the *Yao Yan* centres the flow is directed to the *Ming Men* centre. As we inhale, it goes back to the *Hui Yin* centre along the middle back meridian.

Thus, as these two circles alternate and form a singular orbit, they lock into the *Hui Yin* centre. At the initial stage this orbit can be practised without consideration for breathing. When a woman practices this orbit technique, she will start feeling a pulsation in her womb. If this pulsation can be controlled, this indicates that energy has been gathered, linked and is ready for preservation and for further development.

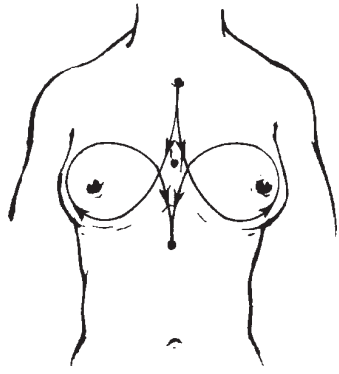
α–orbit or Mammary gland orbit

The α–orbit and the mammary gland orbit is also referred to as the «orbit that strengthens the connection with rhythm». It is connected to the energy produced by the mammary glands. As a result of the practice, this energy is redirected into a definite configuration of movement which can reinforce and transform the body's *qi*.



The flow commences in the *Tian Tu* centre. Then it circles the right breast, and goes down to the *Ju Que* centre and returns to circulate the left breast. Finally it returns to the *Tian Tu* centre.

There is another way to practice using this orbit technique. Two streams flow simultaneously: one circles from the inside to the outside of one breast and other circles around the other breast. These circular streams come to the *Ju Que* centre and then flow in opposite directions to the *Tian Tu* centre.



Connections between the orbit and the mammary glands takes place when practitioners become aware of feeling the orbit.

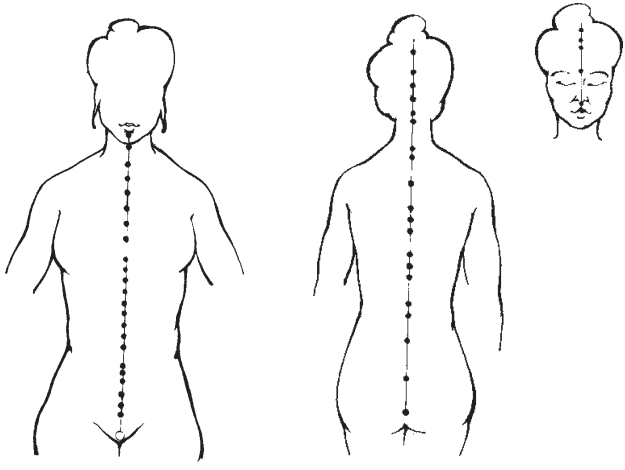
It is better not to connect the spinning of this orbit with the breathing, because it will connect into the *qi* of the lungs. This can complicate your practice as the energy of the breath has not yet been balanced out. This will lead to increased Po spirit influences. (See *«Thirty two rotations of the crucible»*.)

In this section we have examined strengthening orbits that will help women in their preparation for the Microcosmic Orbit.

The Microcosmic Orbit

When there is a shift in energy in the reservoir filled with *qi* energy, Taoist Alchemy refers to this concept as the Microcosmic Orbit or Little Heavenly cycle (*xiao zhou tian*). This energy circulates and governs the creation of conditions for the transformation of *qi* into *jing*, and *jing* into *shen* energy.

Ancient Taoist texts talk about two important vessels in this cultivation, which must have a natural and controlled circulation. They refer to the Middle Back and Middle Front meridians. The Middle Back meridian, *Du Mai*, is the Governing Vessel, which runs medially down the back. All the other centrifugal meridians are linked to this meridian. The other is the Conception Vessel, *Ren Mai*, which links all the other centripetal meridians.



Middle Back Meridian *Front Back Meridian*

Normal work on given meridians and the circulation of *qi* energy through them is a pre-requisite for alchemical transformation. Yet it is still not sufficient. Acquired circulation cannot always be used for cultivation purposes, while certain induced conditions can distract the practitioner from actually practising. This relates to the fact that the created energy flow also nourishes the organs, which cannot produce *jing* energy independently. As a result, practitioners become dependent on manifested sensations.

You may wonder whether it is wrong for these organs to produce energy necessary for further work? There is nothing wrong with this, it is a natural process. However energy produced in this way is still out of control and is likely to be dissipated. This energy can only be directed when the practitioner masters production, division and control over this energy.

The first step toward further energy regulation is control over its circulation in the Microcosmic Orbit. Additionally, this work will optimally assist the development of concentration, which is a pre-requisite for further transformations. This practice also leads to the reverse connection, when the orbit begins to nourish consciousness, thus forming the *shen* spirit.

In Taoist Alchemy the Microcosmic Orbit is a very important concept. The reason for this is that it is the only prepared *qi*, which can change the conditions of energy development within the human body. Also it is only this *qi* which has been controlled, and most importantly, directed. Later this will lead to the possibility of working with alchemical ingredients, or the five main forms of *jing* energy. This energy production occurs in the liver, kidneys, lungs and the

heart. The fifth energy – the spleen-*jing* represents a foundation for further intertwining these energies into the Immortal body.

Attempts to work with *jing* energy by utilising its inherent qualities via the means of either the sperm or blood will prove to be fruitless. This is because it is necessary to do preparatory work with the organs for the actual intertwining to take place. Actually, it is easy to harm oneself by various experiments, which can even lead to a loss of energy already existing.

The Microcosmic Orbit creates conditions for energy cultivation that are the basis for further alchemical work. Nevertheless we must look at this task of cultivation, from the viewpoint of what is possible in our given time. If women live within society, maintaining an active lifestyle, then their work with the Microcosmic Orbit is distinctly different to that of men. When the initial step is to increase their Yang energy, while simultaneously participating in society, then they will find that these combined conditions will activate the process of growth, but will also lead to a burning out of large quantities of natural energy.

By emphasising this point, we are offering each woman the information to make her own conscious and earnest decision, by not defining it as right or wrong; or referring to this or that development line. This will help her to be adaptable in her practice and be ready to correct her mistakes.

If women choose to remain within society, avoiding going to a deserted monastery in the initial stages of her practice; then she must first strengthen her Yin before her Yang energy can be cultivated. Yang energy can be cultivated simultaneously, without damaging the primal *Yuan qi* energy. However, it is necessary to note one more time

here that strengthening of Yin energy does not imply its cultivation. It is very important to be clear about this concept which we refer back to throughout the whole book. The strengthening of Yin energy is connected with energy regulation of the essence, which formed women's nature in general. This allows women to develop.

Methods to strengthen yin energies, however, are not accepted by three out of four main Taoist branches. The traditional cultivation is related to increasing Yang energies as the basis for transformation and immortality. These branches take into account constancy of work, designed especially to increase the force connected with Yang energy. There are Yin strengthening techniques there, but they do not go further than body positions, e.g. specific body positions for practising meditation. Firstly it is important to realise that these schools of thought accepted predominantly male disciples, and secondly, if women were admitted they were chosen because they did not need to stabilise their yin energy, as they were already following the path according to Prenatal Heaven. For example, young girls practising these techniques came from simple family environments that were a part of the Taoist tradition. Very often they had extraordinary experiences, yet it was their life prior to the commencement of serious work. Thus, conception energy did not change its positive vector, i.e. female practitioners were ready for further cultivation work from the inception.

These same principles are also the foundation of many Taoist schools today, but it is always the readiness of the practitioner that is taken into consideration. When we consider that 90% of contemporary people are not ready to develop naturally (having lost their true essence), then we must accept that it is difficult for them to find

themselves correctly – even though the course of action may appear clear. It is important to take a note of these details because many classical-method practitioners imagine that their practices will lead them to maximally beneficial results, believing that their practice is correct. In reality they are just preparing (unavoidably), but mistake it for the actual practice. As a result in 3-5 years many of them become disappointed because they did not understand what they had been working on. If female practitioners can accept this, things can progress. However, if they are unwilling to accept that everything they have been doing for years was just preparatory work, this is a far worse situation. This could stop them from continuing the practice.

Here she must confront her personal 'I', which is not neutralised, but on the contrary has even been strengthened by the realisation that the practice (and not the preparation) is the only correct path. However when women are ready to embrace the path of classical alchemical transformation, their natural energies do not hinder them, and all their desires are channelled towards transformation. From this point she must follow the path of yang energy cultivation (see *'Taoist Alchemy for Men'*).

There are a few variations in orbit practice, offered by Taoist schools. Before examining them however, let's try to understand the reason for such diversity. As each school began developing its own rhythm, new techniques were created following this rhythm, yet also strengthening and deepening the forms of energy work. It must be taken into account that female energy movement differs from men's, and has uniquely different characteristics. The work on the organs is different. Although there is a certain common vector for both men

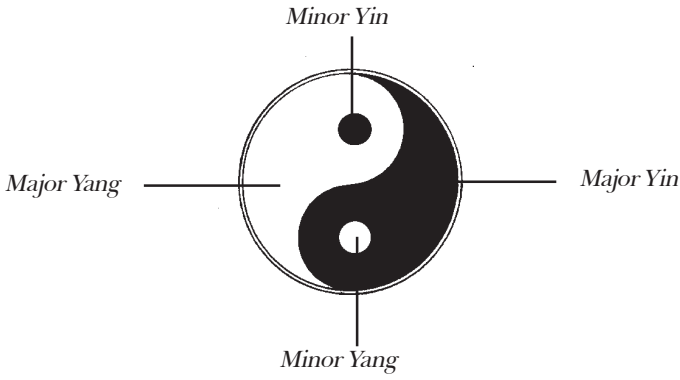
and women, the conditions formed by the Earth and Sky are different for women.

The main criteria for energy formation in women is connected with the rhythm of three organs: the liver, womb and spleen. We suggest working with energy techniques that can help women to understand the concept of the functional rhythm of these organs. Their energy production and influence they have on other organs and vessels occur at the next stage. This is why we offer a technique which 'grabs yin energy'. On the one hand to inhibit the development of yin energy, on the other to strengthen the basis of yin energy i.e. the yang quality of yin energy, which is manifested just in strengthening of organs and body.

It must be recognised that Yang energy also contains Yin energy and vice versa. In the beginning of the practice, it is recommended to use these energetic qualities of Minor Yang and Minor Ying. If we can accept the concept that Yang and Yin energies are not mutually exclusive, but are, rather, mutually inclusive, then we can begin to discriminate between the actions these energies exert. For as long as a practitioner is not ready to work correctly with the energy as a whole, the concept that Yang and Yin retain their exclusive states is provisional.

With the beginning of transformation and commencement of *jing* energy development, the container will become more important than its definition in relation to yang and yin concepts. Taoist alchemy defines energy in a specific way in order to prevent the practitioner from becoming attached to the natural content of these energies, instead to show their transforming qualities. Therefore, it is easier to

refer to this *jing* energy work allegorically, relating the concepts to tiger and dragon, or lead and mercury images. These allegories hide far more meaning than the simple juxtaposition of Yin and Yang concepts.

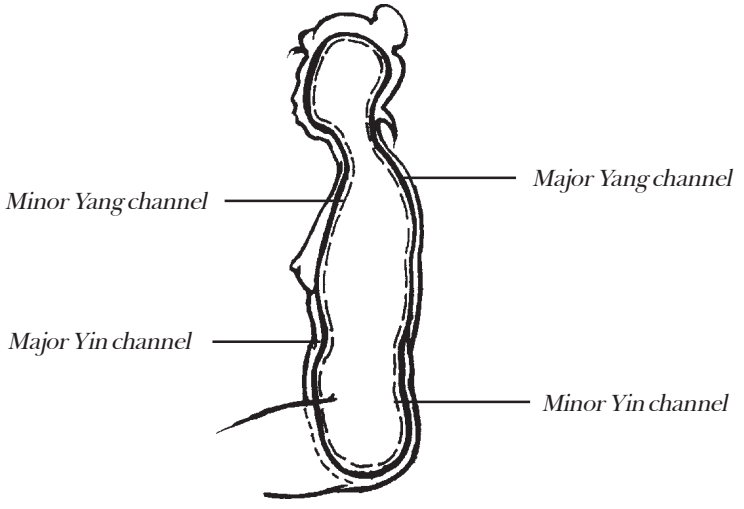


Although Yin and Yang concepts show us the differences, they may not always lead us to a feeling of change. For example if the hand becomes cold, we could refer to this state as a yin indicator, or if it becomes sweaty, it could be a yang indicator. Nevertheless it is still simply that, an indicator. What is important is the process itself, which creates the conditions for the manifestation of a given energy. Each of us is created with both Yin and Yang energies. The more refined our Yin energy work becomes, the better the conditions are created for increasing the Yang energy.

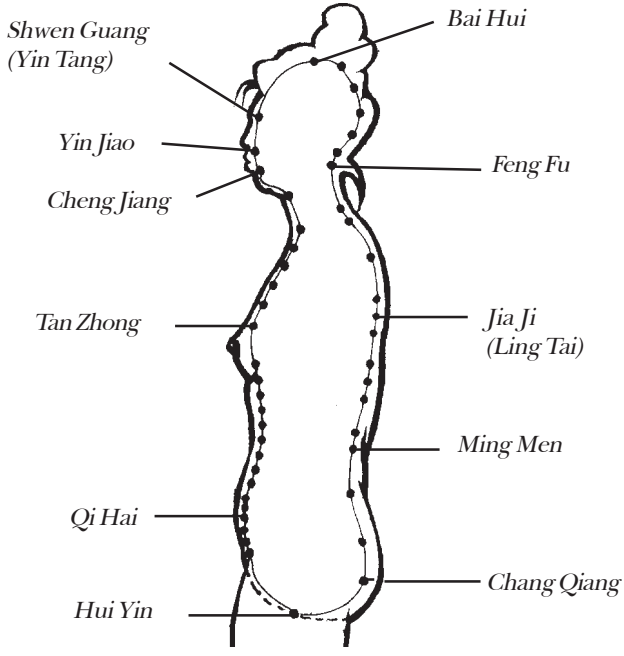
The Yin energy forms the channels which will later contain the finer *jing* energy that again, will later create the immortal body. When these channels are incorrectly formed, they are referred to as a 'body affected by Yin'. The female body from nature is built on Yin energy, which forms naturally cultivated *jing* energy. Knowing that

the Yang energy is the basis of male manifestation of energy, it follows that Yin is the basis of female manifestation of energy. At this point we must try to understand what kind of Yin energy forms *jing* energy. *Jing* is directional energy and can only be formed by the action of Yang directional energy. So, when we say that *jing* energy is formed by Yin energy, we're referring to the yang aspect of Yin energy, i.e. yang energy is present inside Yin energy.

This is not an easy concept, yet we must bring it to your attention in order to explain why women need to rotate their orbit in the opposite direction to the general energy flow. When we rotate the orbit in the other direction, we prohibit the active development of Yin energy because this is the energy women have in abundance. Here we also prohibit the active development of Yang energy as this process can lead to a burning of our own nature.



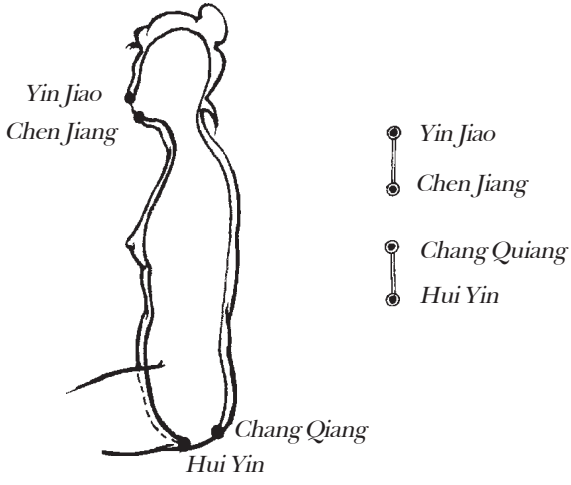
Thus we seize yin energy in a yang channel (The Governing Vessel), and yang energy in a yin channel (The Conception Vessel). Combined these help produce the fine yin energy (yang quality of yin energy also known as Yin-yang or Yang of Yin), which forms the basis of *jing* energy production. Many women, who rotate their orbit following this practice, notice that their orbit begins to rotate in the opposite direction. This is normal and indicates that concentrated work with Minor Yin and Minor Yang is being done correctly. In any case energy will direct itself in the appropriate way, and we should not inhibit this natural flow. Our aim is to regulate aspects of our energy which improve the conditions for both further and finer work toward our self-transformation.



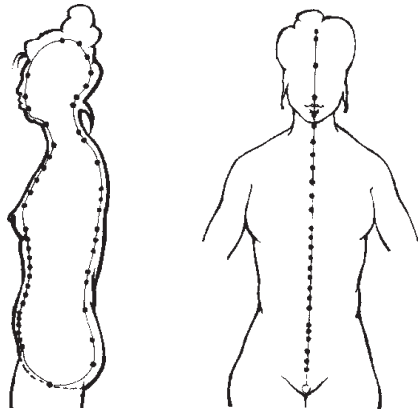
The Middle Front meridian commences in the *Hui Yin* centre and finishes in the *Cheng Jiang* centre. The Middle Back meridian commences in the *Chang Qiang* centre and finishes in the *Yin Jiao* centre. The points along the Middle Front meridian are responsible for yin energy work. This meridian is considered to be the most active in yin energy preparation. Taking this into account, it becomes clear that we have to activate the energy as a whole, regulate it and then prepare the centres and channels for further work with finer energies.

Connection of meridians via the *Peng* force

Here we examine the minimal distance between the energy flow of the meridians. At the top, the meridians are connected by means of the tongue and saliva and below, by the tension in the perineum. This tension should not be forced.

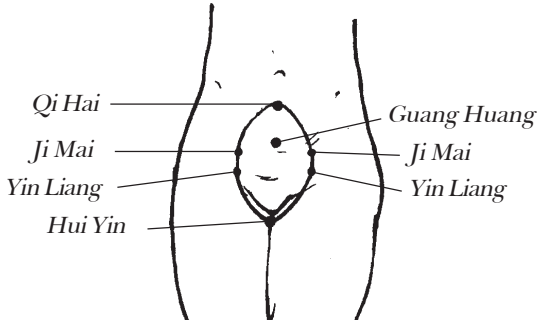


So, the orbit looks like the following:



Connection of meridians via the *An* force

Here the orbit looks slightly different.



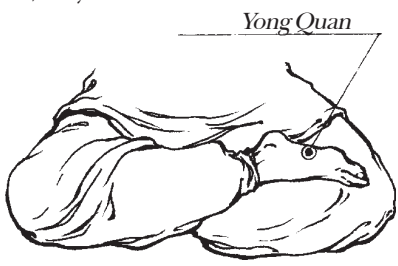
The energy flows from the *Hui Yin* centre, along two channels to the *Qi Hai* centre. Then from *Qi Hai,* it flows up to the *Cheng Jiang* centre. From here, along two channels to the *Shwen Guang* (*Yin Tang*) centre. At this point the energy flow continues along the Middle Back

channel, through to the *Bai Hui* centre and down to the *Hui Yin* centre.

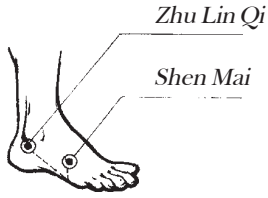
The practice with the first orbit (with the *Peng* force connection) is based on stabilisation of circulation in the Middle Back meridian. In this case (the *An* force connection) the work connects to control of the blood. The reason here is that it includes the liver and pericardium channels more actively. Work with this orbit is recommended for practitioners in the initial stages, as it assists in the development of blood *qi*. At this point we'll try to examine this orbit in more detail.

We also note here that the pericardium channel is activated by an interlocking technique during the practice. This meridian is the 'Mother of the blood' and the liver meridian is the 'Father of the blood'.

In order to enrich the energy of the pericardium, lightly turn and press the *Lao Gong* centre with your thumb (*Shao Shang* centre of the lung meridian) as you inhale.

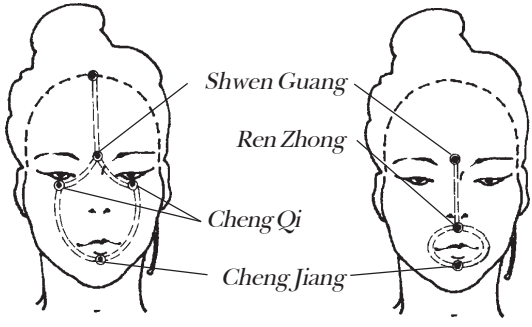


The Yong Quan centre is the source of energy nourishment. It is situated in the centre of the sole of the foot and the energy can be gathered by curling the toes. This pulls the energy from the *Zu Lin Qi* and *Shen Mai* centres to the *Yong Quan* centre.

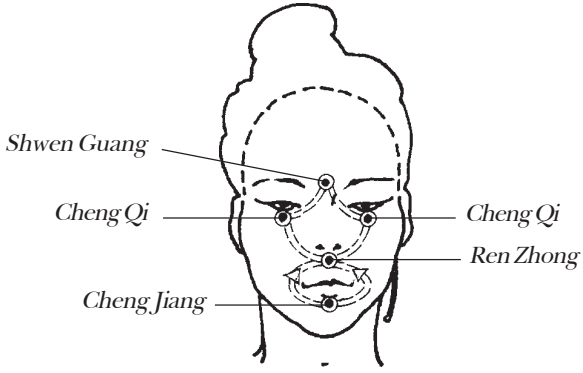


It is necessary to become aware of the sensations in these centres in order to link the feet with the *Supreme centre*. Only with this link then will it become possible to change the energy in the bladder meridian which controls the Yard of *Po* spirits (*Po Hu*), and the gall bladder meridian, (which is connected with the feet channel).

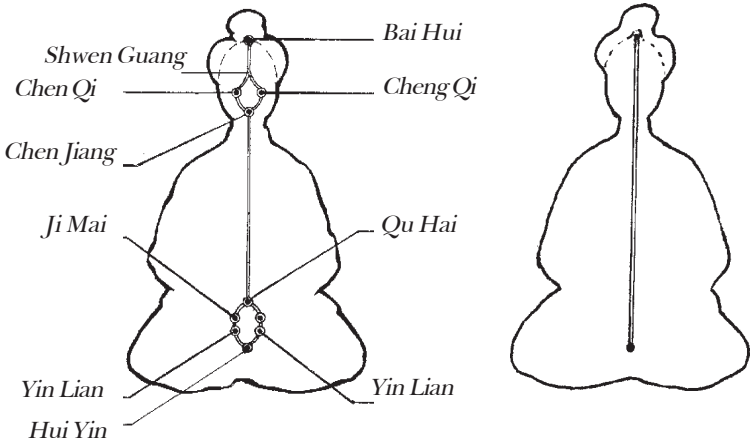
Then we connect the Middle Front meridian with the Yard of *Hun* spirits. *Hun* spirits are connected with the liver, and directly with the *Yin Lian* and *Ji Mai* centres. The energy flows up (a Minor *Yang* movement is implied) into the *Cheng Jiang* centre, connecting with *Zhi She* (House of Will) and *Yi She* (House of Mind). It forms the connection between the *shen* of the spleen and the *shen* of the kidneys.



Connection between the meridians via the *An* Force from the *Cheng Jiang* centre can follow in different ways depending on the centres involved. Firstly, we create a connection through the *Cheng Qi* or *Ren Zhong* centres. Then a more complicated type can be practised: *Cheng Jiang* centre connects with the *Ren Zhong* centre, then with *Cheng Qi* centre, then with *Shwen Guang* (*Yin Tang*) centre.



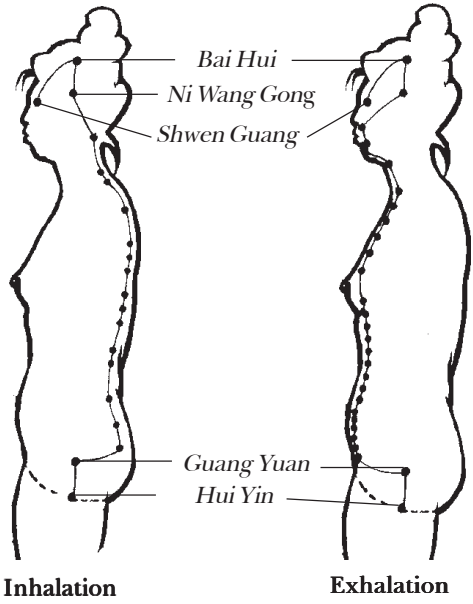
The connection between the *Bai Hui* centre and the *Shwen Guang* (*Yin Tang*) centre takes place either directly (which is better



initially), or via the *Ni Wang Gong* centre. From the *Bai Hui* centre (as previously described), Minor *Yin* energy moves along the Middle Back meridian, down to the Hui Yin centre.

When we can become aware of the movement via this orbit, we can link it to the α and γ orbits.

If you use the connection of meridians via the Peng force, including the *Ni Wang Gong* centre in circulation, the orbit will look like this:



We have examined some variants of the Microcosmic Orbit practice, which are suitable for female practitioners who are trying to regulate their Minor *Yang* and *Yin*. As a result of this practice, female practitioners acquire control of the *Yin Jiao Mai* meridian (the

meridian, that moves yin energy). At this point they may begin to form yang energy and expand *Shen Tan* (place of the spirit).

The traditional concept identifies inhalation as *Yin* and exhalation as *Yang* (which is a necessary division agreed upon in the initial states of alchemy). As we know the movement upwards is *Yang* and the movement downwards is *Yin*. So exhalation should correspond to the natural energy current's upward flow along the Middle Back meridian. However the turning of this orbit is examined along the direction, opposite the energy current. So, exhalation corresponds to the flow of movement upward but along the Middle Front meridian, whereas inhalation corresponds to the flow of movement down along the Middle Back meridian.

Generally, regarding breathing we firstly regulate the energy, secondly fill the breath with it, and then, by means of the breath, we move the energy.

Additional Peculiarities on Working with the Microcosmic Orbit

We also should point out the peculiarities of practice with orbits at various times. This relates particularly to rhythm work. It is important for women to define and distinguish between even and uneven days in their practice. This can be connected to week days, or to lunar days (which are more accurate, although perhaps more confusing). If the day is even, then a woman's practice relates to Yin, if the day is uneven it relates to Yang.

This alternation is necessary to work further with this rhythm. If the focus of action each day is done without the correct rhythmic

rehabilitation, then it may actually worsen the effect of the practice especially if the practice is performed incorrectly.

From this standpoint it is recommended women work with the orbit for development of the blood *qi (*described earlier) on the even days. On uneven days to work with the womb and wais*t* orbit (γ orbit) and mammary glands orbit (α orbit).

If the waist meridian practice is included in a right way, energies will be screwed and unscrewed along the kidney region. From this point, the practice should be modified because the waist meridian reaches its right function and starts to feed the *Supreme centre*.

If conditions to form the *Supreme centre* have not been created yet, then the level of inclusion will also not have been reached, and consequently, the practice could inhibit this action.

Practices that include waist meridian work are *Bagua Zhang*, *Taiji Quan* and *Xing Yi Quan*. Opening this meridian is a prerequisite for assimilating these practices correctly. This is why women use these techniques, not only for restructuring energy redistribution and abdomen relaxation, but also for maximising the productive effects for the waist meridian.

This meridian begins to perform its function, when conditions for the formation of the *Supreme centre* have been created. At this point then, it becomes necessary to begin practicing with Major *Yang* and Major *Yin*, while Minor *Yang* and Minor *Yin* practices are focussed just on the womb and waist meridian orbit (γ orbit) and mammary glands orbit (α orbit).

As soon as this has been achieved, it is no longer is necessary to rotate the orbit in the other direction, because the opposite orbit is only used to stabilise the over active yang energy. It does not mean

that we have to actively increase yang energy via Major *Yang* - Major *Yin* orbit. It simply means that the work needs modification according to individual requirements.

There are two more points to be noted here connected with meditation practices. The first is the body position during meditation, and the second concerns specific breathing techniques. We will not examine specific breathing techniques here, as they may be more disruptive to women than men. This is connected with increased concentration on breathing. If breathing has not been regulated, and we become dependent on it as a result of increased concentration, it will automatically activate and increase *Po* spirits. We describe the most important peculiarities concerning natural breathing for women in the chapter relating to *Tao Yin*.

Positions for Meditation

The main principles:

1. Pay attention to the base of your body, the legs. The feet, knees and hips should be positioned in relation to the Yin-Moon in such a way that it allows reconnecting the links in the horizontal plane. This will help to relax the abdomen, which is the "key" to the whole practice.

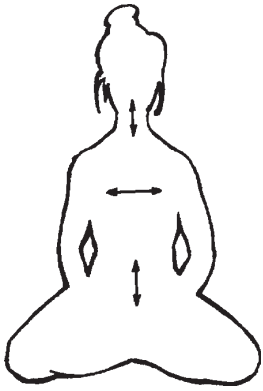
This means that the pelvis must be slightly higher than the crossed legs. The position of the legs can either be "cross-legged", "lotus" or "semi-lotus". Chose whichever is the most comfortable position for you to sit in for long a period of time. The right leg must be on top of the left one.

2. It is important for the pelvis to be above the legs; with the space between the sexual organs and the anus not being squashed, but free.

One of the pre-requisites for correct practice (especially for inclusion of the womb orbit and waist meridian in the overall process), is the normal circulation in the legs and base of the torso.

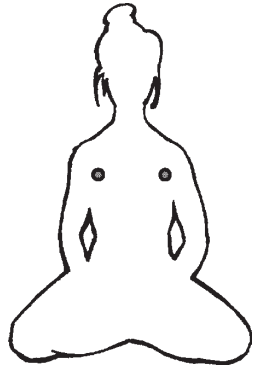
3. Pay attention to the position of the torso in relation to Yang-Moon, in order to restructure the links in the vertical plane. Stretch out the lower part of the spine and the neck, along the vertical line: and the region between the shoulder blades along the horizontal line, so that the energy will not stagnate in the "three gates".

Open up the sacrum and waist region and fill these with energy. The energy must flow up without any obstacles (from the *Chang Qiang* centre, through to the *Hui Yin* and *Qi Hai* centres). Relax and open the area between the shoulder blades, freeing the energy to flow into *Jia Ji*. Pull the top of the head up. Slightly press the chin inwards and stretch the neck region out, in order to open the base of the skull and the centre of *Feng Fu*.



4. Do not lift the shoulders up (a characteristic mistake made by many), but lower them down - not internally by squeezing the chest, but in a relaxed way, so the energy will naturally flow down via the elbows.

5. The chest should neither protrude forward nor be pulled inward. One of the important points to remember is not to cover the points near the cavities of the armpits. Women often block these points by pushing the chest forward. This will not only inhibit the relaxation of the chest region, but will also prevent the chest (especially the mammary glands), from being filled with energy.



Those who favour a so-called "proud" posture, create their own problems, not only from the point of view of their practice, but also from the point of view of health. This posture effects the mammary glands, which can generally lead to such diseases as mastitis.

6. According to classical traditions, the knees must be protected from the "evil wind". Which is why Taoist monks use clothes that protect the knees during meditation. If you don't cover your knees with a cloth, then it is better to put your arms on them.

7. If you want to lock your palms, connect them in the following way:

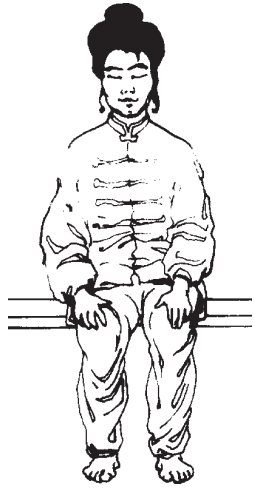
The right palm is in the left, the left thumb is in the *Lao Gong* centre of the right palm, connect the index finger and thumb of the right hand, forming a monad. Another version of this exercise is when the right palm is placed in the left one and the thumbs are locked in.

8. The tongue is touching the palate, while the jaw is relaxed.

9. The eyes are half closed, the glance not fixed, but looking into a point in front, no further than an outstretched arm, and no closer than the tip of the nose. It is best not to close the eyes at all, as this may distract you from real practice, supplementing it with the manifesting images of closed eyes.

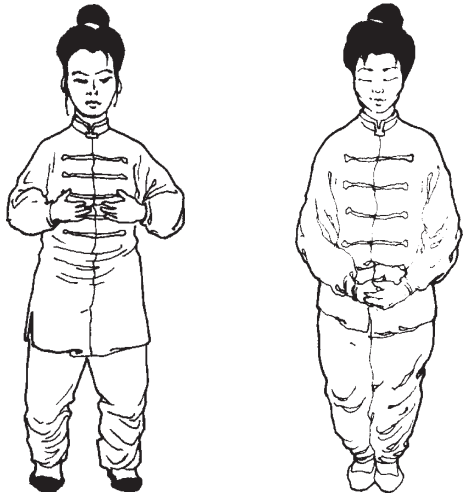
When you begin meditation practices, you may use other positions rather than "cross-legged", "lotus' or "semi-lotus'. However, the best position for the locking is the "lotus' (*Tian Pan*). It provides better control and more concentrated work, but only if the leg energies have been regulated, otherwise the normal circulation may be inhibited in this position. This is why it is best to sit either in the "cross-legged", or "semi-lotus" to start with.

If you have difficulty sitting in any of these positions, then you should start by sitting in a chair. In a chair, the feet need to be parallel, in order to contain the feet energies.

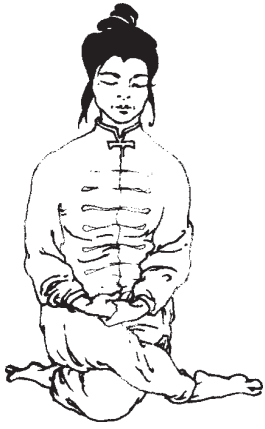


There is also a lying position for older people. One of the arms is placed under the head and the legs are slightly crossed over.

A standing position may also be used. Although it will not tie up the energy, but will enable the channels to function normally. A standing position may also be useful later for practice with the Major orbit. The second position showed here (the feet are together) may not be used for meditation practice but it has the special meaning of *Wu Ji* (No Extremity).



As well as this, classical schools also offer a position for women who gave birth in the past. It is called the position of *Kua He*, or the "crane". All women should use this position who have had sexual contact with men. It is a position that is also used during menstruation.



In this position the horizontal basis is minimised in order to avoid "catching" the yin energies of the earth. This technique is used in monasteries by those who had sexual contacts, until the time of 'cutting of the dragon' or stopping of the menstruation.

Young women also use this while menstruating, until 'cutting off the dragon'. This practice is important for us, because it "seals" the body into that moment when it tends to lose its fine energies, gathering rough, unrefined energies instead.

There is one other position that can be used for the same purpose, which is to sit on a foot and connect the *Yong Quan* point with the perineum.

Nevertheless, serious practitioners should remember that the "lotus' position gives the best results. When preparatory work has been done correctly, the body and legs will be ready for this position. A serious practitioner should practice using only *Tian Pan* ("lotus") position by the age of 42. On the other hand, it is not recommended that women under the age of 28 use this position very often, as it is connected with the active cultivation of *Yang* energies. *Yang* energy needs to be prepared for cultivation, meaning that the correct *Yin* work must be completed. If your *Yin* has not been redistributed, it will "catch" the Yin energy of the earth, and be activated by the Yang process, and in turn will interfere with it. Initially the "cross-legged", or "semi-lotus" positions are good enough.

Seven-year cycles are important for women to note. If you maintain the rhythm of each cycle by not forcing events working in a *yin* period (a female cycle between 21-28) with *yang* energies; then by the age of 35 (at "the transitional point"), you will be able to intertwine *jing* energy in the most effective way. This is the time when women can begin to form the Immortal Embryo.

In certain schools 35 years of age is considered as 'a point of growing old', yet this is not so for those who chose a monastic way of life. This is the moment when women can prepare the 'matured' energy in the best possible way. It is much more important for women to commence their alchemical practice at the correct time.

Massage after meditation

A special massage may be used after meditation. This will help the energetic vessels to adopt the energy activated in the process of the practice, (see '*Thirty Two rotations of the crucible*' in the chapter on the '*Vessels of a human body*'.) This massage is connected with preparations for such vessels as the feet, knees, abdomen, kidneys, chest and head to intertwine the energy later. The massage begins at the head.

Chatter your teeth 36 times and whip up the saliva, referred to as "liquid jade". It is considered an important substance in Taoist traditions, which is necessary for preserving. Swallow slowly, bringing it down to the *Qi Hai* and lubricating the organs. Before beginning the following massage, rub your palms until they become hot. Use soft circular movements to massage your face 36 times (don't pull the skin). Rub your thumb bones and use them to massage the eyes to the sides, 9 times.

Again rub the thumbs and massage the "wings" of the nose, nine times. Movements should be slow and even, so that the energy can nourish those parts of the face. Both thumbs are placed on the chin, and the little fingers pull out and let go of the ear appendix, repeating 9 times. Massage your ear lobes and then their whole surface. Press the palms to your ears with the tips of the fingers on the back of

the head. The index fingers are placed on the middle fingers, then let go by using a tapping movement and making the ears vibrate - you are "beating into the Heavenly Drum".

Once again, rub your palms and stroke your hair region 36 times, then tap your head with the tips of your fingers. Rub the base of the skull with both hands, and then rub the front part of the neck. If you are wearing thin clothes (or no clothes at all), then softly massage the whole neck region.

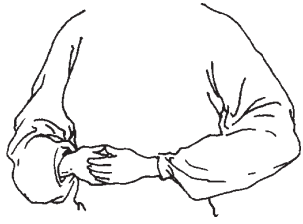
Rub your palms and gently without any pressure massage your chest – circular movements from inside the breast to the top, from outside the bottom, and vice versa – 36 times in both directions. Then connect your palms under the chest, with fingers directed forward, thus gathering the energy in the centres of the palms. Separate the palms and connect the centres of the palms with the nipples and on exhalation gently press (9 times). Then connect your palms together, position them on the stomach and softly massage, relaxing and filling it.

Place your palms on the kidneys and massage them with circular movements towards the centre. Then massage your legs with continuous movement from kidneys to the front of the legs all the way down, and back up – on the rear of the legs up to kidneys. Repeat 5 times.

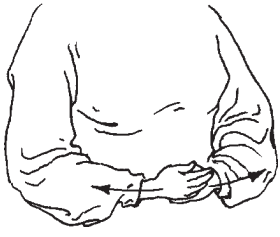
Massage, helping the vessels of the liver, kidneys, spleen, lungs and heart to assimilate the energy

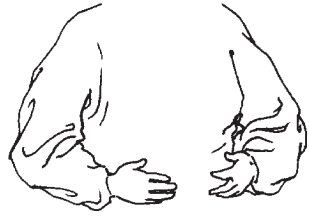
This massage can be done after the meditation as well as a separate practice. It is especially important for women in their preparation to adopt their personal rhythm during menstruation period.

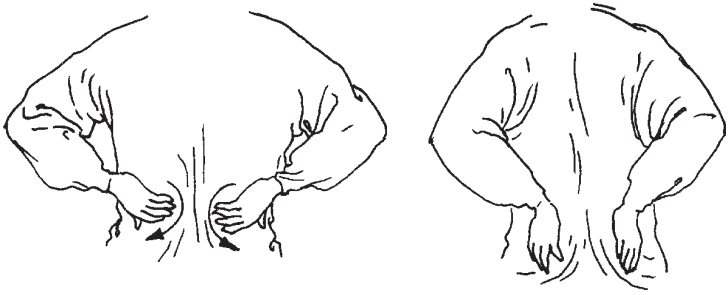
For the *liver*- tapping massage, so as not to constrict corresponding spirit as a result of yin energy influence. Left palm is placed on the right, and softly tap using impulse from the whole body.



For the *spleen* – extending movements. From the centre of the spleen disperse energy to the sides. Your movements should be soft and natural. Try to avoid tension in the shoulders and elbows.







For *kidneys* – screwing in movements. We do not let *Yuan-qi* to dissipate together with the blood. Place Lao Gun centres on the kidneys and make a screwing in movement to the centre, with a slight pressure.

For the *lungs* – holding/grasping position. To stop Po spirits from becoming activated. Both hands are on the upper chest, then move them to the sides, stopping the movement on the breast. Palms are open and the movement is made without pressure.

For the *heart* – circular stroking, calming down, relaxing. The movement is very slow with minimal amplitude. It is important not to have any tension in the arms, breasts and shoulders in order not to cause an excessive energy flow to the heart.

You should spend between 15 to 30 minutes for this practice.

Practising these techniques requires serious attitude, as they are important preparation exercises for your yin organs to produce *jing* energy later.

The Treatise about Changing the Muscles and Tendons for the Weak

«*The Treatise about Changing the Muscles and Tendons for the Weak*» not only addresses tendon development (see: «*The Treatise about Changing the Muscles and Tendons for the Strong*»), but talks especially of the quality of binding between the bones, tendons and muscles.

Taoists working to improve the quality of this connection strengthen the body and invigorate its spirit. In this case supporting the energetic activity around the tendons does not deplete the spirit. On the contrary, spirit gets the necessary energy from them and finer, essential *jing* energy is produced, being the most appropriate substance for the body.

By examining given female techniques from an alchemical viewpoint, we want to demonstrate that, for women, it is very important to define the connection in the body (between tendons and muscles

or tendons and bones), and then to develop it later. «The treatise about changing the muscles/tendons for the strong»on the other hand, initially examines the development of tendons as a criteria for energy accumulation and maintenance.

The conditions for developing *jing* energy differ between men and women. When women develop *jing* according to male laws, they use the accepted and perhaps, the correct vector, but their possibilities are limited. They may obtain longevity by strengthening and reinforcing their *qi*, but will not be able to increase their *shen* spirit.

In fact this may even decrease, because their finer energies would then transform into denser ones, in order to support their life force in preference to their spirituality. Thus many women doing various practices develop vitality, yet mistake it for spiritual power. Although these processes are interrelated, real development is defined by working with *fa jing*. This is an even finer energy that can be directed, and not just produced.

When, through practice, we can produce and sustain *jing* energy, our quality of existence increases and improves. It becomes comparable to that of a beautiful flower. However, as soon as this flower is transported to another place it will change, and all the effort would be directed toward survival. Spiritual power and a spiritual state, it must be remembered, are different concepts. Spiritual power is always accompanied by a high spiritual state. Whereas a spiritual state is a prerequisite for obtaining spiritual power, but only when sufficient *jing* energy has been transformed in order to form the spiritual power.

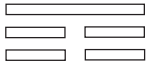
So, the basis of the practice is the increase and subsequent strengthening of *jing*. Original *qi* is subordinate to form-creating

energy Yin. Original *jing* is subordinate to the Force – *Yin* & *Yang* energies. Original *shen* is subordinate to Yang energy, which transforms, cultivates and uplifts. When we come to differentiating between practices on the basis of male and female leanings, we consider the energetic *yin* and *yang* properties overall, rather than separately. Although the separation becomes apparent, when we consider that when men want to improve conditions for *jing* energy formation, they may need to do some female practices (in some form). The same also applies for women.

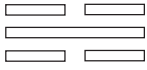
The ability to combine these practices is the art of alchemy. Only those who follow a path of development for spiritual power can use it. This path requires one to take responsibility for their actions. It is important to remember that the main criterion on this path is the attainment of internal peace. This state of internal peace, or clarity, is a high level of achievement, yet it is only part of the journey.

The practice of *Yjin-jing* for the weak addresses conditions that lead to strengthening of spiritual power at a later point. Women find energy concepts easier to understand then men, as their experience of energetic activity is much stronger because of their high sensibility. Once they understand the concept, they can begin forming conditions to control their *jing* energies.

Earth or basis formation - tendons

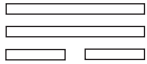


Consciousness formation

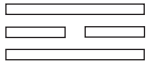


Power formation

Foundation formation, and change of emotional perception of the world

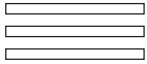


Work with rhythms



Control and management of *yin* organs, *Tao Yin*

Change of energetic foundation of the body from *yin* to *yang*



Cultivation of the Immortal Embryo

At first glance it may seem that women undergo an additional cycle in their preparation for alchemical practice. However, this is not really true, as we have to understand the meaning of a «high quality of existence» as being separated by only one step, from liberation. This may either be a short or a long step, but it is only one step. This path is also recommended for men.

The female body is more unified internally, as her circulating energy is more disposed to contraction, than expansion. This process is influenced by the thyroid, mammary and sexual glands. The thyroid dictating rhythm to the thymus and the mammary glands. The sexual glands stimulate the brain's reaction to the world around, as a pre-requisite for our emotional existence here.

Considering the fact that women's energy is more unified, their body is subdivided into localised parts, with greater or lesser activity. This means that their energy is not directed sequentially. As a result, their interest is often diverted to external aspects of knowledge rather than internal. This circumstance interferes with an earnest approach

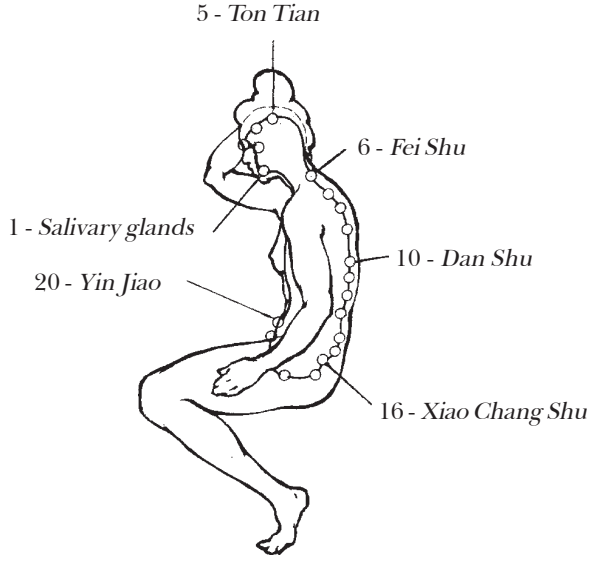
to any practice, and makes magical practices and predictions attractive to them. Even though they pay a lot of attention to their body, internal development may not be the most important aspect of practice for them. From a Taoist viewpoint, a woman's beauty is impoverished and short-lived, if it is not nurtured by the *jing* essence. This concept of inner beauty is an important factor of development according to «*Yijin-jing for the Weak*».

The creation of Yin Spirit

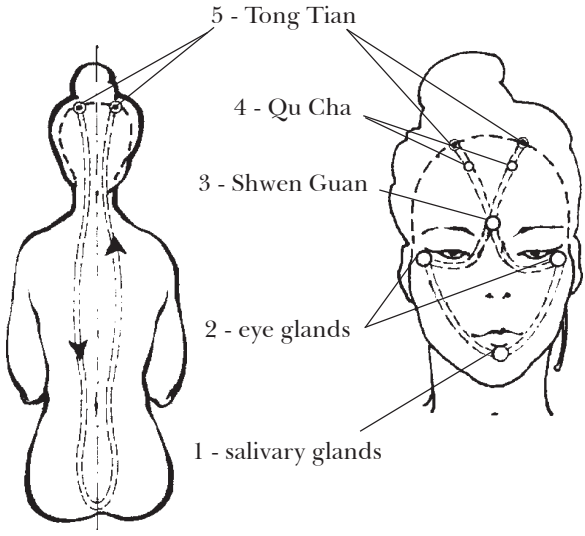
Before commencing «*Yijin-jing for the Weak*» it is necessary to create conditions in the body that are beneficial for finer development. Such conditions are known as «preparation of Yin Spirit». Yin Spirit is formed by an increase of water energies; with an increase of metal energies being necessary to consolidate what has been gathered. In order to begin gathering, it is necessary to have a specifically unified energy. The energy necessary to strengthen the tendons is water, which will lead to the growth of wood energy needed to strengthen the muscles; this in turn helps to loosen and nourish the earth.

The best time for preparation is between 3 PM and 5 PM, when yang waters are more active and cloudy. In order to fill the body properly with water, it is necessary to link the bladders' energy to the energies of other organs, via meridians, by strengthening the following orbit.

Water Energy Forming Orbit (Minor Water Orbit)



1 Salivary glands	- nourishment of nutritious waters
2 Eye glands	- nourishment of purifying waters
3 *Shwen Guan* (*Yin Tang*)	- nourishment of the pineal gland
4 *Qu Cha*	
5 *Tong Tian*	- nourishment of sky *qi*
6 *Fei Shu*	- nourishment of the lungs with water energy
7 *Jue Yin Shu*	- nourishment of the pericardium with water energy
8 *Xin Shu*	- nourishment of the heart with water energy



9 *Gan Shu*	- nourishment of the liver with water energy
10 *Dan Shu*	- nourishment of the gall bladder with water energy
11 *Pi Shu*	- nourishment of the spleen and pancreas with water energy
12 *Wei Shu*	- nourishment of the stomach with water energy
13 *San Jiao Shu*	- nourishment of the triple heater with water energy
14 *Shen Shu*	- nourishment of the kidneys with water energy
15 *Da Chang Shu*	- nourishment of the small intestine with water energy
16 *Xiao Chang Shu*	- nourishment of the large intestine with water energy

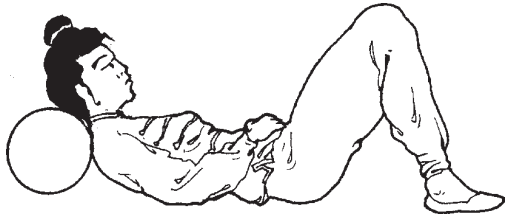
17 *Pang Guang Shu*	- nourishment of the bladder with water energy
18 The Bartolins' gland	- nourishment of the embryonic waters
19 *Qi Hai*	
20 *Yin Jiao*	

The Minor Water Orbit includes the work of the Middle Front meridian, the bladder meridian, salivary glands, the eye glands, sweat glands, Bartolins' gland and the adrenal glands. Before working with the Minor water orbit, preparation needs to be made so that the body is in a state of collection, yet it is also relaxed. When the body is relaxed, the *qi* system (which includes the blood, lymph, uro-genital and respiratory systems) begins to nourish the body.

Women need to begin relaxing their body from the head, while men relax theirs from the feet. The most energetically compressed part of the female body is her head, leading to frequent headaches.

Slow rotating movements are the best way to start relaxing the head. The body should be in a natural position, either sitting or reclining, so the chest area can relax without compressing the thymus. Then relax the spine and whole body. Even if you can do this quickly, you should take about 10-15 minutes in order to thoroughly relax. Now we can begin work with the orbit.

Three Positions for the Minor Water Orbit Practice



Lying on the back with knees bent, head slightly lifted.

Palms under forehead, knees bent under the belly (stomach)

Positioning body sideways on right.

Change position every 5-7 minutes, and finish on sideways.

After circulation of water *qi* has been completed, we can then use it to 'wash out' the body, which creates conditions for *jing* to increase.

Any practice connected with water energy can be used as preparation for '*Yijin-jing* for the weak'. However, if our intention is to use *Yijin-jing* practice independently, we will then need to include the development of the "Minor Water Chariot" or the Minor Water Orbit.

'*Yijin-jing* for the weak' practices consist of three levels, excluding the preparatory level.

1 Elixir gathering

2 Linking of *qi* by means of the tendons

3 *Jing* development by means of the tendons, and its linkage to bone and muscle *jing*

It is vital to successfully attain the first level, as this is a pre-requisite to achieve both the second and third levels. This can take between one to three years to do, depending on the condition of the energetic state you begin with. Practices to extend and reinforce the tendons 'for the Weak and Strong' are different.

Those for the "weak" are practiced lying down, and those for the "strong" are practiced standing up. This is an important difference, based on the fact that for standing practices it is necessary to prepare the lower alchemical fields to produce the required filling process. For practices in a lying position this is not required because if the effort is centripetal in nature, this also helps to develop the *Supreme Centre* and the lower alchemical fields. Therefore, in the first

instance *qi* is accumulated in the abdomen, and in the second instance, in the extremities.

Practitioners must be absolutely clear in understanding their practice. If not, then it is better not to go further than the preparatory stage of the first level. We will only examine the first level of "working with the tendons for the weak' in relation to this, as it concentrates on development of "the inner power' or the "inner strength" known as *"nei-zhong*".

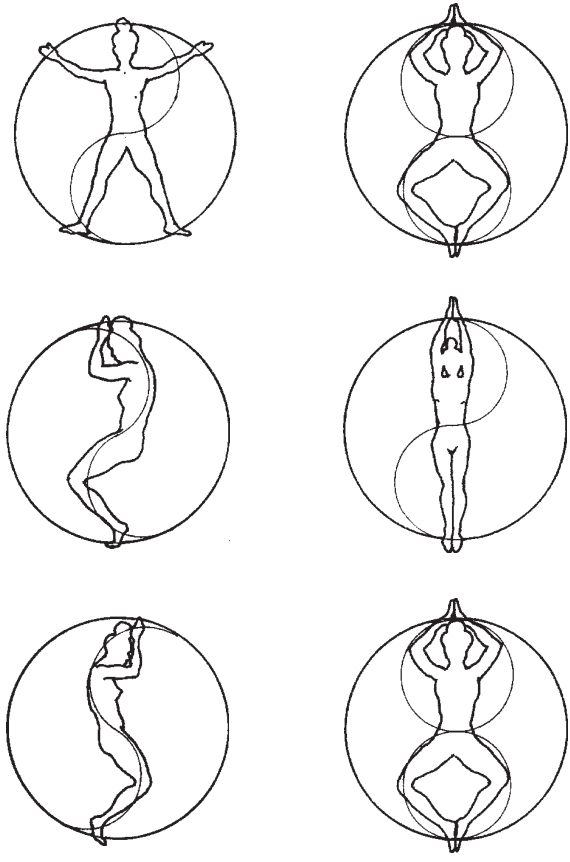
The Line of Four Cardinal Compressions of the *Supreme Centre* for Tendon Work Reinforcement

Our knowledge of the body organs is based on our ability to distinguish between internal processes. When we speak about organs, muscles and tendons, we simply itemize what is inside us. We know what's there, yet we don't feel it. What do we know about how our spleen feels, when many cannot even define its position.

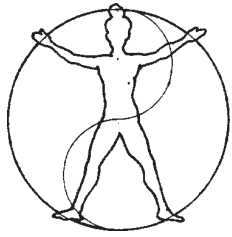
We need to understand that when we begin to work with tendons, we should define what we know about them, rather than the quality of their performance. In order to realize the quality of their performance, it is necessary to gradually come to a deeper understanding of the techniques we're practicing. This understanding also applies to work done with all the organs.

If we want to work directly with tendons we must begin with an understanding of changes in the body's *density*. The following work on the four cardinal compressions of the *Supreme Centre* is based on this understanding. When working on compression and liberation, the practitioner is learning how to listen to her body. She develops

clarity, realizing what she is doing. This is important for a scattered consciousness, as it is not so simple to enforce an interaction between forces inside the body. In a beginner's stage these forces neither obey our consciousness, nor our body.



1. The Compression of Governing Forces



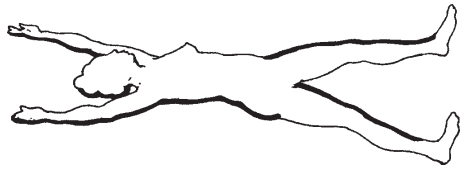
As the hands and legs open up the body proportionately, it is important to reach maximum synchronicity of movement in the extremities. In this practice the whole surface of the body compresses itself to the earth or floor (try to avoid cold floors, like concrete or stone). The compression should be evenly spread over the body, avoiding tensing in the muscles.

The human body creates form regulated by internal *yin* and yang. If the body, and therefore its consciousness, is controlled by *yang* energies, it can quickly bum out. If it is controlled by yin energies, it can fade or wither away. What we are talking about here is a question of balance, but to speak specifically, we must define what this implies.

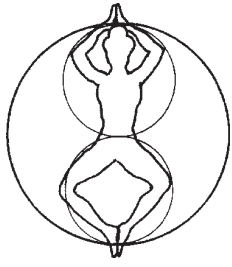
It's easy to say "relax", or "balance yourself ", but in reality it is not so simple today. Even if your consciousness thinks it is balanced or in control, the body may not be ready to relax, or even know what to do. Ideally the state of balance is when the consciousness governs the energy streams in body, which willingly accepts it. This state means in the same time that we have an ability to differentiate between *Yang* and *Yin* energies in our body.

By compressing the posterior of the surface of the body, we can direct yang energy into the centre of the body. When we experience

more focused sensation throughout the posterior surface, our work deepens and compression travels across our back, over the back of the head as well as through the upper surface of the legs. Here we are learning how to govern *yang* energy. If someone becomes confused over which part of the body *yang* energy is more and in what parts of the body are connected with different energies, don't let this confusion bother you. There is a distinction between *yang* energies which ought to be recognized: the *yang* energy which defines the body position and moves along the channels, is different from the *yang* energy necessary for the alchemical process. Actually there are three types of *yang* energy – *yang-qi*, *yang-jing* and *yang-shen*. The *yang* energy which moves along the channels is *yang-qi*. The *yang* energy which is required for the alchemical process is *yang-jing*. The yang-*shen* is the substance we can not speak at this stage. So, when we begin to compress *yang-qi*, we are trying to attain the experience of *yang-jing*. However if we don't succeed, we achieve *yin-qi*.



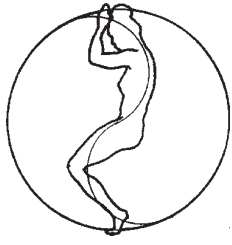
2. Liberation of *yang-jing*



This second position is connected with locking into a complete relaxation. In this state the *yang-jing* energy attained through the previous practice, flows within the body nourishing its *jing*-organs. What are *jing*-organs? They are those organs able to contain this energy, and are located in all form-creating organs (Yin organs) and vessels capable of active energy conversion.

If the *jing* organs have not formed, then the *yang-jing* transforms into yang-*qi*. *Yang-qi* energy, in any case, nourishes bones, kidneys, liver and tendons as the major element in the production of *jing*-organs. In this case the consciousness must not allow this energy to interfere with the body.

3. Spirit Gathering

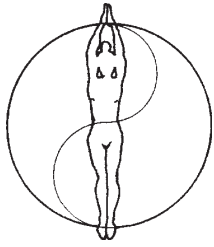


The concept of spirit gathering is the production of *jing* by the liver, or the creation of an organ, within an organ. It is recommended to do this in the period when the yin energy is less active, that is between 1 PM and 3 PM. One could practice only in this position during this time.

However, if you are practicing the whole complex, then the quality of *jing* energy will vary depending on the time of the practice. Therefore, it is better to alternate the time, and for women 1 PM to 3 PM is the best time for these techniques.

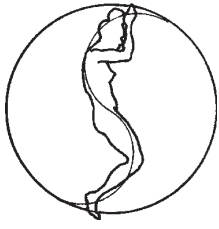
This formation of liver-*jing* organ is very valuable in the *gua*-signs, or the signs of rhythm. While in the position, all the surface of the right side of the body tenses up with all the pressure directed toward the liver. This is why it is important to keep the liver relaxed. One should not feel uncomfortable or heavy with this pressure, as its increase depends on the quality of energy and concentration, but not on physical muscle contraction.

Intermediate Position



The body is relaxed keeping the posture locked. The stretching of all surface is even, not strong.

4. Liberation of Liver-*jing*



The liberation of liver-*jing* is a response to the proceeding function. The body position is interlocked and similarly, concentration is on the liver energy filling up the whole body.

Tendons and *jing* energy

Now let us consider what happens to the tendons if the work has been incorrectly done, or not done at all. We must remember that tendons have a tendency to accumulate unrefined energy, and without practice, this energy becomes rough, and consequently the proper functioning of the tendons will be difficult. The point where they attach to the bones begins to contract and to absorb a quality of energy that is not easily transported by the body. This causes the tendons to lose their elasticity, begin to dry out, become hard, and as a result, loosens the state of the whole body.

If we want to change this situation, we need to put a lot of time and effort into enlivening the tendons again. They need to be kept in *qi* energy that matures over a long period of time. This energy must achieve a certain quality that is necessary to prepare for the production of *jing* energy.

Production of *jing* energy indicates that the tendons are working in a correct way. Actually it is the constancy of *jing* energy production that stops the tendons from becoming clogged. It is important to understand that practice designed to enliven the tendons is different from practice directed toward *jing* production. These practices are structured differently. However, the overall result is that work with *jing* energy cannot be rushed, or this same energy will produce unregulated energies.

Firstly we begin to work with *qi* energy, by becoming aware of the sensations taking place during the process of practice. This is a preparation for further control and regulation, and is the first level of work in «*Yijin-jing* for the Weak». The objective is to develop inner

power, where all efforts are directed internally, to stimulate a proper interchange between the internal forces.

One of the prerequisites for the formation of *jing* energy in the tendons is finding a balance between the body and the mind. This implies the ability of the conscious mind to guide energy streams within the body, providing that the body is ready for this, and also that it occurs naturally.

If the body and mind are unbalanced we can create additional problems for ourselves. The revived tendons would consume the energy very intensively and we would experience a need to stretch out, extend and twist ourselves. These movements are connected with the freeing up of this energy. This is a natural process, yet it indicates that our tendons cannot yet form and produce *jing* energy. As previously mentioned, production of *jing* energy is a prerequisite in the process of helping our tendons not to hinder our body, but to help it.

Women need to begin serious practice with tendons, or rather with the connections, in order to primarily avoid obstructing them with rough energies, and more importantly, to increase and strengthen their *jing* energies, allowing them to improve their internal practice.

Let us define our steps in this practice.

Firstly we have to understand what we are doing, then we try to feel it. When we become aware of our sensations during the practice the purpose is made clear, we can then direct our effort and concentration in order to ensure continuity of work.

When we work with extension and contraction, or freeing, we change the density of our body. For women this can be done in the horizontal position by using four actions ('four cardinal

compressions'). We contract *yang-qi* in order to achieve *yang-jing*. Then we relax, allowing the generated energy to enrich our kidneys, liver, tendons and bones. This is the order and the rhythm which should be followed in practising with *jing* energy in the tendons.

Additional discussion about *jing* energy

When we consider *jing* energy production in the tendons, we imply alchemical work. The ultimate aim is to produce this energy not only in the tendons but in all other parts and body organs. Eventually everything should produce *jing* energy. However it is important to follow a sequential order while unfolding this energy.

To begin with we should understand that the body constantly produces *jing*, however unevenly. Although under normal circumstances, this kind of *jing* energy cannot be intertwined, refined and used for energy cultivation, as it's quality is not high enough to assist in the alchemical process.

The processes which manifest *jing* energy are usual in our life. However, it becomes complicated and practically impossible when we try to recognise this particular energy as it is occurring and to define it for further serious work. For example, when *jing* energy is naturally activated, a person becomes excited, not just sexually but also emotionally and even mentally, this needs to be carefully realised. All our reactions to surrounding events and things are connected with the activation of *jing* energy. It occurs not just because we are out of control, but because we need to produce some amount of *jing* energy and we cannot yet produce this energy in the right alchemical way. This unrefined *jing* energy is neither controlled nor kept, but is a

stimulant, having both a toning and activating affect on the glands, without which they would wither and shrivel. Production of small amounts of *jing* for this purpose has a protective function, necessary for a healthy immune system. States of aggression and increased activity, as well as strong emotional feelings are connected with active *jing* that becomes a powerful driving force to redistribute our qi. However, using this energy before the emotional factors have been neutralised is not appropriate and should even be avoided.

Women's emotional states need to be transformed, otherwise they will never be able to formulate their basis, and their energies will constantly burn out as a result of the unending flow of reactions to various stimuli. Moreover unfolded *jing* energy will increase and intensify this process, thus creating a vicious circle for women.

The female body mainly produces *jing* energy in the liver and kidneys, and through the liver there is a connection to the blood. This is one of the most important postulations in the alchemical process. That is why, rather than trying to define this energy when they are experiencing moments of uncontrolled excitement, women need to concentrate on their ability to define and feel this energy in a more refined way. Here we are referring to the time of menstruation. Women can, and should practices at this time in order to lessen the unavoidable energetic losses taking place. By bringing their attention to *jing* energy, produced precisely at this time, they can at a later point define and hold it.

However, we must confess this is not so simple to do. *Qi* energy, which is more condensed or dense, can be felt more easily, and may block us from feeling finer internal *jing* energies. Nevertheless women can begin to work with the main alchemical principles, and can unfold

and use some of them especially during their menstruation period. The first one is the conservation of finer energy. In general, when talking about *jing* from an alchemical viewpoint, we imply energy which is conserved.

Besides, quality alchemical work implies not only the possibility of *jing* energy generation, but also its intertwining, in order to create the conditions for cultivation of *shen* spirit. If our *jing* energy is not prepared correctly, we cannot proceed with further transformation work. Women need to practice during their menstruation period; it is an indisputable law of this preparation. If we draw a parallel between menstrual and sperm secretions, as *jing* energy carriers, firstly, we are not referring to material substances that dissipate , but to an energy loss that cannot be contained. Secondly *jing* energy is also dissipated during uncontrolled emotional states. The mechanics of this dissipation is the same for both circumstances. Even the *jing* that stimulates the glands is dissipated or lost at this time. Until we have learned how to control and keep this energy, it is impossible to consider working with it.

We have to understand the mechanics of working with the glands energetically as they have a direct influence on this energy, and can help in making it possible to hold onto it. We cannot say that they produce exactly the same *jing* energy as the organs do for example, but they transform energy from *jing-qi* and *jing-jing* into *jing-shen* and also direct it.

Let us say that the liver produces *jing* energy, which could be referred to as *yang-jing* of the liver. We cannot say the same about glands. The glands are partially constructed with *jing* energy and also we can note that they embody the substance with qualities of *jing*

energy. Therefore, when we correlate glands with *jing* energy, we talk about the constructive functions of this energy. We have to note that *shen* spirit formation depends, to a large extent, on the state of the glands. The intensity of our reactions to our senses, is created by the mind, and is directly connected with an agitated state of the glands. When they are calm and do not react to stimuli too intensively, their function (to formulate the energetic rhythm of the whole body) is normal. The condition of a calm state of mind is essential for *shen* spirit formation.

Specific mechanics of gland functions in the female body also define her ability to hold, and alchemically accumulate energies. As we have already noted, a centripetal movement, towards the centre pulls energy distribution in the female body inwardly. Glands begin to react to energy movement by compressing and contracting, which leads to an excretion (either of secretion or just energy). This is a manifestation of *yin* quality of the glands and is connected with the water quality.

In men, the energy moves away from the centre in a centrifugal movement, allowing their glands to consume energy. In this case, all gland excretions are a manifestation of *yang* quality of the glands based on extension and giving. The function of the glands in women are based on excretion, whereas in men they are based on consumption. This is why it is vitally important for women to understand the concept of preservation.

Moreover in order to preserve *jing*, as well as produce it, it is necessary for women to preserve energy during their menstrual cycle. This does not mean that they have to try to keep it specifically in the glands. If the energy were not preserved in the whole body (being

connected with *qi* functioning), it would be unable to be preserved in the glands. The regime of practice in accordance to rhythm as a whole is therefore designed to improve the *qi* in the body, especially during the menstrual cycle.

Now we will comment on an additional branch of practice necessary in women's *jing* energy assimilation work. This is the improvement of links between specific organs and body parts, as well as their connections and correspondences, but these connections are not linear.

The first connection: 'Feet - Base of torso - Brain'. We are connecting vessels that are developed in the lower abdomen, feet and the head. It is important that this vertical basis of *jing* formation helps to create conditions for further *shen* spirit cultivation.

The second connections: 'Kidneys - Ovaries - Liver'. The second link rebuilds a horizontal basis, which creates and strengthens the foundation for the development and maintenance of *jing* energy. That is, *jing* energy should not just be linked, but it should also be contained and held. It can be kept either through *qi*, *shen* or *jing*. If we keep *jing* by means of *qi*, we expose it to the influence of a rougher energy, thus creating the chance for complications. It is also difficult to keep *jing* energy by means of *shen*, because it is finer. To keep *jing* by means of *jing* energy is far simpler, as the energies flow into a relation(with each other). For example if we connect *jing* energy of the liver with *jing* energy of the kidneys, they link together. In other words, *jing* energy of the wood keys into *jing* energy of water. However there can be no such linking between *qi* energy of the liver and *jing* energy of the kidneys. In general though both energies of the liver and kidneys have a primal connection. The navel connects them both.

The alchemical connection 'Kidneys - ovaries - liver' occurs via the *Supreme centre*, a zone where all energies are unified. Actually when the *Supreme centre* is functioning, energies of all kinds can be directed there and they will flow naturally. We can then also limit them, or create special links (as we have seen above) which will help to direct these energies.

It is important for women to improve both of these *relations* as they are important elements in the process of holding and interrelating the *jing* energies. At a certain stage it is not enough to simply produce *jing* energy – it has to flow according to specific links (relations) in order to be able to start the intertwining process. Therefore, initially we produce *qi* energy, then we learn how to intertwine it. When we have mastered that, we learn how to direct it. At a later stage we will produce *jing* energy, learn how to intertwine it and furthermore, direct it. When we 'tie up' the energy, we keep it. When we keep it, we maintain a rhythm of energy, and therefore create conditions for its cultivation and refinement. If we do not 'tie up' and keep the energy, the rhythm cannot be maintained, as there is no reservoir, and the energy can only be available in each given moment. The same process occurs when intertwining *shen* energy. The lower alchemical field, "the cinnabar field", links *qi* energies, the middle one links *jing* energies and the upper one links the *shen* spirit.

Thus we have defined the links women must work with to understand why these particular organs and parts of the body are connected with *jing* energy. Later, they must feel both the vertical and horizontal basis, and use them for creating links (relations). Naturally it is important to pay closer attention to this practice during menstruation, as the generated *jing* energy (even being unopened),

can be guided appropriately.

In this manner we have now reached the concept of practising a regime during menstruation.

Practice during menstruation

Without a doubt the menstrual cycles of today's women has been drawn out from the general rhythm of their existence. This is true especially when they firmly favour a male orientation. For these women their menstruation is more than just a time of natural vulnerability, it is an irritating condition that intrudes and distracts them. Under such circumstances, specific qualities and the significance of energy is simply ignored, causing leakage of energy precisely at the moment when it must be gathered and increased.

During this time they unconsciously strive for a feeling of peace. Yet often this peace is required as a preparatory stage prior to a new period of increased activity. However now we need to examine not only the short period of menstruation but also the whole cycle of the state of glands that are undergoing a process of change. This is influenced by anything women involve themselves in, which in turn changes the quality of the current cycle, as well as creates an energetic basis for the following cycle. Based on this understanding, practices can also influence the quality of the next cycle.

Female bodies are constantly in this process of change, whether they are menstruating or not. Young girls, as well as elderly women, live in response to shifting cycles. Between these cycles there is a transitional space of three days, a transition, where the energy undergoes a change of quality and is restructured. These regular

changes taking place within their bodies are directly connected with the cycles of the moon.

Women have always experienced their monthly periods in accordance with the moon's movements, and in the past it was natural for them to menstruate during the full moon. Now however, external influences interfere with this natural rhythm, leaving them with little chance to harmonise with the moon's changes. It is also a fact that women generally tend to give birth during the full moon. The other fact is that women synchronise their cycle, if operating in groups of a singular orientation. All this indicates that women still have the ability to influence their cycles, by finding their own rhythm and connection to the moon. If they wish to control this process through practices, it then becomes important to chose at what times which special practices they should use.

Every month the changes women experience with the same timing, can help them understand this cyclical concept, but can also numb their sensations during the time of transition. Most women are trapped within this vicious circle and are unable to recognise their escape route. Actually this escape route is connected with the differences in energy movement during menstruation, as well as during the intermediate period. It is at this point that the energy should be gathered, developed and accumulated. However, women of today are only aware of their losses at this time. This is the reason why one of the most important considerations for practitioners is to recognise and master the *difference* in the movement of energy.

Women need to learn how to hold onto these energetic qualities which occur during their menstrual cycle. This work helps them to

understand the concept of their own rhythm.

They also need to learn how to 'listen' to their energy at this time and need to be prepared to spend a lot of time learning to do it. Only then can they hold onto and later find a way to purify, regulate and preserve it. Other practices can be continued, however you will need to relate them to different rhythms and experience of different sensations. To do this work, a self-contained focus is necessary. This helps to avoid energetic losses, but will not allow you to isolate and confine *jing* energy to be worked with. While in a state of peace *qi* becomes stronger, and as it is given the opportunity to circulate with a better quality, it's strong sensations will overtake the finer *jing* sensation. That is why additional practices are required to define and produce *jing*. This process can become more intensive if you change place where you live.

Ideally, one should completely change rhythm during this time, but it is difficult to do so. Therefore, try to structure your schedule so that excessive activity can be avoided, which is especially important in the few days of bleeding. In other words be aware of your menstrual cycle at all times.

Let us now look at what happens during menstruation from the point of view of the lunar cycle. We need to know whether we are working with *yin* or *yang* qualities, because the work with *yang* energy, and the strengthening of *yin* energy corresponds with the phases of the moon.

The menstrual cycle must correspond to changes taking place in a woman's body during the 28 day period, counting from the first day of menstruation to the first day of the following one. Yet it is rare

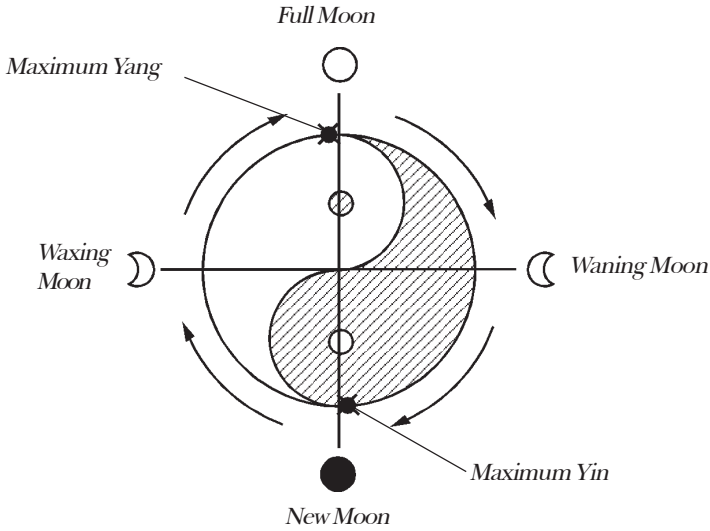
for today's women to maintain this pattern during their cycles. Generally speaking to refer to the term cycle today would be slightly incorrect, as women's natural rhythmical sequence (cycles repeated with the same sequence in equal time borders) is affected by external rhythms. Although they seem to know what happens and how, in reality the action of their internal organs fluctuates between different streams. This fluctuation follows energy demands and alien influences, which correspond to different laws.

Very often women can not pinpoint the activities of their endocrine system at any given stage in their cycle. As a result the number of unplanned pregnancies has increased, not only because their cycles are destabilised, but also because they are out of touch with activities within their own womb. They unable to understand their own finely tuned structural system.

If these internal rhythms and cycles are not balanced from birth, they need to be restructured through serious practice. It is only then possible to achieve a harmonised relation between the inner changes in women, which are connected with blood, and those changes created by the Moon and manifesting the rhythm of the Earth.

As a system, Taoism is oriented toward change, with rhythm being the foundation of its work. We could say that Taoists work with the earth and its cycles, in order to move toward the heaven. The movements of the moon represents the earth's cycles, its rhythm is a constant change of qualities, defined by interactive movements between the earth, moon and the sun. Here *Yin* and *Yang* interchange, allowing the unseen to be seen.

The point of maximum *Yang* transition and its inherent quality-change is just prior to the full moon. The moment proceeding this,



is the starting point for a woman's new cycle, which commences when maximal *Yang* manifests its full ripeness. The full moon frees this energy, creating a movement that is directed outside. Actually menstruation is the most dynamic part of this cycle. It is not a point, but a process, during which changes of qualities take place. Menstruation does not correspond to any particular quality, but rather is a change and transition. This makes it so important for women.

Located exactly opposite this moment is another moment of transition, the moment of ovulation. It is also a quality of change, but it carries another sign with it. The transition of the menstrual cycle expresses itself externally, while that of ovulation expresses itself internally. Its manifestation inwardly oriented, as the ovule has a physiological potential to form an embryo, to grow and be carried in a woman's body, filling it from within.

The subtlety of the ovulation period is difficult to notice or to feel. It carries dense, animalistic energy to nourish the formation of a new being. It is no coincidence that women who have many children have the same symptoms during ovulation as they do during their pregnancy. By activating the same mechanisms the inwardly turned transition becomes noticeable. Ovulation, or maximum *Yin*, is the moment of optimal inward direction. This transition signifies the birth of *Yang*, the point where the seed is planted and begins to grow.

Development and growth are the qualities, characteristic of the period between ovulation and delivery. These same *yang* qualities also characterise the period between ovulation and menstruation. Following menstruation *Yang* changes to *Yin*. Thereafter is a period of preparation, gathering, strengthening and unification, proceeding the next stage of ovulation. The ripening of an ovule is a *yang* process but it occurs in a *yin* period because its final point is not an externally directed movement, but rather an internal strengthening.

Menstruation is a transition with a *yang* signature. It is an obvious external process that can be worked with by using various practices. Ovulation is a transition with a *yin* signature. It is an internal process that can be worked on only when we have caught the thread of change. It is connected with the new moon, or rather with that moment, when the moon is diminished. The dark moon does not mean a static moon, equally, the full moon does not mean that it is «frozen» into that position. The moon continues to move, meaning the starting point of growth, when her *Yin* is being replaced by *Yang*.

The alchemical process here is of constant change and growth and from this perspective menstruation represents a break in the flow, which inhibits the building of a spiral for development. The

energy is not only unable to be purified in this period, but it goes to the increasing and development of *yin* quality. This *Yin* in turn becomes an obstacle for women, who are trying to cultivate their *Yang*.

However the concept of this break in the flow also implies the concept of break through, as well as of reality. What this implies is that if you work with this break, in time, it can become a passage, which will allow you to move forward. Also this break indicates where we need to direct our efforts to archive effective quality change.

From this point of view, women have more scope than men, because their mechanism for change is within them, and can be switched over and reconstructed. Men also have such a mechanism, but it requires fine energies for their change. Their denser energy is more easily felt than the finer ones, which is why men pay no attention to their finer energies. Thus it is a bonus for women that they can define their own tools in order to work with them. In order to feel the change of qualities during their cycle, as well as the differences in the energy flow between periods and the rest of the time, women must concentrate. They must learn to separate from both and listen to their cycles. This however, may take a lot of time to achieve.

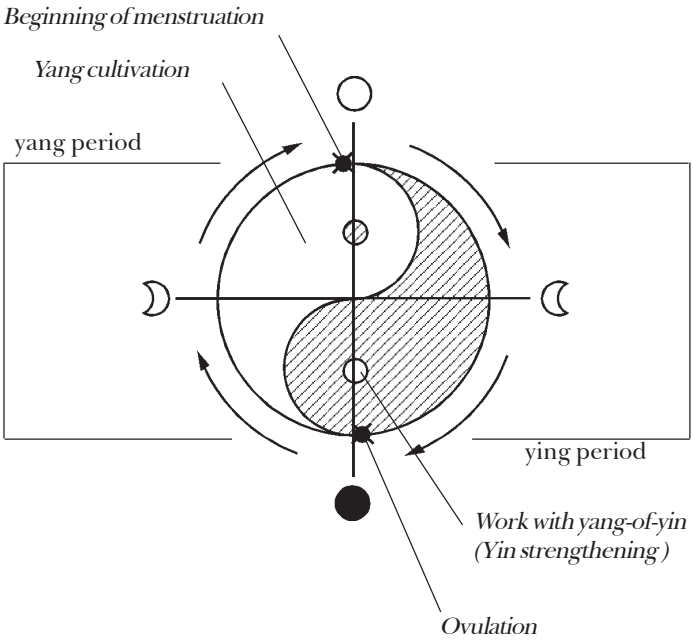
Success depends on many factors. Firstly, it is the redistribution of *yin* at the moment of commencement of practice. Let us look at an example of a woman of 30, who has never given a thought to the special nature of her existence during menstruation, nor done any regulatory practices for her energies. If she has an active life, and is uncontrolled in her emotional outbursts, we would expect that when she begins to practice seriously with a good teacher, she would need to be very patient to achieve the first preparatory step in this work.

As mentioned earlier, real alchemical work cannot begin until the preparatory work is complete. If women have not recognised their *yin* energy, they cannot develop their *yang* energy. During menstruation *yin* energy is activated, therefore its redistribution is most needed then. Despite the fact that menstruation starts from the position of maximum *Yang*, their saturation with *yin* energies (especially *yin* energy of the earth) is increased. On the initial stage of practice this energy is hard to follow and control. If women don't practice then they have no awareness of this process. *Yin* energies increase during menstruation through excessive activity and during sleep. Thorough practice while being awake will not allow *yin* energies to increase while sleeping. That is the reason why women need to thoughtfully prepare their energetic structure for sleeping. Here we speak specifically about a formula which menstruating women should follow. Cultivation of a *state of peace*, which is emphasised many times, will help women not to compress their *yang*. Practice in the horizontal position, in turn will help to free these *yang* energies. As we have already mentioned, unprepared *yang* energy will be compressed in women, if they spend a lot of time in a vertical position.

During menstruation this process increases, due to a general increase in *Yin*. If over the duration of their whole cycle, women practices to redistribute and strengthen their *yin* energy, then if they practice lying down while menstruating, they would not only be able to free their *yang* energy, but would also be filled by its refined quality.

This entire book is dedicated to *Yin* redistribution in order to further strengthen and cultivate *Yang* and unless our practices relate to this concept, we cannot discuss Taoist alchemy. Now we will examine this in relation to the menstrual cycle.

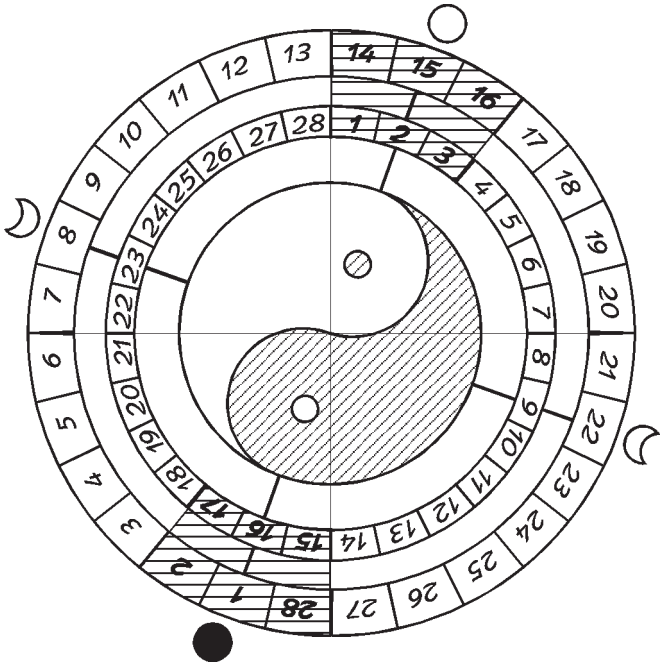
By relating the menstrual cycle to the lunar cycle, we discover, that the period between the beginning of menstruation and the following transition, or ovulation, is related to the decrease in the moon. This is a *yin* period, from its minimum to its maximum at ovulation. During this period we need to work with *yang* within *yin*, or *yang*-of-*yin* energy. This is a redistribution and strengthening of *Yin*, which will allow us to strengthen and increase *Yang*.



Menstruation commences just before the first point of this period, and sometimes can last as long as seven days. If this happens, it is especially important to base your practice on stabilisation and strengthening of *yin* energies. In general, this whole period is dedicated to Minor *yang*, or *yang* within *yin* energy work. For example the orbit

technique using the opposite direction (see the section on alchemy), is exactly the technique to help define this energy. If you work with this orbit, then the *yin* period corresponds to a larger degree to this when the moon diminishes, or when *Yang* changes into *Yin*. These 14 days correspond to a preparation for the following period, when women begin cultivating their *yang*.

You may well ask 'What is the starting point in our practice? The moon position, or our own menstrual cycle?' Naturally today there aren't too many women living in harmony with the phases of the moon. If we combine both the lunar and menstrual cycles to create an ideal model, then the picture would look like this.



Here it is clear that on the second day of menstruation a transitional point falls. This is the day of maximum bleeding and is a crucial for every woman. It relates to the fifteenth lunar day, or the beginning of the *Yin* period. The moon diminishes so we work with *yang-of-yin* energy or Minor *yang*. We come to a new moon.

The other transitional days correspond to ovulation. According to our scheme, they fall on days 15, 16 and 17 of the menstrual cycle. In reality the ovule matures earlier and is then ready to conceive. This is why the days of ovulation-transition cannot be strictly defined, because the internal conditioning for the process is too strong. Work with these days can only be stabilised when *yin* energies are sufficiently regulated. Eventually if you work during your menstrual cycles over sufficient time, your ovulation period will balance out. These internal processes are difficult (and unnecessary) to influence externally. However, they are dependent on external factors, which are worked on during the preparatory and strengthening processes.

The ovule's potency will increase with practice, and after the formation of the *Supreme centre*, is directed inward to help strengthen the creation of the Immortal Embryo. In the initial stage this could increase the probability of pregnancy if you haven not stopped sexual contacts.

The period of ovulation initiates the next part of the cycle, or the *yang* period. The maximum point of this phase being completed with menstruation, corresponding to the growing moon. During this *yang* phase you can and must work with *yang* energies. Cultivation techniques are practised, and you can also work with male orbit variations designed to increase *yang* energies. Male vertical practices are recommended to help rebuild the body and learn the principle

of movements. If you practice *Bagua-Zhang* for example, your movements should be more clockwise, while in the previous period they preferably ought to be anti-clockwise.

Women can only cultivate their *yang* energy during the 14 days of their cycle. The transitional stage lasting for only three days commences in the last days of this *yang* period. It is during this short time that women can access their *yang* energies. Following this, work begins again to prepare for the next *yang* cycle. Energies accumulated while practising with *yang* energy can be accessed during the *yang* period, however, the overall quality of work depends on the three transitional days (menstruation) where the rhythm changes.

Serious practitioners need to understand that menstruation is not an irritating necessity to undergo, but a real chance to find their individual rhythm and to improve their practices. If the moment is not observed they miss the real value within it. Define your own practice with your menstrual cycle and be consistent with your work. Understand that your practice is a preparation that will strengthen with each technique containing an element of *yang-of-yin* energy.

Purification is a most important concept to be considered while menstruating. When we speak of retaining *jing* energy, we refer to energy occurring in this period in a specific way so it can be isolated and defined. In our practice, purification implies a specific quality that must be present during menstruation. Purification and storage are not the same yet they are inseparable, if you want results of quality from your practice. The energy needs to be isolated before it can be purified. To store this energy only makes sense when all your energy is purified, then you can access this energy.

What is purification and how can women use this concept? The simplest word to define it is *refinement*, implying both concepts of distinguishing and purification at once. Women need to refine their blood energy during menstruation for further *jing* utilisation.

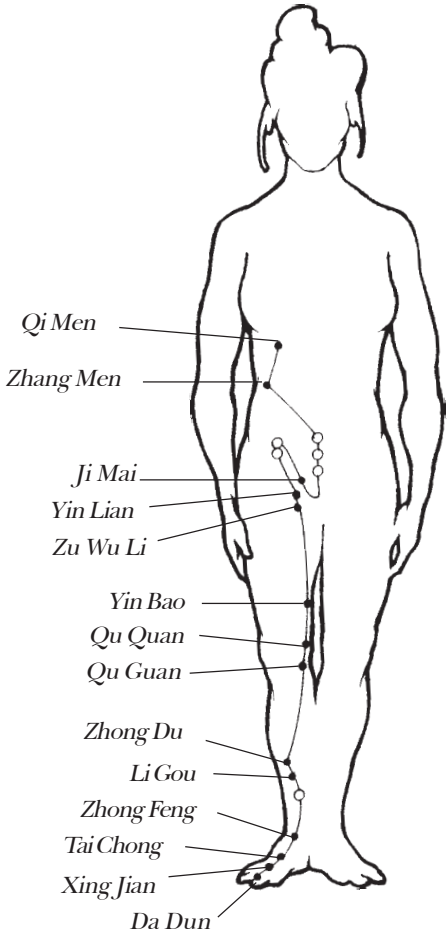
The formation of *jing* is an important function of the liver, with the mammary glands assisting in its production. Creating a combination of glands, blood and *yin* organs working together during the menstrual cycle. Through purification and redistribution *jing* energy is activated, and in this connection women can actually change the rhythm in their bodies. As seen earlier, practice with the glands implies that firstly your efforts should be directed to controlling the emotional responses of the senses. The goal is to reach a state of peace, and everything that helps to reduce excitement through the movements, mental activity and emotions, supports the process of production and refinement of *jing* energy.

Techniques directed to the practice of *jing* energy in the blood

Quality work with blood energy can be achieved by doing techniques orientedtoward the womb (γ–orbit, and septenary orbit for womb) as well as toward liver jing.

Here we can use the techniques of two types. The techniques of the first type help to regulate the energy in all yin organs. The techniques of the other type help us to restore the function of the liver meridian. They are connected to the energetic vessels of the feet. These techniques will strengthen the liver and reduce energetic pollution within the blood. Later we will examine a complex of

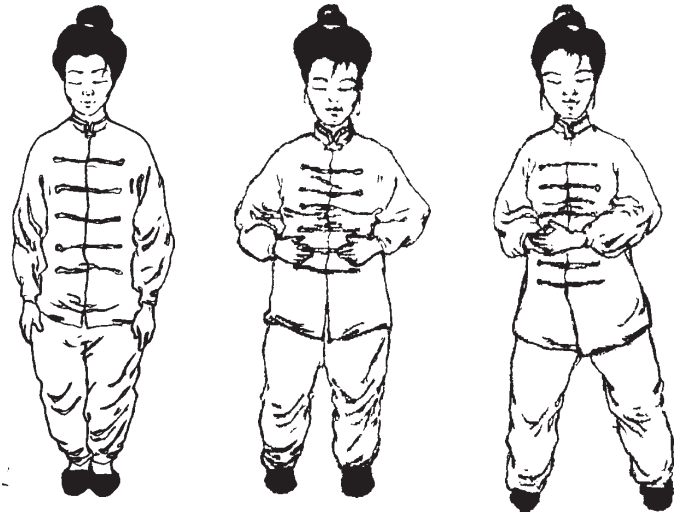
Liver Meridian



movements especially for the feet, which creates additional conditions for the production of *jing* energy.

As during the period of menstruation it is important for women to pay attention to their individual rhythm, they need to adjust their schedule of practice to their own rhythm.

Practices specifically designed to work with liver jing, rhythmically relate to exercises around the womb orbit.

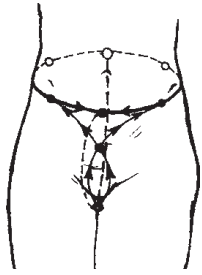


Begin with feet together. In this position try to feel the internal surfaces of the feet. Move the right feet to shoulder level. This movement is done with the internal surface of the foot «scrubbing» along the floor. Balance the weight. Sit down, slightly lifting the arms from the elbows, resulting from slightly collapsing the back.

Place your palms on the liver and spleen (in a natural way). Then shift your weight to the right leg, and by bringing your left leg next to the right, we make another step, using the same "scrubbing"

movement. Shift your weight to the right leg, simultaneously putting the left palm on top of the right one. Begin to massage the liver with slow circular movements, originating from a waist movement. The right leg carries the weight.

After making both circles alternate them with γ-orbit of the womb.



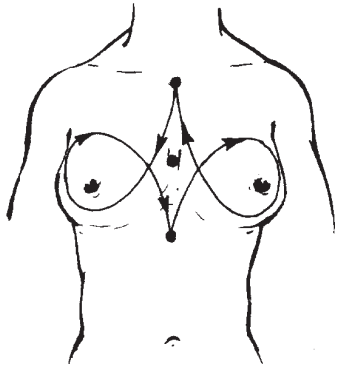
Repeat these movements for at least 15-20 minutes. Then slowly balance the weight, returning the left palm back to the spleen. Shift the weight to the left leg and pull in the right one. Again move using "scrubbing" movements. Slowly and softly bring down the arms, and return to the initial position.

It is important for women to listen to their own rhythm and to move with it. This will help to restore and intertwine energies. When they define their own pace of moving and breathing during the womb exercise, they are identifying with their own internal state. Try to avoid dependence on external things, and avoid activity. This helps the energy to be ready to move toward the next cycle. The practice completes with energy assimilation. The function of the orbit of the womb is to saturate the region and points associated with it, with energy. One of the special tasks is to fill the waist meridian with energy. This prevents the energy dissipating, helping it to assimilate and raise it's quality.

Techniques for working with the Mammary Glands

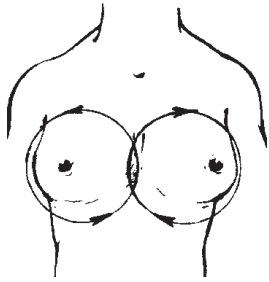
Before we begin to discuss *yin* organs techniques, we will look at the significance of one more practice which will help women understand the concept of their *jing* energy – a technique for the mammary glands.

As mentioned earlier, mammary glands have a direct influence on *jing* energy, especially its production during menstruation. They are the main distributors of this energy – supplying it to the Middle Front meridian. Mammary glands nurture this meridian; the intensity and quality of the filling of this meridian with the energy also depends on them. In time these glands assume a function to feed the Immortal Embryo inside the body.



We create a circulation circuit within the mammary glands (α-orbit) in the same manner as in the womb (γ–orbit) in order to increase its function to produce *jing*. It is important to practice α-orbit techniques in order to prepare for practice with the Microcosmic orbit, but also to help the work with *jing* energy as an additional technique during menstruation.

During *Tao Yin* practices, women should spend no less than five minutes on each of the two (α and γ) orbits. When working with them separately it is best to combine them with the mammary glands



orbit, and with massaging the breasts. A mammary gland "shower" should be used as a preparation. This is done by screwing a cup or a glass (or similar container) toward the centre of each breast, not pressurising it too strongly, and then pulling it out. Repeat nine times on each side. This helps to purify the mammary glands from the pollution of energies that takes place during sexual contact. It also energetically strengthens them.

Massage consists of soft, simultaneous, circular movements around the breasts. Each palm has to round each breast, touching the *Lao Gong* centre and not pulling the skin. Repeat nine times in both directions. Then the centres of the palms are placed on the centres of the mammary glands, and softly pressed nine times. Exhale on each pressing movement. On inhalation, by concentrating on the centre of the palms prepare for the repeated movement. This is followed by the mammary glands orbit. The process can be mixed by alternating between the orbit exercise and the pressure exertion exercise. Altogether the sequence should take no less then 10-15 minutes.

Before commencing the described exercise you should try to feel the pulsing sensations in the centre of the palms. This sensitivity is important because of the connection to the heart. An accurate influence on the heart is required because, if it's rhythm is out of balance, it will have a negative influence on the function of the mammary glands. This influence is ensured by the normal functions of the pericardium.

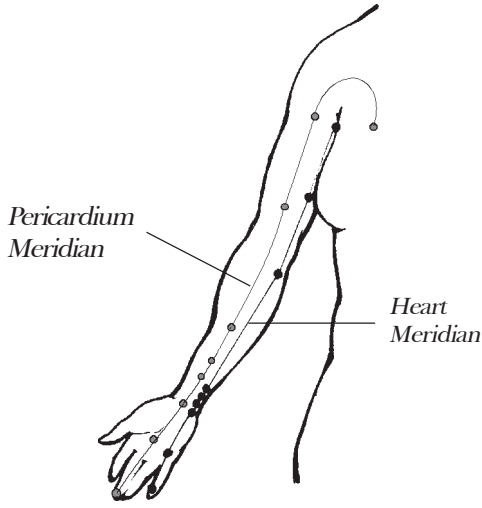
The following posture of *Tao Yin* technique will help to stabilise the function of the pericardium, and to feel the pulsation in the centres of the palms. Lightly place palms together, with the fingers only touching at the tips. Create a slight pressure between the palms.

Heart Preparation

According to alchemical precepts the pericardium channel is the Mother of the blood, while the liver channel is regarded as the Father of the blood. In order to understand the concept of practice with the pericardium channel we need to prepare the heart by balancing its rhythm. As we grow older the rhythm of our external influences becomes more prominent, and during practice conflicts with our own individual rhythms.

Women are often confronted with this incongruity while practising. It manifests as unpleasant sensations in the heart region, and creates a feeling that the heart is out of balance. However, that redistribution is unavoidable and takes place in any case, especially if your heart energy has not been regulated yet. When this point is reached you cannot stop, otherwise you will once again begin to depend on the familiarity of the *Yin* rhythm.

For women the heart is a dwelling for *shen* spirit, whereas for men, this is in the brain's castle known as *Ni Wang Gong*. Alchemically speaking then, the indicator for high development in women is connected with the heart. This is why it is important to work to regulate and calm the energies of the heart including internal control over the excessive emotional manifestations. The condition of the heart depends on the condition of all five *yin* organs, referred to as the forming organs. Any reaction to external stimulus (especially during the menstrual cycle) can attract uncontrolled *jing* to flow toward these organs. This is further enhanced by the activity of the brain, which in turn, causes the heart to function in an unnatural rhythm.



When this rhythm is imposed on us externally, not only does it stop the heart assimilating *jing*, but it also affects the functions of both the thymus and mammary glands. This is why it is so important women to prepare themselves during the menstrual cycles in order to help maximise their chances of finding peace. If they are inclined to emotional, psychological and mental excitements, and aware of it, they must try to change the situation. Your motto should become: «I see nothing, hear nothing, and say nothing to anyone». We have exaggerated the frame of action here in order to give women the opportunity to prepare to commence their journey on the path of Taoist Alchemy.

Practices for women who do not menstruate

Is it necessary to work with this concept for women who do not experience transitional periods? The answer is yes, it is important.

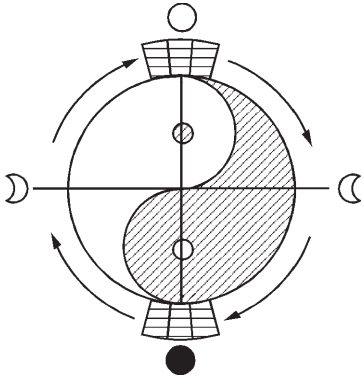
However, first we have to define what processes occur within the body when menstruation is not active.

Taking into consideration today's conditions of existence, serious alchemical work for young girls is inappropriate. However, for young girls growing up within an environment, where activities of everyday life are naturally concentrated on practice, the case is different, particularly in connection with strengthening the first factor connected with the energies of Pre-natal heaven. (see «*Definition of the initial positions*»). Here they have an opportunity to begin their practice with *Yang* energies before *Yin* manifests itself, creating obstacles in their path. Even when menstruation begins (which it may not if practice remains pure, and a specific rhythm is kept), their *Yin* will be regulated and therefore, will not interrupt their energetic structures.

Young practitioners will have *Yang* cultivation as a basis of their practice and may reach a high level of development by the time they are 28. However, this is only relates to the supportive environment which would help them to take constructive steps toward the sky level. Otherwise, without it, the negative influences of *Yin* will destroy the *Yang* energies, which have not yet been strengthened, taking the ground that they have spent both time and effort to form and strengthen, away from them. These processes will also depend on time and cycles.

In reality, if a girl living in contemporary society is not confronted with the question, «to practice, or not to practice», it is best for her is to pass through the normal process of defining her *Yin* energy, followed by utilising the ways to strengthen it. She needs to understand why this basis needs to be formed, and how it can help in the process of preparation and cultivation. If conditions around her

were such that her questions were answered naturally, then, at the onset of menstruation she would be able to use her knowledge to suit the demands of her energy. Meaning, her ability to work with *jing* energy, as well as to strengthen *yang-of-yin* energy. If she can feel the cyclic changes within her energy, and is willing to practice conscientiously before menstruation begins, then she could use the same program designed for women who have entered menopause.



Time of full moon, one day before and one day after - the moment of change

The scheme above is connected to lunar phases, therefore it is important to be clear about the moon's position in the heavens. It is recommended to make a graph defining the time of the full moon each month.

The threshold of the full moon can become a natural reminder of the maximum *yang* time. No matter how you are feeling, starting from this moment onwards, it is better to isolate yourself and minimise your activities, in order to observe the internal processes, and later, to preserve and purify your energies.

The energy of a woman whose menstruation has ceased differs from that of a young girl. Nevertheless it is still necessary for her to

listen to and be aware of changes in her body, so she can maintain her own rhythm. As a rule, during menopause, she loses her rhythm. When she stops bleeding, she stops losing that fine essential energy. However, she loses access to it in the transitional process of restructuring the endocrine system to suite the new circumstances. In addition, if her energy is unregulated, then the restructuring process is quite substantial, and at times can even make her ill.

Constant emotional outbursts and extreme mood shifts, fluctuating between uncontrolled gaiety, and longing and depression, exhibits the state to which she has approached at this stage of her life. These changes in her energy can be compared with the changes in a river's course: calm across the plains yet stormy in the mountains. A stormy river can destroy a lot in its path before it's course evens out over the plains. Note that the process of the 'river changing its course' is unavoidable. This is connected not only to the fact that the quantity of women's ovules is limited and that from that moment on, women can no longer have babies. Women also lose their liveliness and essential energy at this time and there comes a point when they realise they must adapt to a new way of life.

With every menstruation period women lose "forming energy", a building energy, they can no longer accumulate. This is why a change of quality takes place if this energy hasn't been protected, and there is a lack of it. As a result energy that should be intertwined, is simply not there.

Hypothetically, at this moment women can begin to cultivate their *Yang* energies, but their unregulated *Yin* energies may prevent this from happening. If this occurs they will be unable to access their Minor *Yang* energies, which they need to work with to build up their

Yang. By commencing practices long before this time, women can at least prepare themselves for such a change. With preparation, their chances of being able to work with their *Yang* energies at this time will greatly increase.

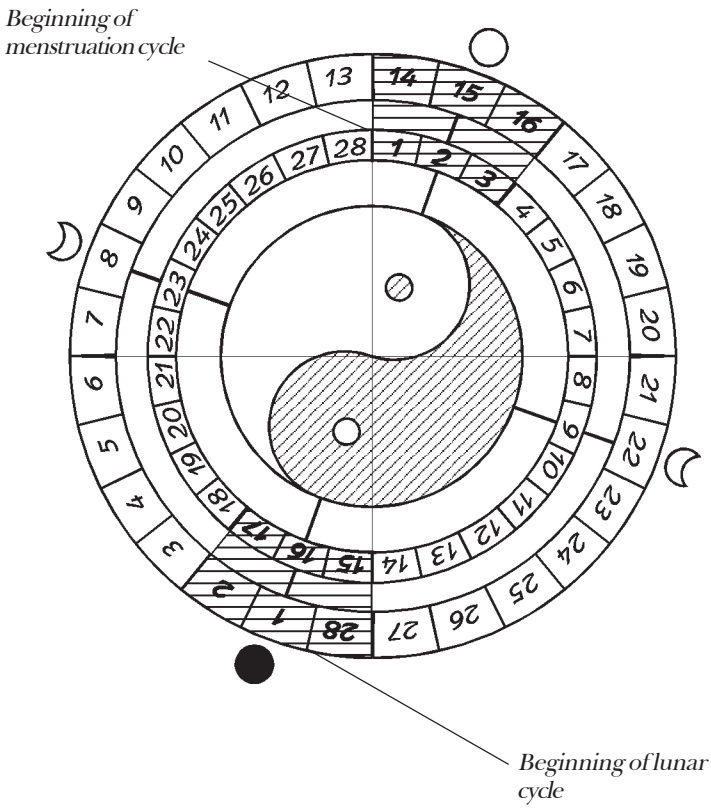
There is one more factor to consider during this process, which may happen much earlier than 49 years of age. It has been mentioned earlier, when we referred to women following their *yang* vector of development. In this vector practices are consciously directed towards stopping menstruation. In Taoist tradition it is called 'cutting off the dragon'. These practices are designed to connect with, and cultivate *Yang* energies.

If, after practising for a long time with a thorough understanding of personal rhythm and with an aim to strengthen and regulate *Yin* and cultivating *Yang* energies, women's menstruation ceases, it will indicate the success of their practice. In this case after nine months without menstruating, practices should be directed to the cultivation of *Yang* energies, when women's energy changes from *Yin* to *Yang* and their whole being assumes a different quality.

Nevertheless these transitional points should not be overlooked. As this process is cyclic, it does not depend on whether women practice to strengthen *Yin*, or cultivate *Yang*. In order to increase the quality of practice, each new step must be based on the energy previously cultivated and adopted. When women cultivate their *Yang* energies, they need three days to be able to adopt it. These three days relate to that period defined as menstruation.

If women are familiar with their personal rhythm, they will recognise the transition point, but if they have difficulty in feeling this moment, then it is best to relate it to the threshold of the full

moon. There is another approach menopausal women can use. They can relate their 'menstrual' cycle to the position of the moon at their moment of birth, or in other words, to their astrological moon. This method can only be approximated, yet it can be justified from the point of view of the shifts between *Yin* and *Yang*. Each person's moment of birth is fixed by the moon's position in the sky. The moon's symbolic growth begins from that moment, and subsequently moves between 'the full moon' and 'the new moon'. Each lunar month, when the moon returns to this same natal position, becomes their transitional moment. By understanding this transition, it becomes clear that it



corresponds to the transition of ovulation. After this the period of the moon's symbolic "growth" (the period of *yang* growth) starts. It's maximum increase is on day 14, 15 and 16 of the moon's transit, and is a transitional *yang* period, with maximal external manifestation, and a time of energetic menstruation.

This scheme could be used also for correlation of energetic menstruation with the actual lunar cycle. Here the first day of the moon represents a transition from maximum *yin* to a new born *yang*. The first day of symbolic menstruation, or quality change, falls on the maximum *yang* point, the symbolic threshold of the «full moon», or day 14, 16 and 16.

Thus, by knowing the days of change their own astrological 'lunar month', they will be able to utilise one more element to define the movement of their personal quality change. If women observe their internal changes during their lunar cycle, they could deepen their knowledge regarding any peculiarities within their own menstrual (real or energetic) cycles.

Days 14, 15 and 16 into menopausal women's personal 'new moon', represent that brief period when they can use the practices described in this chapter. However, leaning on these external factors of the natal moon and it's phase is merely an additional tool, to help find their own individual rhythm. If they have found their own rhythm naturally, they may discover that their cycle happens on the full moon period, just as women of the past found.

Under the conditions of life in a modern city, many of us have lost our rhythmic relationship with the moon. Therefore initially women need to depend on the practice and its rhythm. As this rhythm needs to be rebuilt on something, the lunar month can be used as a helpful tool in order to return to their own natural rhythm.

PART THREE

Tao Yin

If we listen, develop, and control the five internal organs, (heart, liver, kidneys, lungs and spleen) which form the basis of a woman's energy, we support the internal balance to encourage a life lived in happiness and peace. If the energy of these organs is out of control, then, through actions, we lose vitality because of the resulting uneven flow. This vitality exits through our eyes, ears, nose, and mouth.

The regulation and control of yin organs is the basis of the creation and development of *shen* spirit. The correct functioning of these organs, interdependently with *shen* spirit, helps us to promote its creation and development, rather than destruction.

When the Immortal Sisters created techniques that became the basis for preparing women for alchemical transformation, an independent system of *Tao Yin* manifested. This system included the following techniques: «*Tao Yin*» (working with the five organs), «*Yijin-jing*» (the change of tendons for the Weak) and «the Art of Transformation of Marrow» (connected with the transformation of bone marrow energy).

Today it is impossible to confidently define when this female line of Taoist method of development and perfection began to form. Nevertheless from the 13-14th centuries the system of knowledge used

by women was well structured, considering that it had remained contained and was not transferred to a wider circle. By perfecting these techniques a woman not only becomes a part of the Taoist structural system, but also extends her opportunities, and by doing so she is able to utilise states unobtainable by men.

Practices were stemmed from those used by Taoist men, but were actually used within a very narrow circle. Such techniques were not widely distributed, not only because they were secret, but also because of the lack of orientation toward yin energy. Although in some techniques it is precisely this energy which fosters the constructive and creative force. One of the main emphasis of these techniques is to work with the Conception vessel (meridian) that «turns the body toward Yin», so that Yang energy can be balanced, to be increased later. The work of this vessel in turn depends on the condition of the 5 yin organs which have a direct correspondence with the 5 senses. Contrary to men, the movements take far more energy from a woman than they give. What gives her energy is peace. However, her existence in this world demands a lot more movement than her nature is designed for. Being so active she loses control over her elements of transformation.

Active energy (energy which has a Yang vector of movement), has a straight (linear) flow in a woman and a spiral flow in a man. This results from a certain orientation of energetic centres, which is different in a woman from that of a man. Straight (linear) energy is unable to transform, and can only direct. (In this case we are talking about the energetic characteristic of the process as a whole).

This peculiarity relates to the activity of the senses especially when energy is directed either towards living and surviving; or towards

consuming. It is not directed towards development and fulfilment. *Tao Yin* practice specifically enables the catching of this energy to transform it later into an orbit. This is reflected in its name, *Tao Yin* or the "Art of five orbits».

Thus, gaining control of yin organ energy is the primal orientation of the *Tao Yin* complex. Once this state is reached, we can speak about controlling energy as a whole and cultivating it. If we begin too soon to try to increase the streams of energy, before gaining control over Yin energy organs, we would consume a larger part of what has been cultivated. By practising *Tao Yin* we should not try to reach quick results. This practice should help to gather the strength to be used later.

It is important to bring your attention to the position of the body during these practices. The bench we sit on should not be too high, but the pelvis should be slightly higher than the legs. We can use a cushion, but do not forget that the body should be straight with no backward or forward angle.

Preparatory part

These exercises are performed slowly and with a relaxed but attentive mind; typically they should take 10-15 minutes. It is best to hold each position for approximately three minutes. The quality of the whole sequence depends on the attentive execution of this preparatory part.

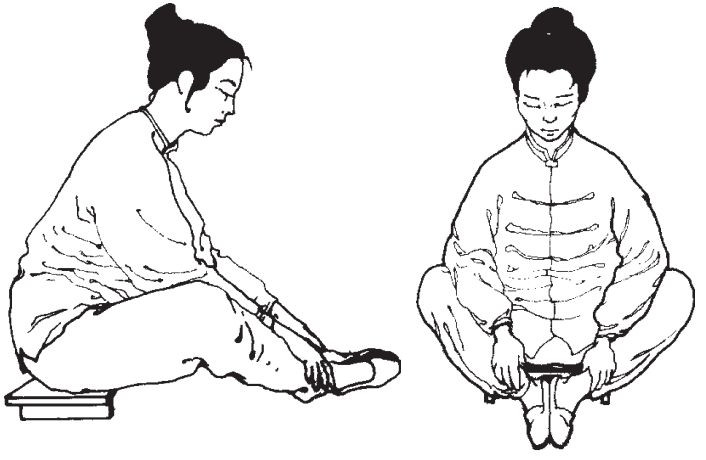
The Breath. Breathing is constant and unrestricted, as if it where not there, while it is there. When we are relaxed, the breathing is quiet and fine, the mood levelled and calm. The abdomen is relaxed

and filled with breath. Do not compress or pressurise the lower abdomen, as this will adversely influence the organs of this area.

Fill the upper part of the abdomen on inhalation (the diaphragm rises) and on exhalation relax the lower part of the abdomen. Do not extend the abdominal muscles on inhalation but fill the abdomen radially, enlivening and filling the waist meridian.

On exhalation, the breath flows naturally to the lower part of the abdomen filling the womb.

First position: The body leans slightly forward so that the energy flows down to the lower part of the abdomen. The back is straight, neither stooping nor overly tensed.



The head is aligned with the back. The neck is slightly extended or lifted, so that the base of the skull remains open. The chin is gently pulled in. Shoulders and elbows are relaxed, so that the roundness of the arms helps to fill both the arms and the abdomen with energy.

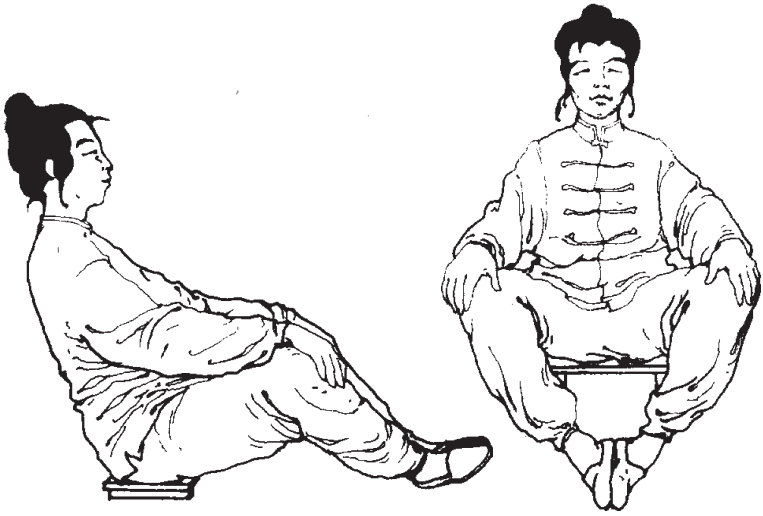
The soles of the feet are together, legs slightly extended forward, hands grasping the ankles.

Second Position: Slowly raise the body to the vertical position. The crown of the head is directed up. The hands grasp just below the knees so that the thumbs are fixed on liver meridian point ('*Zhong-du*'). We are enabling the flow of energy to descend the front of the body and fill the abdomen.

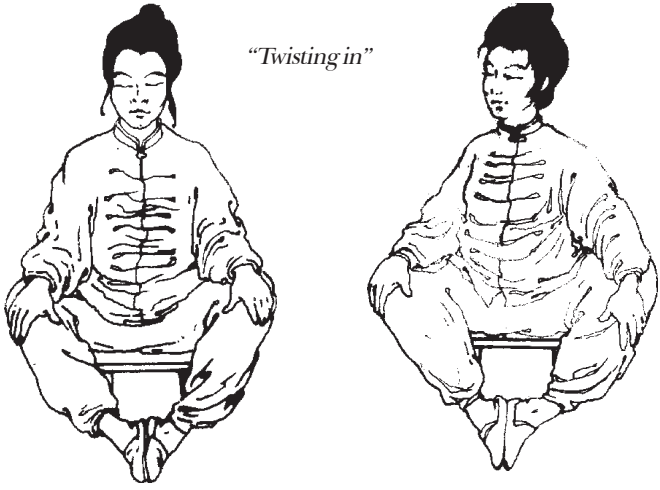
Third Position: Softly move the body until the torso is leaning backwards, the arms holding the knees, the head and back aligned.

Using the wrists, try to keep the line of the back and neck straight without bending the lower part of the back. Relax and fill the abdomen.

Return to the central or vertical position. Pause briefly.



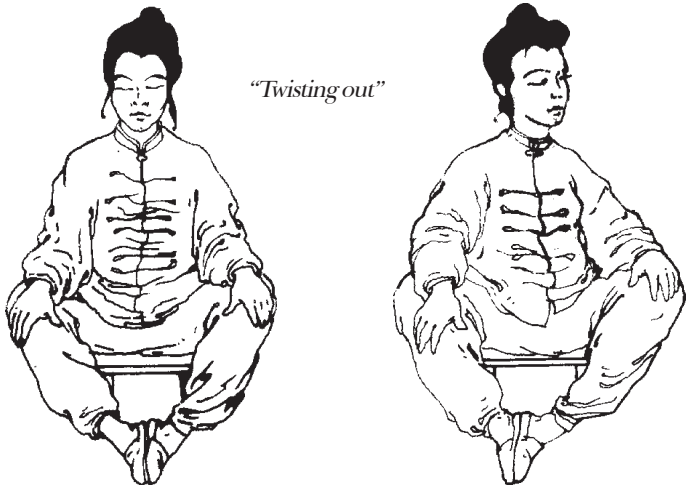
Fourth Position: Slightly lean to the left, while twisting to the right about 45°. Maintain the vertical axis of the head and spine. The left arm moves down the leg, the right arm slides up to the knee.



The sacrum is slightly stretched, creating the support for the lowest point of the torso, so that the axis is screwed into the base, creating a "funnel". Concentrate on the perineum.

Return to the central position.

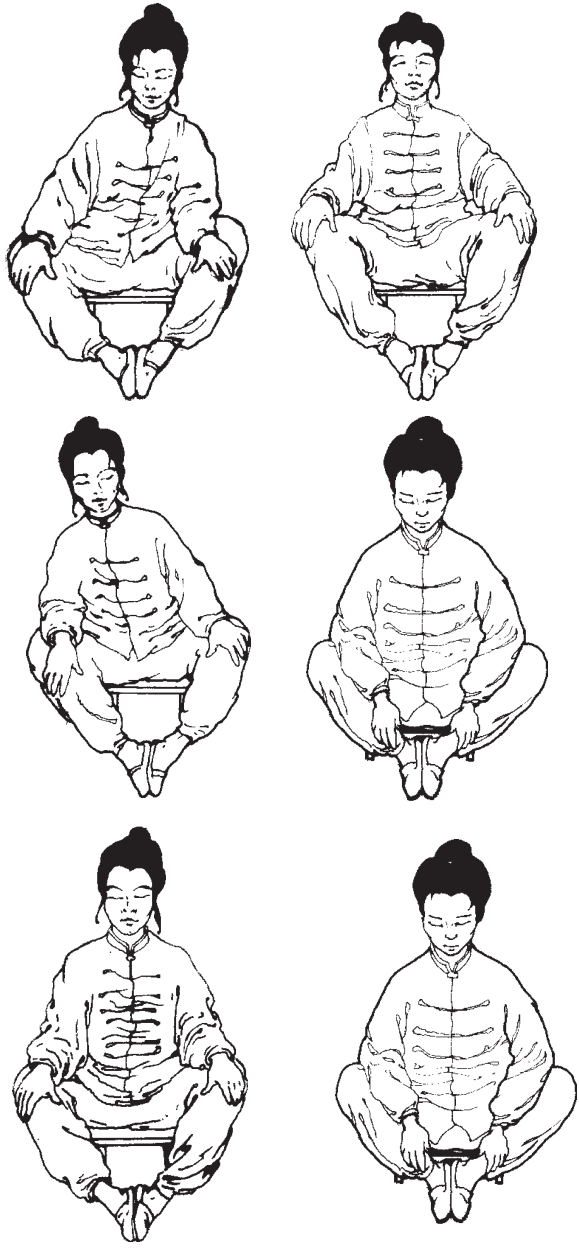
Fifth Position: Lean to the right, twisting to the left. Unscrew the axis in the upward direction and direct your concentration to the crown.



Return to the central position.

Sixth Position: Lean toward the feet, keeping the back straight. Start a slow rotation to the left, back, right and front sides.

Be attentive during each position, focusing on the stated points. After three full circles we stop in the front inclined position. Relax the abdomen. Slowly return to the upright position.



Position for Meditation

On returning to the upright position we are now ready to meditate.

Pull the legs towards you and sit in a lotus or semi-lotus position. Stay in this position for not less than 10 minutes. Relax the abdomen and remain aware of your breathing.

Beginning

The position of the legs is the same as for meditation, preferably semi-lotus.

1. Put the hands together creating a slight pressure at the fingertips. Feel the tension in the tips of the fingers, this activates the heart and pericardium meridians. You can remain in this position for a few minutes.

2. Then, by leaning forward, separate the hands bringing the arms down in a circle behind you to the area of the kidneys. Then bring the palms forward, past the waist, until the elbows are beside the waist. The forearms are parallel and horizontal. All bending movement starts in the waist.

3. Once again bend forward, drawing the elbows back. Turn the arms out in a circle rotating them from the elbows and bring them forward until the hands are levelled with the chest. All movements are circular.

4. Now make the elbows the points of rotation, and circle the forearms down until they cross over.

5. Keeping the forearms crossed, lift the arms and place the palms on the shoulders. Place the thumbs on the points next to shoulder joints. The impulse for all movements of the arms and shoulders comes from the back.

6. Bring the arms down, until the forearms are parallel and horizontal to the ground.

"Weaving Loom"

The "impulse" for each movement commences at the waist, this will activate and fill the waist meridian.

1. Turn from the waist to the left, pulling the left elbow backwards and turning the palms down as the arms move. The right forearm moves until it is parallel to the left thigh. The left arm is now at 90° to the right arm. Then, turn the left arm over from the elbow, so that both arms are parallel, palms up.

2. Turn from the waist to the right, pulling the right elbow backwards. Turn the palms down as the arms move. The left forearm moves in the horizontal plane until it is parallel to the right thigh. The right arm should be perpendicular to the left arm. Then, turn the right arm over from the elbow, so that both arms are parallel, palms up.

3. Turn back to the center, bringing the left hand over the right hand in front of you, palms down. Hands move towards the body until the left hand rests on the right, with palms up.

4. Commencing movement from the back, while keeping the arms crossed, lift the hands up, placing the palms on the shoulders with thumbs on the same points.

Bring them down into a horizontal, parallel position.

5. Now repeat the "weaving loom" one more time, commencing with a turn to the right. When the hands return to the center, place the left hand over the right, palms down.

6. Move the arms towards the body, lift them and turn the palms facing outwards.

"Large Circle"

1. All movements commence at the waist. Turn your palms towards your body. Left arm moves up simultaneously with right arm moving down. Make a slight turn to the left forming a circle between

the arms. Return to the central position with the right arm up and left down.

2. Repeat the movement, this time commencing with a turn to the right. Keep the movements circular.

3. Exchange the arm positions in front of you, without turning to the side, again the shape of the arms should contain a circle.

4. Then rotate the arms along the large circle in both directions. At the end the palms turn. The waist participates in this movement as well, although it is not so noticeable.

5. Bring palms together. Left arm is outside (the arm that moves up is *always* outside). Create ball position with the arms.

"The Ball"

Imagine the hands are holding a ball about the size of a volley or basketball. Keep the relationship of the hands as if on opposite sides of this ball at all times. Begin with the left hand on top and the right hand underneath. The centre of the ball is at the level of solar plexus and remains so during all the rotations. Each movement commences from the waist.

In the first sequence of rotations we will rotate the energy away from the body and in the second sequence we will rotate the energy toward from the body. Each sequence has four axes of rotation; diagonal to the left, diagonal to the right, straight ahead and side to side.

1. Rotate the ball away from you, half a turn or 180° each time

Left diagonal axis

Right diagonal axis

Forward axis

Right side axis

Left side axis

2. Rotate the ball **toward** you, half a turn or 180° each time.

Left diagonal axis

Right diagonal axis

Forward axis

Forward axis one more time

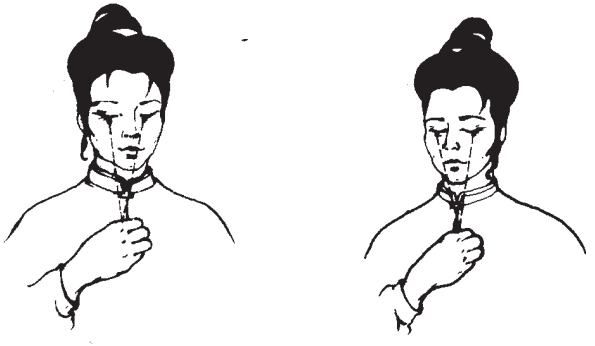
Exercises with the Eyes (sight)

Bring the fingers of the right hand together with the thumb. Gaze at the tips of the fingers throughout this sequence. The left palm is open and placed below the belly.

Feel the vertical axis, especially in the neck region. Maintain the connection between the neck and the back of the head during the movement.

As you breathe in, turn your head to the left, without moving your gaze from the fingers.

As you breathe out, come back to the central position. Then breath in - turn to the right; breath out – return to the central position. Repeat three times. Open the right palm at the position in front of the chest.



Work with the Sound (hearing)

As we breathe in, we use the 'impulse' from the waist to move the right hand to the ear. Close the hand beside the ear and by rubbing the fingers together, make a sound.

'Capture' the sound and listen to it as you breathe out. The waist turns to the left, lowering and opening the right arm. Open the palm. The left palm gathers into a fist. The sound is lowered down to the abdomen.

Again bring the right hand to the ear and open it with the turn. Repeat three times.

Exercise with the Nose (smelling)

Bring the right hand to the nose, breath in.

The thumb closes the right nostril while the index finger is fixed on the third eye region.

Left palm is gathered in a fist.

In this position do the following series of breathing:
Inhale, then on exhalation relax the centre of your head.
Inhale again, relaxing the centre of abdomen on exhalation.
Repeat each series five times.

Work with the Throat (speech)

After working with the sense of smell, move the right hand to the level of the throat, palm open. Gaze into the centre of the palm.

Inhale into the centaur of the throat, exhale into the centre of the palm. Then alternate, inhaling into the centre of the palm and exhaling into the centre of the throat. Altogether ten inhalations-exhalations. At the end, lower the right palm under the left fist.

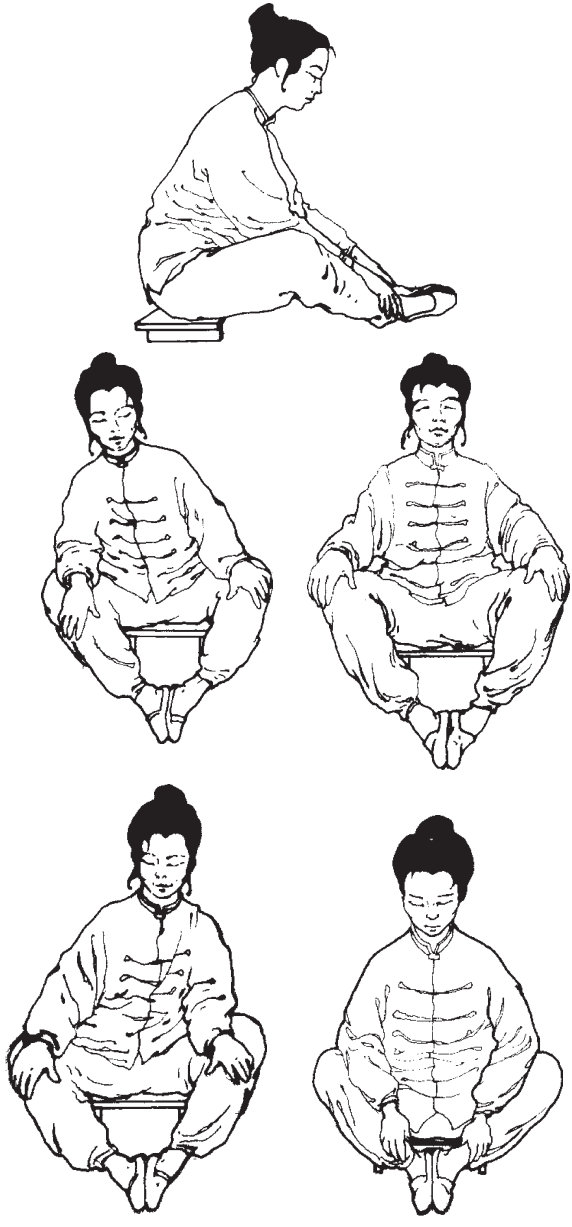
Finale

Keeping the hands together, inhale and raise the arms from the belly to the level of the chest in an outward arc. The arms should contain a circle. Then the palms turn outward and are raised above the head as you exhale. Follow with the opposite movement, bring the hands down to the belly. Repeat this three times.

Conclusive part

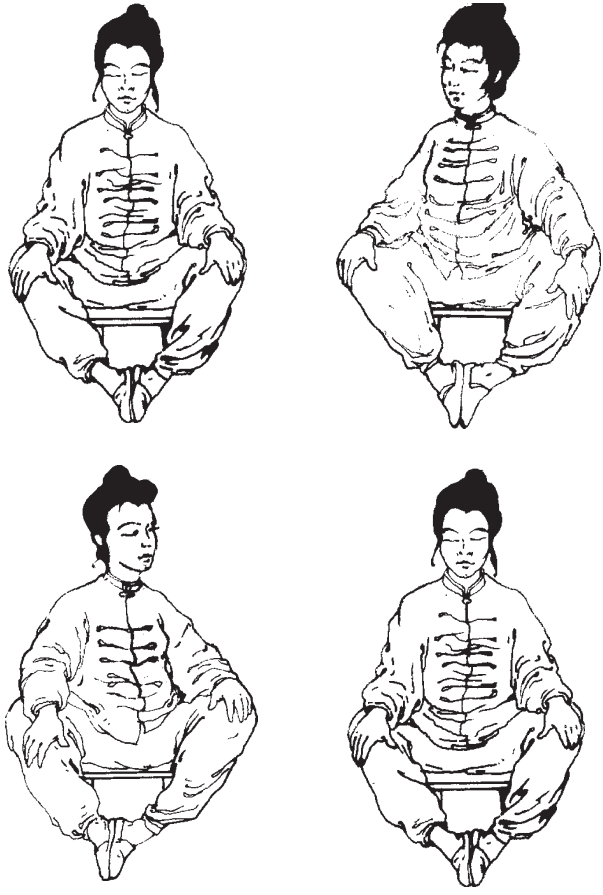
As in the preparatory part, bring the legs in front of you.

1. Commence a clockwise rotation: to the right, to the back, to the left, to the front. Three circles.



2. Then incline forward maintaining the axis of spine and head, relax the abdomen. Return to the central position, relax and fill the abdomen. Then lean back relaxing the abdomen. Return to the middle position.

3. From the middle position we "unscrew" ourselves by leaning to the right and slightly turning to the left; then "screw in", leaning to the left, slightly turning to the right. As we untwist, we listen with our attention to the crown, as we "screw in" – to the perineum.



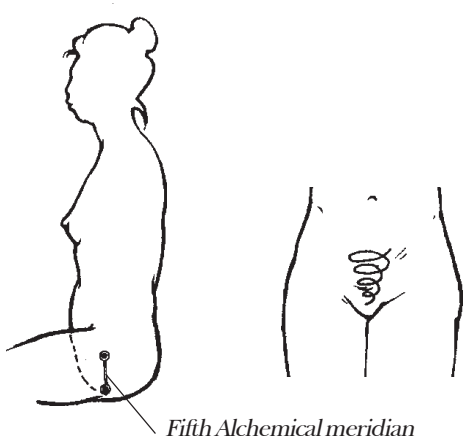
4. Return to the initial position. (The end of the exercises)

Before getting up, massage your legs by passing the hands over both sides of each leg. Then massage your kidneys using soft, circular movements, slowly moving the waistline, turning it from one side and another. You should not get up immediately, allow the energy to settle in.

In the first stage of your practice, your concentration is directed to the correct execution of the exercises, and the observation of the principles involved. If the principles are observed properly, the practices will become a meditation in movement. In time, the moving energy will start to intertwine.

Practices with the Feet

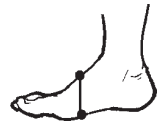
Practices with the feet are connected with certain aspects of alchemical work. Feet have a vertically oriented first alchemical meridian. This orientation can be used in the further formation of the fifth meridian situated in the lower abdomen. In women this meridian can not function in the same way as in men.



In men, their prostate gland pre-conditions the formation of this meridian. Women do not have this gland, however, they do have a cavity, or womb, where the energy can intertwine. Therefore, although they lack this particular meridian, they do have an energy

flow. Men on the other hand, have a meridian, but need to create an energy flow within that meridian.

It is difficult for women to form this meridian. In the past it was considered that they were unable to form the meridian by themselves at all and in order to do the alchemical work, they utilised the male penis to perform the function of an absent meridian. This caused the energy to rotate, increasing the flow in the ovaries, activating the process of formation of this meridian. It would be difficult today for a woman to find a man, whose penile energy would assist her in substituting this missing energetic channel. Nevertheless, today we can discuss additional consciousness work and techniques (when used correctly) which could help to increase her ability to do this. Women's energies in the lower part of their abdomen cannot be properly used, because there is no proper upward flow of energy and dissipation occurs. By mastering their yin energy in the feet and intertwining it, women are able to create conditions in the lower abdomen for the formation of the alchemical basis. So we need to use the work with vertically oriented feet meridians in order to activate the function of the fifth alchemical meridian.



In order to help the energy so that it can intertwine within the feet, the actual work, in accordance with the principles of vessel formation, should be aimed at the feet. The construction created in this way should resemble the form of a womb, similar to that of the *Supreme centre* during its formation. Primarily, the feet need to become used to the structural energy forming within them. The structure is characterised by its intertwining system, which gives it (structure) a

specific form. This linkage is achieved by directional means. In principle, both feet have a different direction of energetic flow. One foot can even have a multi-directional energetic flow that needs to be intertwined. If we want to link the energies in both feet simultaneously, it is a lot harder to do with two than it is with one. This is why certain Taoist schools practice with only one foot, excluding the other one from the process, because to form energy in both feet simultaneously is very hard.

The multi-directional flow of energy movements, can be worked through by using those positions, where the energy ties up naturally at angles of 45° and 90°. These angles create the effect that is used when intertwining a pattern. Straight lines indicate working with an expanded consciousness, while crooked lines are working with the basis formation.

Another aspect of practising with the feet, is their connection with the control and saturation of the liver meridian, which in turn influences the blood. The blood, as we have already seen, is a major distributor of *jing* energy in women, and this energy must be cemented in order to improve the function of this meridian. The meridian is directly connected with the foot's energetic vessel, and if not functioning properly the function of the *yin* channels of the feet begin to degrade.

In turn the liver channel is greatly affected by this negative influence, causing energetic blood pollution. The conclusion would be that it is a prerequisite for women to control the work of their feet and to restructure their vessels for alchemical practice.

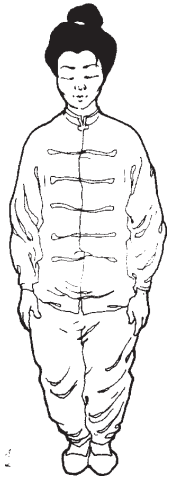
The following technique has great significance when the work of preparing the vessels of the feet is conducted. Its main features

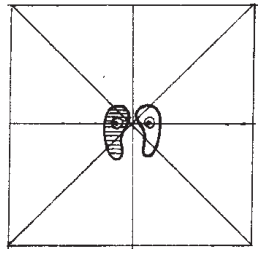
include: maintaining a connection with the earth; observing directionality; maintaining the axis of the feet; energy linking in different positions created by angles; formation of *jing* energy in the feet by directing the energy flow towards the centre and finally, pulling the energy upwards by means of turning on the toes and working with the axis.

Entrance

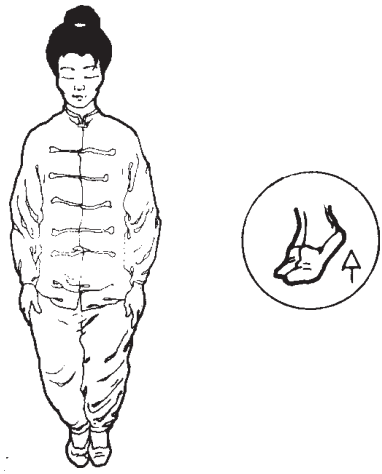
Initial position: Feet are together, knees slightly bent, centred along the axis. In this position you must feel the contours of the feet.

Position of the left foot is drawn (see fig).

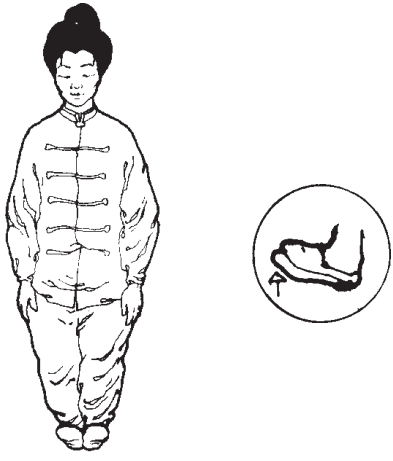




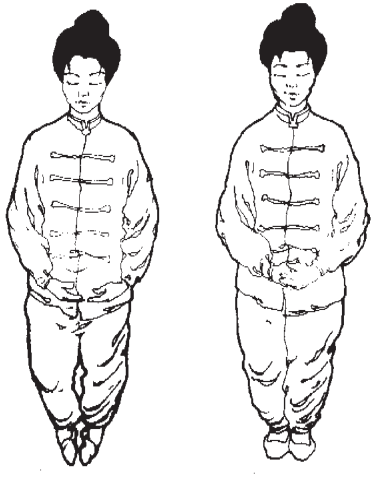
Lift up onto the tips of your toes. This movement pulls the energy to the centre of the soles of your feet. Use your feet to keep your balance.



Shift body weight to the heels, lifting the toes and balancing the body.



Lower yourself down slightly, putting your weight onto the external sides of your feet.



Arms are slightly bent at the wrists, and pulled apart, as if holding onto something.

Then:

Return to the initial position, with palms on the abdomen. Lower yourself down in this way, three times.

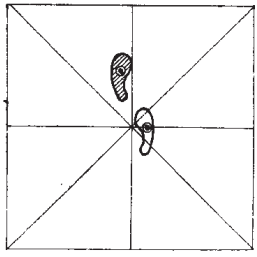
'Angles'

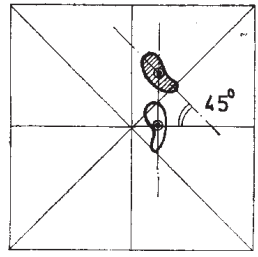
Slightly bend your knees and shift your weight into the right leg, bringing the left foot in front.

At first, the direction of the movement of the left foot is parallel to the front one, then it starts to turn to a 45° angle.

Position the foot so that the tip of the right foot faces the centre of the left foot.

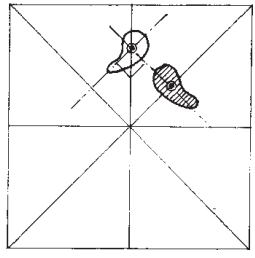
Shift your weight into the left leg.



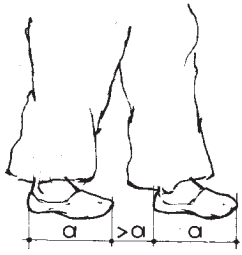


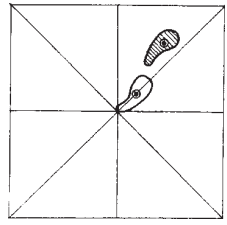
Bring your attention to your knees, which are constantly bent as we shift from one leg to the other. The weight must be correctly shifted: feet are not to be lifted before all the weight has been shifted to the other leg. It is only in this way that you will be able to intertwine the energy in your feet, by releasing it. After shifting your weight to the left leg, the tip of the right foot lifts from the ground and (as a result of waist and thigh movements), is placed next to the heel of the left foot. All these minor movements must be done so that the *jing* energies in the feet are not dissipated.

Repeat the same movement with the right foot: bringing it forward parallel to the left, turn it to an angle of 90°.



Shift the weight completely into the right foot, and bring the left one forward (as a result of waist and thigh movement), till parallel.



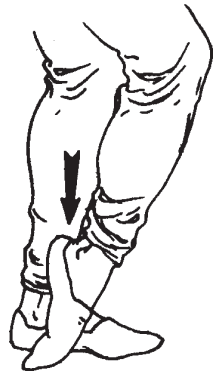


'Press'

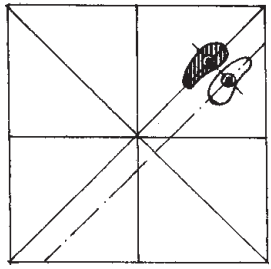
The next movement is directly connected with the production of *jing* energy by the central part of the foot.

Bring the weight into the left foot and move the waist in such a way, that the right hip is turned to the left, and the tip of the foot is next to the left heel.

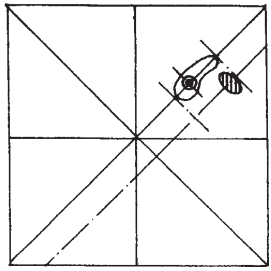
From this position (resulting from the waist returning to its initial position and sitting down), we press on the tip of the right foot. Squeeze the centre of the sole of the foot and slightly fix it into this position.



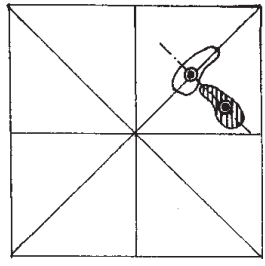
Lift the right foot and place it parallel to the left.



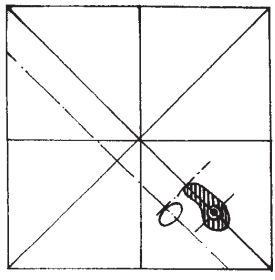
After the shift of weight into the right leg, we turn at the waist and press, this time to the left foot.



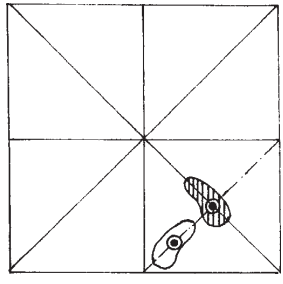
Then we separate the left foot from the floor, placing it at a 90° angle, along the line of movement.



We shift our weight onto it, then repeat the same thing by turning and pressing on the tip of the right toe.

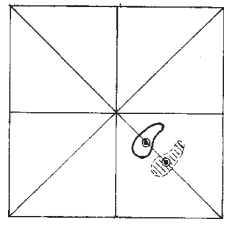


Next the right foot is placed at a 90° angle along the line of movement. In this position, the knees are bent.



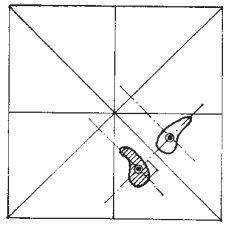
'Turn'

We shift our weight into the right foot and place the left foot parallel to the right, and next to it, although it does not touch the floor. Bring your attention to the centre of the foot.



Lift the left knee up, covering the right knee with the left foot. Place the foot forward, perpendicular to the right foot.

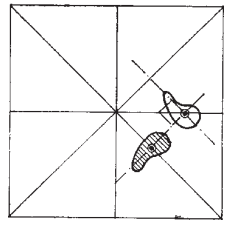
In this position we slightly lower ourselves down (at first), by lifting the heel to the right foot, that is behind.



View from behind

Then we lift onto the tips of the toes, turn, to end up in that same perpendicular position. This time however, the right foot is in front of you. This movement is connected with the energy being pulled

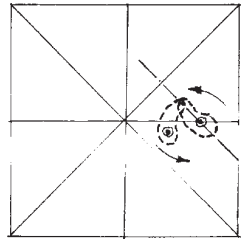
upward. You have to maintain the feeling of being along the axis, as if in the moment of rotation, you are being pulled by the tip of your head.



'A funnel'

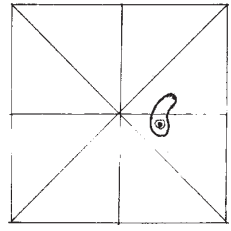
Lean back in such a way as to create a funnel as you turn. The weight is in the back leg.

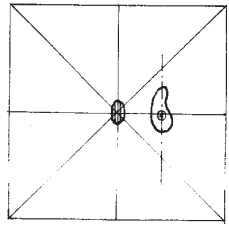
We start turning to the left, by turning the right foot first.



It is turned to the point of direction, opposite the initial one.

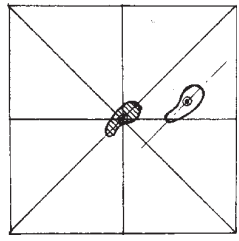
Then put the weight into it, by lifting the left leg and bringing the foot to the knee.





Then place it behind, on the tip of the toes

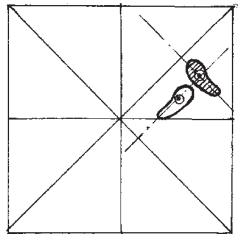
Finally, the feet are turned to a parallel position of 45° toward the direction of the movement (as in the initial position).



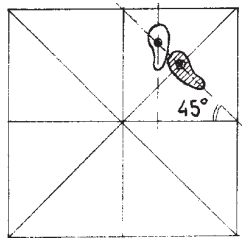
'Angles'

Repeat the same movements as at the beginning.

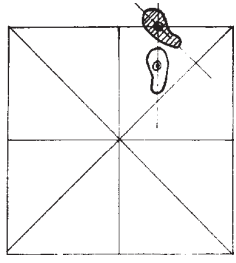
The first movement - the left foot turns to 90°.



Then bring the right foot, turning it around 45°.

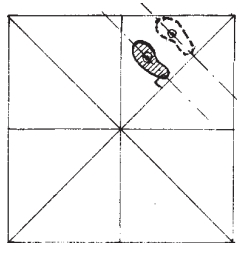


Shift the weight and bring the left foot to a 45° angle.



Then shift all the weight into the left foot and bring the right foot to the left one.

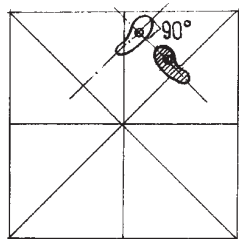
Do not place it onto the floor.



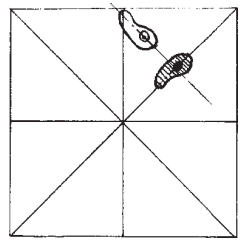
'Turn'

This turn is a mirror reflection of the previous one.

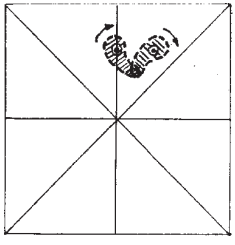
Lift the right knee, by covering the left one with the right foot. Then place the right foot perpendicular to the left.



Lower your body down and lift the left heel, then lift up on your toes and turn. In the final position the feet are perpendicular, the left one is in front

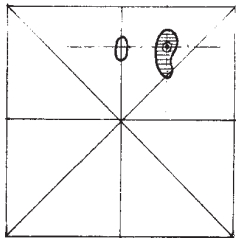


'Funnel'

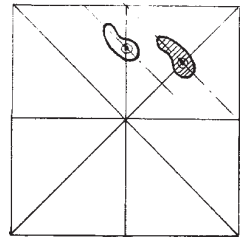


The weight is on the right leg. Start to turn, turning the left leg first.

Turn it as far as you can, and put your weight into it. Then lift the right foot, placing it behind on the tips of the toes.



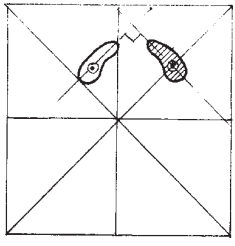
In this position your torso is turned to that same side as in the beginning of the exercise.

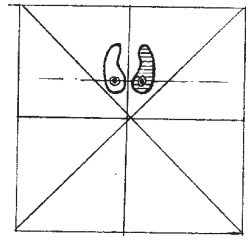


Turn the feet to a parallel position, (by making a 45° turn), this time however, your back faces the opposite direction (to the initial position).

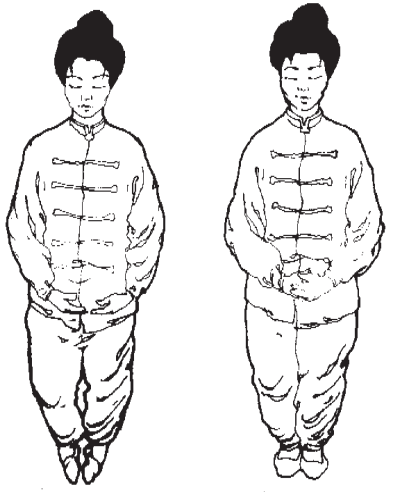
'Exit'

Lower yourself down, turning to the right foot. The tips of the feet are facing, both sides at a 90° angle. Shift the weight into the right foot. Bring the left foot over, placing the tips of both feet together. Straighten out.





Thus, the final position is opposite to the initial one. Then lower yourself down three times, as in the beginning, by leaning on the external side of the foot.



If initially this seems complex, difficult and confusing, don't worry, just continue your work. It is useful to practice remembering the sequence of movements. It helps with concentration, and gives the right pressure to the brain. The movements of the feet can also be done individually, one by one. For example, simple shifting, by putting the feet first at a 45° angle, and then at a 90° angle. Then practice doing the turns. You may alternate shifts, turns and tunnel exercises.

There should be no thoughtless feet movements, attention to the feet here, is the most important thing. Observe the construction of the movement№s axis, notice if they are parallel or perpendicular. Free your leg before lifting it up, and correctly shift your weight. As you press onto the foot, slightly fix it, giving the energy a chance to intertwine.

Work with the feet can also be useful as a preparatory technique before the practices, as it helps to redistribute energy in the head. For example, if you start to practice with a septenary orbit for the head, and the energy in the head is highly concentrated, then this practice will increase, rather than lessen unnecessary manifestations.

Therefore, work with the feet will help women to redistribute their energy overall and pull away unnecessary energy from the head.

Working with Masks

A prerequisite for women's development is the work done with consciousness. Regardless of direction of efforts, this must be done consciously. However, in order for their consciousness to be supportive in redistributing energies, as well as to develop concentration, they must learn to relax their heads. Much has been mentioned previously concerning this, yet there is one more technique we should look at when working with this zone.

Specifically this is a technique designed to relax your head, not from the inside, but from the outside. This is important for a woman, as this path is more familiar to her. External relaxation of the head has a connection with mime. We are not discussing those acts, easily forgotten during the course of the day, but rather those mimes we practice relating to the expression of different emotional states. When we want to control our expression, we normally tense our face, rather than relax it. Very often it is easier to put on a hard mask, than it is not to.

In reality a fine facial, muscular structure has specific zones, which absorb and redistribute energies in a specific way -

preconditioned by certain glands. Specifically each facial expression reflects different states, conditioned by activation of the function of certain glands. Women also use makeup to imitate emotional functions: using colours to either increase or decrease the energy movements on the various zones on their face. By putting on makeup while in an intense emotional state, they project this onto the face, and wear it externally (as well as internally), all day.

It is essential to learn how to relax the face. This process of relaxation affects the glands, which in turn influences the process of internal relaxation. A Budda's smile not only indicates the specific state, but it also shows a real ability to activate these glands, connected with that state. On the other hand, the glands motivated increase facial expressions, reacting to stimuli.

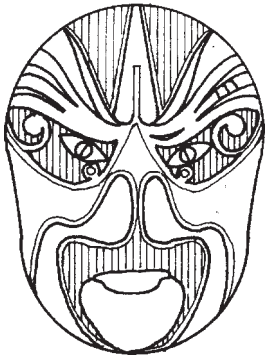
Masks, created by people in the past showed these zones in an exaggerated way and demonstrated emotions or manifestations of specific energy styles. They were sacred, carrying the meaning of mimed reactions, or the manifestations of the angers and joys of the gods or deities. By wearing these masks, people not only absorbed the strength of that spirit, but also the emotional states they portrayed.

Today the meaning of internal work with mime is forgotten. Even though women are considered to be natural actresses, there is a difference between acting and demonstrating certain states, and acting in order to work with internal states. The first thing women must learn is to relax their faces. Their smile must come from within, smoothing away the mime imposed lines, and taking the pressure off from the muscles and glands.

The energy of those glands can be used for practice, in turn, with the *Ni Wang Gong* centre. Here the mime helps the glands to

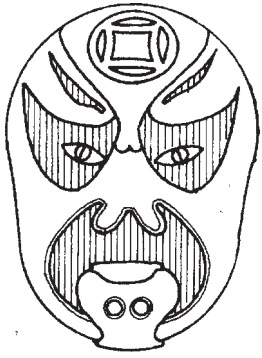
produce energy of a specific quality. Because the emotional state is controlled, this energy can be directed to develop the *Ni Wang Gong* centre. These masks reflect certain states, which are activated by specific glands and there are defined zones and pressure regions connected with these glands.

Practice with these glands and zones will help to regulate the head vessel. This is important for reconstructing the "Feet Lower abdomen Brain" connections. With time and an understanding of which mask is dominated by which gland, it will be possible to work with these zones in greater detail. However, practice with the masks must begin and end with facial relaxation. Before applying or removing makeup, it is important to do these relaxation techniques. In fact, women of the past used makeup to work with various states and energies. This was one of the elements of magic we will discuss in the next chapter.

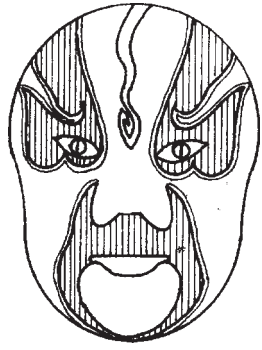


The frontal gland

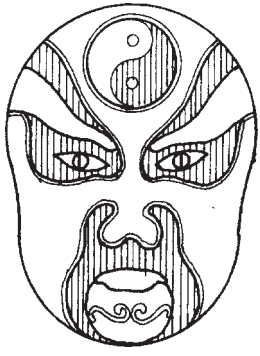
Glands of the cheek-bones



Glands of the temples

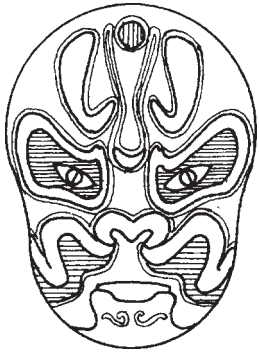


Maxillary glands
(Jaw glands)

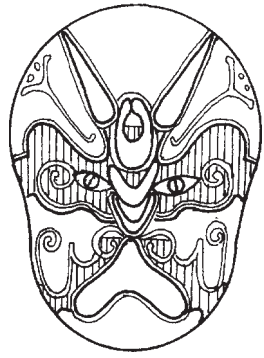


The gland of the chin

Glands of the eyebrows



Gland between the nose and the upper lip



Glands of the eyes

PART FOUR

Magical Taoism

When we analyse Taoist alchemy for women, we must bring our attention to the fact that alchemical knowledge, formed within the framework of defining the art of interaction with the world around us, is also known as the art of magic.

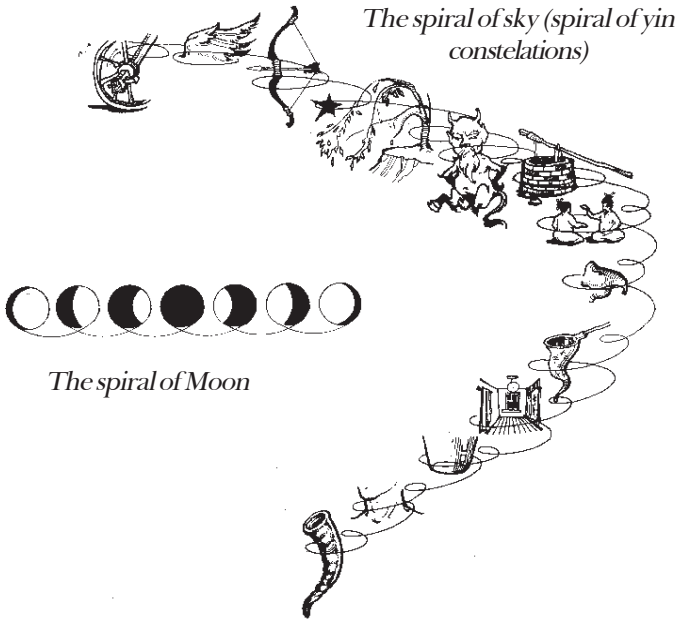
Taoist alchemy has historically developed into a series of sciences. The basis of Taoist alchemy is magical Taoism, in itself including aspects related to *Yin* energy construction. Knowledge is *Yin*, while the ability to use it is *Yang*. In Taoism, women are *Yin* elements, represented as elements which contain. This concept co-ordinates with a spiral, which is related to creation of constellations, the moon and earthly branches.

Knowledge, as a female energy, manifests in all magical traditions (*Mao Shan,* the '*Four elements*', the '*Seven forces*'). Later when alchemical techniques began to form, they also began to take on different qualities for men and women.

All male techniques emphasised the development of an internal spiral, yet externally theire movements were simple and organised. For women, it was the other way around. Their movements were followed by numerous, wavelike, coiling movements, demonstrating external spiral work. Today there are few techniques remaining for

women. One of them is the technique of the snake.

The main task of magical Taoism was to connect various components of life. It helped to transform the life force, and to protect oneself against the evil forces, enemies, or to search for success in something.



The development of magical Taoism occurred in the period when energetic possibilities were different for humans than they are today. In those times people were not only able to perceive forces, unseen by us today, but could also structure their lives according to specific energetic principles. They directed all this to their interaction with the sun, moon, constellations, and the earth (especially its stones, being the major accumulators for earthly energies). It was precisely a

certain quality in the female nature that enabled women not only to see these interactions, but also to work with them.

At this time men used women to help develop their own possibilities and knowledge. Today, this situation has completely turned around. In the past, most developed women embraced the concept of *Feng Shui* to increase their energy, as a result of a restructuring of their living space and actions.

Actually, magic, as we know it today, was hidden behind this concept. It was a method for humans to reach the highest energetic results and states. Sometimes however the enormous force used could

destroy the user, as well as those around them, because they were unable to control it.

One of the highest manifestations of magical Taoism was the emergence of the alchemical Pill of Immortality. Many tried to achieve this elixir, but only a few have managed to advance on this path. In their striving to find immortality, people swallowed minerals, poisons, lead, mercury and so on. By these efforts they tried to activate and transform their energies.

Even today, there are groups whose followers try to create a "pill", which will at least enable them to prolong their lives. Although many have in fact shortened their lives by taking wrong ingredients and incorrect doses at the wrong time, this all helped the development of Taoist medicine, with many volunteering to partake in experiments. Contrary to internal alchemical practices, when the "pill" is cultivated inside the body by means of inherent energy, the added influence of external energetic structure becomes very risky.

Today's magic is viewed either as a fight with evil spirits, or the calling upon of higher forces to help those who need it (on a personal level). This is a primitive view of magic. Although this particular stream is highly developed now, it has very little in common with its original source. People who involve themselves in these things are, to a large extent, uneducated in this sphere of knowledge, and are very ambitious. In either case all this leads to an inaccurate understanding of magic, by covering all its positive aspects. For example, the division between black and white magic created competition, rather than a deep and fundamental sharing of knowledge. Such a serious and magical art as *Feng Shui* is demonstrated today as a modern, avant-garde stream, with a touch of mysticism.

Let us try to understand the basis of, for instance, black magic. Contrary to the general view, it does not mean that some bad people perform negative actions. Black magic implies practice with rough, dense energy, referred to as practice with black energy or *yin* energy. This concept also implies the art of controlling those energies by women, which is why it is also referred to as women's magic. Black magic uses a large number of amulets, which help to transform energy. Interestingly enough today we all passively partake to some degree in magic. Namely, money, being one of the main magical attributes. In the past it was connected with sacrifices and was one of the major instruments of magic. Today it has no sacred meaning for us.

Shamanic magic in its own right, was a powerful tool influencing the world around it. The laws of existence were defined for everyone to experience. Magicians were familiar with people's energetic structures and could read them. Today people's lives are chaotic alchemically speaking. They have no balance and therefore, the art of its application has lost its meaning. There may be many who would disagree with this statement. In order to agree with anything though, we must learn how to live in agreement with our own thoughts, feelings and actions first.

The rebirth of magic, and its interaction with our culture, can only take place within enclosed spaces and lines, where lives are restructured according to specific rhythms. When speaking of shamanism, we imply paganism, the developmental source of all familiar religions. The development of human power was its basis, and when this power was acquired, it was used to interact with divine spirits.

Today, the power of the human beings, their actions and energetic qualities, are ignored by many religions. Our interaction with the spirit world has been substituted by intercession from a priest, a mufti, or a rabbi. The way of interaction has also been greatly changed.

As a system, Taoism, originated out of shamanism, holding the same principles and concepts at its base. It has maintained a lot of magical methods and knowledge, and can be divided into three branches.

1 *Shen* cultivation. The development of a spiritual base in a human being, relating to today's white magic.

2 *Jing* cultivation. The art of interaction with the space around us for healing and protection.

3 *Qi* cultivation. The development of vital life energy. Working with emotions and unrefined animalistic energies. Black, or *Yin* Magic belongs to this branch. The work with seven *Po* spirits is also defined. The structure of *Po* spirits is sometimes referred to as the *"Po* tree". It is a most interesting part of magical Taoism. The magician needs to know how to prepare seven alchemical potions, in order to understand this "tree".

The Seven Alchemical Potions of *Po* Spirits

1 The alchemical potion, that purifies breathing
2 The alchemical potion, that purifies the voice
3 The alchemical potion, that purifies hearing
4 The alchemical potion, that purifies seeing, vision
5 The alchemical potion, that purifies taste

6 The alchemical potion, that purifies the consciousness

7 The alchemical potion, that purifies yin organs (liver, spleen, lungs, kidneys, heart)

After appropriate preparation, the magician begins to master the seven spirals of *Po* spirits. This enables them to change the energetic structures of either a human being, a tree or a cloud. This practice depends on the magician's power. Usually it was done by a female magician, a female shaman or *Shu*.

Her practice involved the use of *ling-qi* energy (see *«Alchemy of Tai Ji»)*. On a physical plane, this energy is located in the lymphatic glands and is connected to the yin energy of the senses. All human creation is based on *ling-qi* energy, which helps to connect the essence of the heavens to the essence of the earth. These two types of essences created *Shi* and *Wu*. *Shi* refers to men who have the capacity to recreate the world, while *Wu* refers to women, who contain the power to transform themselves from the inside. *Shi* was created by means of three *Hun* spirits, or three rotations of *Hun*. *Wu* was created by means of seven *Po* spirits, or seven rotations of *Po*.

To gain mastery over these rotations, is to gain mastery over movement, which is connected to something, or someone, else. This concept is still alive today and magicians and shamans use circles and rotations in their magic. In the past it was proceeded by two dances. One of the dances consisted of seven parts, the other of three parts. These dances were used in Taoist ceremonies in the time of the Han dynasty. Later they were transformed into various types of movements, united by meanings of *Li* or *Kan*.

Li contains the meaning of the dance of *Hun* spirits. *Kan* contains the meaning of the dance of *Po* spirits. There were different

interpretations regarding the significance of these dances. Their main purpose was to interact with the elements, deities, the sky and the star constellations.

Magic can be divided into three main streams. The most ancient stream is the work done with creation. Another stream interacts with the forces, while the most recent stream is based on healing and protection. Our use of it today is mainly connected with this stream. By briefly examining these streams, we can define the following:

Healing magic implies that the healed should connect with their own creating energies. By this we mean their external, energetic structure (including destiny), as well as their internal energetic structure, formed by the eight energies influencing them.

There are many energies forming a human being. We notice those of both parents; a rhythmic energy that relates to a given type of a person. Further there is the energy of space, where this essence is trying to continue or find its existence on the earth. Another energy is the one of time, entering people according to the conditions of their conception, mainly connected with the earth.

The second direction of magic is the work done with the eight external and eight internal forces, which define the conditions of earthly existence.

The third stream, defined as the earliest and most ancient form, is the work done using the principles of redistribution of the 64 forces described in the *I-Jing*.

We will look at the main points in these principles, according to the example of the school of the «Four elements». These are based on the movement of the sky, which forms ten energetic qualities, described as «ten celestial stems» (*Tian Gan*), forming the way.

Ten Celestial Steams

south
Fire
4 Ding Bing 3

1 Jia
east
Wood
2 Yi

Wu 5
center
Soil
Ji 6

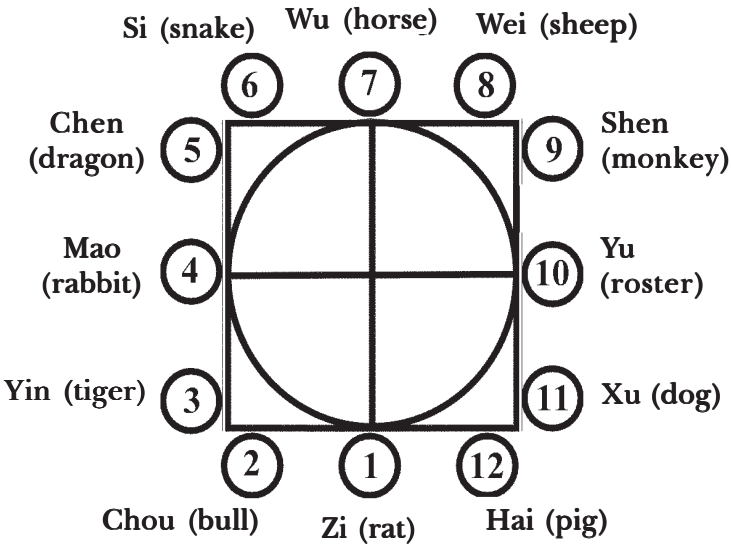
Xing 8
west
Metal
Ceng 7

7 Ren Gui 10
north
Water

Jia (hard wood) and *Yi* (soft wood; *Bing* (the fire of the sun) and *Ding* (the fire in the stove); *Wu* (mountain, earth and hills) and *Ji* (soil); *Geng* (ore and stones) and *Xin* (processed metal); *Ren* (sea water) and *Gui* (freshwater).

These points are also based on the movement of the earth, creating the four directions. Each one of the directions containing three qualities or three knots of the power, reflected in the notion of twelve earthly branches (*Di Zhi*).

Twelve Terrestrial Branches



Each knot defines a certain energetic quality, relating to specific animals which characterise the given energy. These are, the rat, bull, tiger, rabbit, dragon, snake, horse, sheep, monkey, rooster, dog and the pig. Each knot defines the density of the earth's energy, which changes during the course of each month, several months and the year.

The full cycle is defined by the interaction of the nine heavenly pillars and the twelve earthly branches, with Yin-Yang being the circle of creation. 120 years is necessary for the transformation of the 64 forces created by this internal/external cycle, i.e. 59 years for Yin and 60 years for Yang. It is considered that 120 years are required to completely transform the energies.

In magical Taoism each sector of the sky symbolises a specific spirit. Their names vary according to the place and the magician. However, all these spirits are subjected to lunar energy, forming 28 constellations, or 28 spirit houses. The seven changes of the moon, in the four sectors of the sky define the energy of these constellations. Here we find the incongruity between western and eastern astrology. It is not our task here to unravel this incongruity, particularly as a great deal of this knowledge is beyond rational thinking.

It is important for us to understand the conditions that define magic, it's knowledge and it's connection with yin energy. We have the four sectors of the sky connected with the 'twelve terrestrial branches', by means of the 'ten celestial steams'.

This is a relative connection, as the celestial steams also have their own cycle, the rotation circle defined by the Great Bear (Ursa Major). To simplify things, we will use this connection as our basis to understand the magical energy component formed by the magician.

The magician works with the rhythm of 120 hours, or five, twenty four hour periods. At this point they must do something with the energy, otherwise it will dissipate. Five day weeks are also connected with this concept, in as much as it takes five days to collect the alchemical pill and forty eight hours to absorb and realise it.

The twenty eight lunar movements form four transformations, or four forces: the Red Bird situated in the south; the Black Turtle situated in the north; the White Tiger situated in the west, and the Green Dragon situated in the east. In magic these images were not often used, only in Taoist alchemy, although it must be remembered that these two spheres of knowledge can only be divided in relative

Terrestial branches		Celestial Stems									
		1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
		Jia	Yi	Bing	Ding	Wu	Ji	Geng	Sin	Ren	Gui
		60-turn cycle									
1	Zi	1		13		25		37		49	
2	Chou		2		14		26		38		50
3	Yin	51		3		15		27		39	
4	Mao		52		4		16		28		40
5	Chen	41		53		5		17		29	
6	Si		42		54		6		18		30
7	Wu	31		43		55		7		19	
8	Wei		32		44		56		8		20
9	Shen	21		33		45		57		9	
10	Yu		22		34		46		58		10
11	Xu	11		23		35		47		59	
12	Hai		12		24		36		48		60

terms. The colour was used most widely, usually like the following: Red Dragon – south. Black Dragon – north. White Dragon – west and Green Dragon – east.

It is interesting to note that in connection with the centre (Yellow Dragon), these five major elements related to five emperors: *Fu Xu*, *Shen Nong*, *Huang Di*, *Shao Hao* and *Huang Xi.* Each emperor corresponded to a dragon of a certain colour. This was also an indication of the connection between the sky and the earth by means of the forming yang energy (dragon). Taoists saw the inter-relationship between all things and defined this in such a way as to enable them to develop their own energy.

The movement of the energy is like a spiral, resembling the shape of a snake, which is why the dragon is the most frequent allegory in Taoism. It represents the highest point of energy manifestation, being that which has developed, transformed and flown up. In magic each movement defining earthly connections, were related to the Yellow Dragon or the lymph, and the Red Dragon or the blood. The lymph take five days to increase the energy, while the blood takes eight days. Then it is either transformed, or it dissipates.

Let us return to the concept of magical Taoism. The laws upon which it is based are complicated and diverse. Nevertheless, they all come together on one point; the realisation and search for immortality. These sects can be divided according to five primal elements:

1. Sects which developed to follow the laws of heaven.

They use the elements of fire as part of their practices. Their major characteristics relate to heaven, the forces of heaven and the deities.

2. Sects using movement as part of their practices. This includes dances and dynamic practices. Their knowledge corresponds to the Major Bear and Polar Star. It also corresponds to the water element. Similar sects exist even today and are located around the Omei and Wudang mountains. The art of *Bagua Zhang* began its development within the framework of these schools.

3. Sects correlating with the metal element

These were mainly situated in the western provinces of China. They mainly used incantations, mantras, chanting and communication with spirits.

4. Sects correlating with the wood element

These were mainly connected with healing through the use of plants and various drug substances. They also were involved in the preparation of the alchemical pill.

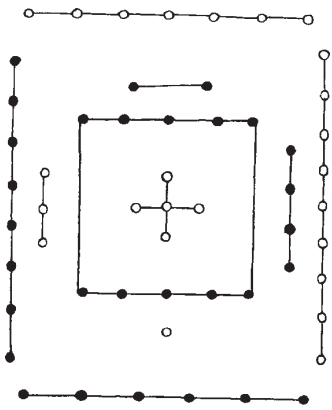
5. Sects correlating with the earth's element

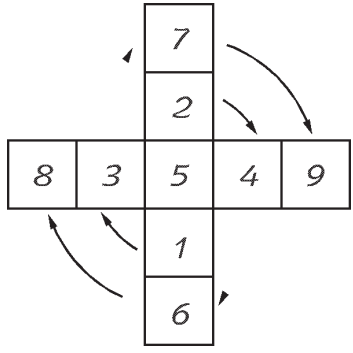
These are the most characteristic of magic. They are known mainly as black magicians. Their knowledge was based on the earth, and earthly powers. They were connected with the most unscrupulous actions, that seemed wild and devil-like to the uninitiated. It is from this stream of Taoism that knowledge concerning the brain was introduced to activate longevity and protection from unwanted occurrences. The main tools of this stream were objects of the earth, especially, stones, minerals, as well as the poisons of spiders, snakes, scorpions etc. Poisons were used to alter energetic states, thus influencing the processes of the brain. One of these sects, known as

Mao Shan Shang Qing, was founded by a woman known as *Wei Hua Zong*. It was very well known in the beginning of our millennium. This sect used strong drugs within their practices. Many sects lived in mountain places, utilising the power of the mountain and it "s spirit for their magic, but there was always one dominant element used as the main force of the particular sect or magician.

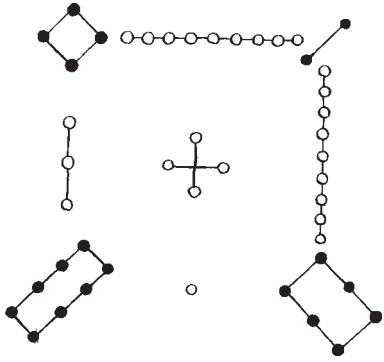
Today, magical Taoism is practised mainly in Taiwan and to a lesser degree in Hong Kong and China. The knowledge coming from the study of various sects, has deeply infiltrated all spheres of life in the east. For example, the magical schemes of *He Tu* and *Lo Shu*, were the basis of various arts, ranging from martial, to the expressive arts.

The scheme of *He Tu*





The scheme of Lo Shu



4	9	2
3	5	7
8	1	6

Magical Steps

Ritual, created by Taoist mediums, is a part of the basis of *Ho Tu*, a magical dance (not to be confused with *He Tu*). It connected the blood with the spirit, using rhythm, and it correlated with *Zhen*, the trigram of thunder. It was the point of connection between the real and the unreal.

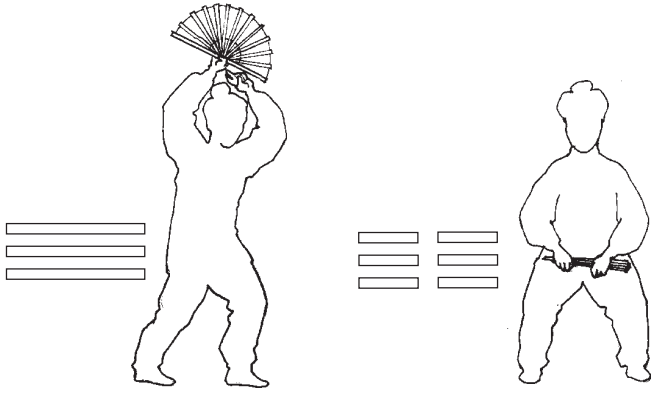
This was the dance with stones, subjected to lightning, and manifesting the connection between the forces of nature and the force of the magician. The steps were used to connect the blood with the *Wu* force (or magical power), and the stones were used to control the visions, by not allowing any unwanted energies to create distractions. These steps were particularly necessary for women to reconnect with their yin energies in order to form the basis for their power.

Later on the movements of this dance were related to another dance known as the «heavenly steps», which became the basis for

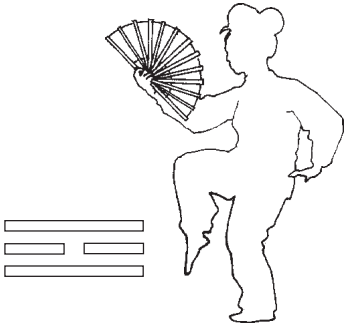
many Taoist rituals. *Bagua* forms, using weapons, were created from these. The magician's weapons were always connected with the five primal elements he used for his magical tasks. Now though it is difficult to define what they used as primal weapons: self protection devices, weapons of war and uprising, tools to connect with spirits, protection from them, and realisation of their own energetic powers.

Female magicians used rice paper as both a tool and a weapon. They used it to subjugate the wind. It was considered that women worked better with wind energy then men did. Wind techniques were further developed by the Taoists, with the basis of their work being precisely the ritual of Eight scoops, that grab the wind.

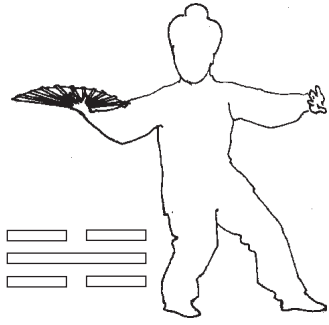
Eight scoops that grab the wind



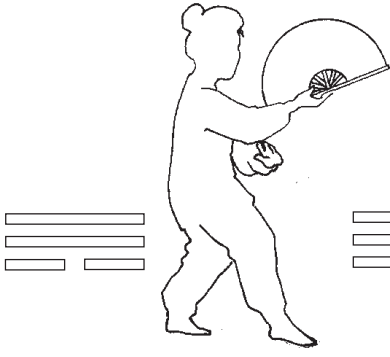
The scoop *Qian* **The scoop *Kun***



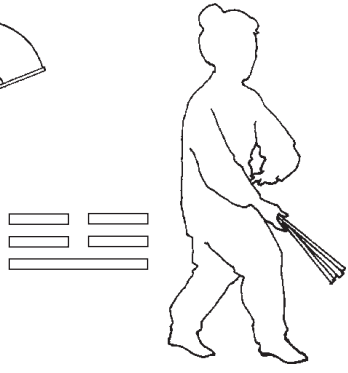
The scoop *Li*



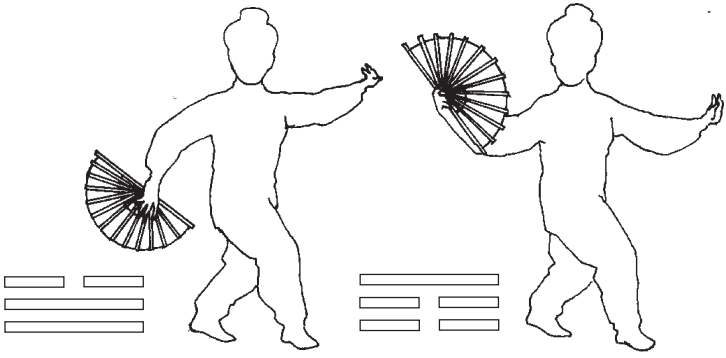
The scoop *Kan*



The scoop *Sun*



The scoop *Zhen*



The scoop *Dui* **The scoop *Gen***

The technique of 'Eight Scoops Grabbing the Wind' was also connected with another, 'The Stone Hit by Lightning'. However, it was used in this way not to control visions, but to increase the karmic force. As it is the female karmic forces that are connected to a certain energy, which is easier to align with, through the use of wind energies.

Stones were strung together in the form of beads or necklaces and were worn around the neck. Either 5, 13 or 24 stones were used in a necklace. The movements during the practice of "eight scoops" were designed to connect the energy of the elements with the gates. The gates being representative of the gates of life's exit (Ursa Major). Six spirits formed the wind's energy, and with their help practitioners could interact with the wind.

In the Taoist pantheon, these spirits were represented in a human form that possessed a specific energetic type.

1. *Qia Zu*

Who governs the sound of the wind. He is represented with two horns, yellow hair, a beard and is richly dressed. He governs demons by means of a bow, a sword and an iron. He lives in the mountains, owns twelve forces and holds up the sky.

2. *Qia Xi*

He has a spiral-like, twisted body. He is often represented in a snake form. A golden crown and spear are his signs of distinction. He is connected with the earth, water and stones, and owns nine forces.

3. *Qia Shen*

A severe woman warrior. She owns the power of the nine heavenly pillars. Her clothes are rich and she wears a gown, sandals and a belt. She owns a flying sword.

4. *Qia Wu*

She is a beautiful women who owns eight forces. Her hair is gathered in a bundle at the back, and her clothes are made of silver. She rides a horse and owns a double handled sword.

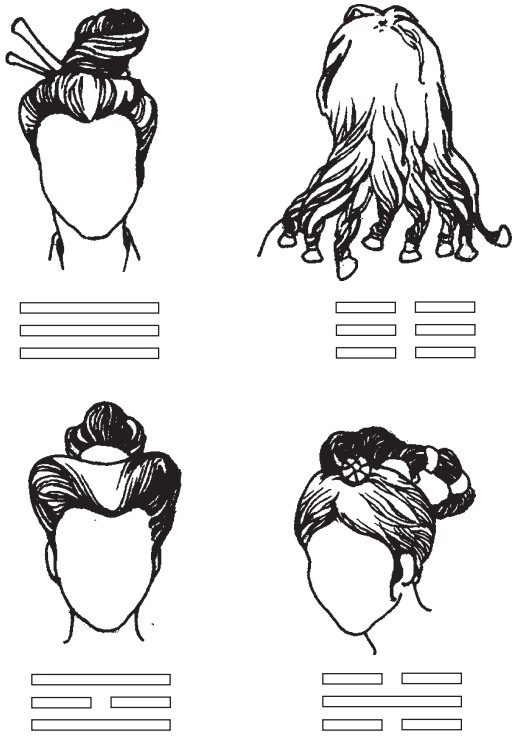
5. *Qia Chen*

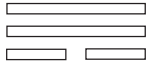
Like *Qia zu, Qia Chen* owns twelve forces, connected with the twelve earthly branches. Portrayed as a warrior, owning a halberd, and lives in mountains and villages.

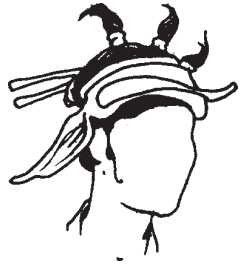
6. *Qia Yen*

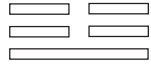
He is connected with animal forces, most frequently with the leopard. He lives in the same place as the wind and owns all metal weapons.

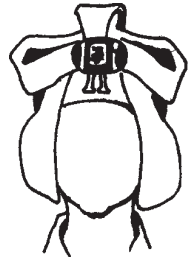
Women were also skilled in the magic of every day living, and of clothes. Some most interesting work was done with hair. This enabled them not only to create and contain the necessary qualities of energy, but also served as a protection against evil spirits and destructive *xie qi* energy. The hairstyle served to hold various objects such as charms, or various weapons including small metal objects.

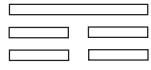












Magic and shamanism were an integral part of life in ancient China. The ability to further form the systems of knowledge depended on those, who kept these traditions alive, those for whom it was a real way of life, based on the interaction between the energies and the world around them. A female shaman could use everything that surrounded her in her work with the energetic forces. The rituals, which later became techniques, were often personalised as they depended on the magicians strength and energetic quality.

As a rule, women not only worked with these energies, but also contained them. One of the most important female properties in those times, was the ability to intertwine the energies of everything they worked with, and to preserve it.

Today we are unable to understand magical Taoism from the viewpoint of our ancestors, but the qualities of preservation and intertwining are ingrained in us, and are a part of our fundamental movement.

Dictionary of Chinese Terms

Ba Gua Zhang
'The Palm of Eight Trigrams', the one of three inner styles of martial arts.
Chang E
– the goddess of the Moon
Di Zhi
– The Twelve Terrestrial Branches, the twelve energetic qualities formed by the earth *(Zi, Chou, Yin, Mao, Chen, Wu, Wei, Shen, Yu, Xu, Hai).*
Dou He
– The Pole Star, corresponds to the concept of the Macrocosmic level of the *Supreme Centre* and transformation.
Dou Yi
– the energetic centre of the Earth, which creates the foundation for everything.
Du Mai
– the Governing Vessel or the Middle Front meridian.
Fa Jing
– the directed energy, which also means 'the totally controlled energy emission'.
Feng Shui
– 'Wind and water', Chinese geomancy
Fu Xi, Shen Nong, Huang Di, Shao Hao, Huang Xi
– the five emperors which correspond to five elements, five colours or five dragons.
He Tu, Luo Shu
– two magical diagrams which were used by Taoist shamans. *He To -*

the scheme which was on the dragon№s back from the He river. *Lo Shu* - the scheme which was on the turtle's back from the Lo river.

Ho Tu

– magical dance, the ritual created by Taoist shamans

Hou Tian Qi

– Post-heaven (or Postnatal) Energy

Hun spirits

– the three rational spirits which are connected with our conscious states.

Huo Qi

– the *Qi* of fire, which in our body corresponds to the Postnatal *Qi.*

I Jing

– 'The Book of Changes', Chines oldest treatise about the eight forms of phenomena and their transformation.

Jing

– one of the 'Three Treasures' - Essence, refined, subtle energy.

Gua He

– the 'crane' position, specific posture for meditative practice for women.

Mao Shan Shang Qing

– the magical sect well known in the beginning of 2nd millennium in China, was founded by the shamaness *Wei Hua Zong*

Nei Zhong

– the inner power or the inner strength.

Ni Wang Gong

– the alchemical centre in the head.

Peng, Lu, An, Ji, Lieh, Tsai, Chou, Kao

– 'The Eight Forces' which manifest everywhere (correspond to Eight

Trigrams).

Po spirits

– The seven irrational spirits which are connected with all uncontrolled functions of our body, and also uncontrolled states and emotions.

Qi

– one of the 'Three Treasures' - Energy, which circulates in the body.

Qia Zu, Qia Xi, Qia Shen, Qia Wu, Qia Chen, Qia Yen - the six spirits forming the wind's energy.

Qian (sky), *Kun* (earth), *Li* (fire), *Kan* (water), *Sun* (wind), *Zhen* (thunder), *Dui* (lake), *Gen* (mountain)

– 'Eight Trigrams' or 'Eight forms of phenomena', see 'I Jing'('Book of Changes') , also correspond to 'Eight scoops that grab the wind'.

Ren Mai

– the Conception Vessel or the Middle Back meridian.

Shen

– one of the 'Three Treasures' – Spirit, high level, fine energy.

Shen Tan

– 'Dwelling Place of the Spirit'

Shi, Wu

– magical persons. *Shi* refers to men, *Wu* refers to women.

Shu

– female magician, shaman

Shui Qi

– the *Qi* of water, which in our body corresponds to the Prenatal *Qi.*

Tai Ji Quan

– 'The Fist of the Supreme Ultimate' one of the three inner styles of martial arts.

Tao Yin (Dao Yin)

– 'The Art of Five Orbits', one of the parts of Taoist Yoga, the system of working with five organs.

Tian Gan

– 'The Ten Celestial Stems', ten energetic qualities formed by the sky *(Jia, Yi, Bing, Ding, Wu, Ji, Geng, Xin, Ren, Gui).*

Tian Pan

– the 'lotus' position, a posture for meditation.

Wu Ji

– the concept of 'No Extremity' or boundlessness.

Xian Tian Qi

– Pre-heaven (or Prenatal) Energy

Xiao Zhou Tian

– 'The Minor Heavenly Cycle' or 'The Microcosmic Orbit', a special alchemical practice creating the circulation of *Qi* in the Middle Back and Middle Front meridians.

Xie Qi

– harmful energy.

Xing Yi Quan

– 'The Fist of the Directed Mind' the one of three inner styles of martial art.

Yang

– The active, positive, external, male principle, 'Something that moves and develops'.

Yijin Jing

– 'The Treatise about Changing the Muscles and Tendons for the Weak', the art of working with muscles and tendons for women.

Yin

– The passive, negative, internal, female principle, 'the Something that forms and creates a foundation'.

Yin Jiao Mai

– the meridian which 'moves the Yin energy'.

Yuan Jing

– Original *Jing,* a fundamental substance inherited from parents.

Yuan Qi

– Original *Qi,* formed by Original *Jing*

Zang Fu Organs

- the dense (yin) organs and hollow (yang) organs

Zhi She, Yi She

- 'House of Will' and 'House of Mind'

OLEG TCHERNE
ELENA LAZARO

TAOIST YOGA FOR WOMEN

The Taoist Yoga teaching or Taoist Alchemy has roots before legendary Emperor *Huang Di* and *Lao Tzu*, who are generally credited as the founders of Taoism.

Male and female Shamans contemplated Sky and Earth, listened to animals and birds, searched for the truth inside themselves to understand the uniform Laws of Being. Their wisdom and knowledge created the foundation of broad system Taoism. The Inner alchemy was a part of it. The special method of Taoist teaching for women, *Yin methodology* or *Female Alchemy* starts its formation from *3rd* century AD.

This teaching focused on the theories and practices of female internal development and spiritual refinement. Yin methodology was used as the preparatory work for alchemical transformation. This preparatory work involves balancing the circulation of energies within the meridians and internal organs and refining of the energy accordingly to female energy peculiarities.

Preparation exercises for Microcosmic orbit, Tao Yin technique, practice with the feet are some of several parts of Taoist Yoga for women and are related to most important aspects of female work with energy.

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